The Code Of Cadmus

Avoid conformity to keep your soul.

Tasos Valtinos

2025

不易流行

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We are our truest self when our honestly selected words echo
louder than the lies that would have kept us safer.
For millennials.
I really hope you read every sentence.

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Introduction

Who am I? Why did I write this book for you? What is this book about?

Who am I?

Hello World!

We live in a proof-based system, therefore before I dig any deeper into all the things I want to talk to you about, first I need to tell you my story and who I am. I don't aim to surprise you, impress you, shock you or anything like that. I just want to share my story with you and who knows, you might feel a bit closer to me, or you may resonate with it.

Let's begin.

My name is Tasos.

I never really liked the sound of my first name, but like most of us out there I suppose, I didn't really have a say in it. I should admit though that I like how my last name sounds. It makes me feel good about myself when I hear it. I don't know why, it just does. You can see that just from someone's name, two opposing thoughts try to balance each other out. And then we wonder why the world is so complicated.
Tasos is a shortcut of my full name: *Anastasios*. Which in ancient Greek is derived from a word that means resurrection. I promise you though, up to this day, I haven't come back from the dead just yet.

Due to the complexity of the world, and the fact that some of us are more privileged than others, I won't be labelling my past as good, bad, soft, harsh or anything like that. I will use the word **'weird'** to describe situations that I have seen, been through and experienced in my life. I will leave it up to you to define the nature of those experiences, through your own lens.

You have probably guessed it by now, that I am originally from Greece. Athens to be precise. I grew up in the west suburbs of Athens, where all sorts of *weird* things happen, all the time. From early childhood, through secondary school, through high school and then through university. Weirdness, all day long. Where should I start? From *"I love you"* to *"who gives a fuck"*. From having zero money to temporary omnipotence feelings. From all

kinds of drugs to doing pushups in the park. From sweaty sex in cars in abandoned parking spots to avoiding phone calls from your parents. From smoking a strong pack of Lucky Strike to chewing a gum before you meet your parents so they won't smell the smoke. From deadly motorbike accidents to *"let's have one more drink, it won't hurt us"*. From *"if you don't fight you are a pussy"* to *"please don't tell my parents about it"*. I tell you, childhood and early adulthood in Greece has it all.

The first two decades of my life I spent them in Greece. In the last years of the second decade, a few more weird things happened to me, which we might talk about later in this book. One important thing you need to know about me is that ever since I was a kid, I had this feeling in me that I wanted to see the world. I wanted to see everything. I remember going to bed, checking the time, closing my eyes, and imagining what another family, in another country, in another time zone, might be doing at that exact moment. I was using images from movies I was seeing and it made everything way more fun. I left Greece when I was 21 years old, and I still cannot answer you the following question: Did I leave because of that childhood feeling of intense curiosity about the world or because of all the weirdness happening to me? Maybe it's both. Who knows.

It was August 2016 when I left for the first time. I went to Brighton, England. A backpack, a suitcase, and 2,500 euros wrapped inside a piece of kitchen foil, handed to me by my mother so I'd have enough to get by until I get paid from my job. The job was a data related one, paying 800 pounds a month. The most boring job I have ever done in my life. I was terrible at it. I stayed in Brighton for 7 months, consumed half the alcohol of the city, smoked Chesterfield red, made some good friends, got infected by bed bugs and of course, saw more weird things. That's what I loved about moving and travelling, it was weirdness, ALL DAY LONG.
Then like every little prick out there trying to hustle his way up, I made the move. London, here we come!

London. London. London. Even the name of that city does something to me. It holds a special place in my heart. I went there as a very young man and the city toughened me up in many ways—ways that were different from how my own city, Athens, had already

hardened me. Cause trust me, if Athens does something really well, it is toughening you up. In London, the word 'many' fits perfectly well in most of my experiences.
I lived in many flats, with many people taking many drugs, with many rats, many bottles of alcohol and of course, seeing many more weird things. I was never really into drugs, for reasons we will discuss later, but in London almost everyone is. Thus, if everyone is on alcohol or drugs most of the time, how do you expect a city to not be….interesting?

London was full of lessons for me. I learned what is bad for me, what is good for me, where my limits are, what I'm comfortable doing, and what I am not. I will use the same technique I used to describe my own city, Athens, because London feels like another home to me.
Let's do it.
London was full of polarizations.
From bank account balances hovering near zero to feeling like kings in Shoreditch.
From catching rats in the kitchen with flatmates to wearing Calvin Klein clothes in art exhibition parties. From cocaine on the sink with Russians on a Friday to let's run 10k on a Saturday because health is everything, right? From having a million beers on a casual Tuesday to Powerpoint presentations in corporate buildings on a Wednesday morning.
From roadmen riding bicycles in East London, to fancy restaurants in Kensington.
London has it all. They say that the Devil could not make hell beautiful. That's why he made London so beautiful, because it is the fastest way to hell. I confirm the validity of the quote.

There is no point in explaining every single trip I have done or every experience I had during all those years. That would require a couple of books. But as many digital nomads do, I have also travelled quite a bit. I have been to Central America, almost everywhere in Europe, I have been in Africa, Asia & South East Asia. Travelling the world is a wonderful experience in general, I definitely recommend it. It will open your mind, teach you stuff about yourself you never knew, but trust me, it won't solve your problems. But I am getting ahead of myself. We are still in the introduction part.

After London I moved to Barcelona, Spain.
Funny story— it is my last day in Barcelona as I'm writing this exact sentence, sitting at a coffee shop right next to my place.

I have been in this city for 3 and a half years, and I am really excited about the next chapter of my life. Looking back, my time in Barcelona has been the most transformative period of my life. I have changed a lot. A LOT. I feel more mature now, more grounded and with more clarity.

Barcelona deserves its own paragraph, of course.

I love Barcelona. I lived here during Covid but left early 2021, and came back again late August 2023. For this city, I will not use the same technique I used to present to you what Athens and London meant to me.Not because it does not feel like home to me, but because the last 2 years of my life were not about what I was doing, but what I was reflecting on.

In Barcelona I started doing therapy more intensively. Both self-therapy, through a lot of research, reading and a lot of mental effort but also with the help of doctors. I had long been aware of the things I was carrying with me from my past. But during these years in Barcelona, I came to realize that they no longer served me—that they were no longer part of who I am. But more on that later. My time in the city was full of music, jam sessions, writing, building apps, investing, making and losing half a million dollars, creating interesting relationships and filled with motorbike trips (I even went from Barcelona to Athens with my motorbike - funny story that one).
To be completely honest with you, the last 2 years feel like 2 decades.
I guess that's a good thing.

And now…I'm moving again.

From the outside, it might seem exhausting, exciting, living the dream or what is this weirdo doing with his life? I don't know, everyone has their own opinions. But as *Beau Lotto* put it in his book *Deviate*: From the *inside* it seems like the next logical step.

Oh, by the way…

I know I still haven't said what I do for a living and how I pay the fucking bills. So, let me give you a bit more context.

It always bores me to death when I have to talk about 'work' or when people ask me *"what do you do for a living"*. Or when I have to do any type of chitchat to be honest with you. But before I end my introduction, I think it would be useful to tell you what I have been doing all these years to be able to pay for stuff. Not to put a label, not to play status games or to prove anything. Just to give you a bit of context. I know we should not judge anyone from his or her job or status, but let's face it. In this life it is not about what you say, but what you do. And when I say 'do' I mean any type of action not just work.

So…

I have a degree in Economics & Finance, but most of the things I know about economics & finance, I learned from non academic books, loads of Youtube videos and business failures. In general, I code stuff. Databases, web apps, backend systems, frontend interfaces, smart contracts on blockchain networks and AI-based tools. I also invest like my life depends on it, because it kind of does.
As an entrepreneur I have built many apps but till this day, none of them changed the world or made me rich. Maybe what the world actually needs is not another app nor another rich Greek. For the last couple of years I was part of a cryptocurrency business, running it as CTO. I worked for big companies in the past as an employee too, but not since 2021. A few of those companies fired me, and honestly, I've never been good at a 9 to 5 job. I like doing my own things. I'm deeply interested in technology, philosophy, psychology, science, music, art, and human nature. And right now I'm writing this book.

I think this should be enough to give you an idea about who I am and what I do.

Oh, and as you will see for yourself in this book, I think too much.

Why am I writing this book?

Before I answer why, I need to back my answer with a statement. In the last 6 years I have changed a lot. If you ask people close to me, they might tell you that I'm a completely different person. I used to be very distant from people, anti-social, cold, and I

would never ask anybody's help or anybody's opinion. I would fight every battle, and I would put all of my mental effort to correct people, convince people, explain things to people, and above all, make sure that everyone sees me as the smartest and most independent person in the room. But all that was just copying mechanisms mostly. I would not commit emotionally, never show any kind of weakness or emotion and always be like '*it is me against the world*'.
This way of living life, of course, is the definition of living life wrong haha! This way of being did not serve me anymore. Therefore, I had to change. And as I am going to explain to you in this book, I did change my way of being.

Thus, as you can imagine, with all these changes happening, writing this book was inevitable. It has been a few years since I wanted to, but only recently, I felt a real urge to write it. Let me tell you a bit more about that urge.

In 2025 alone, I have done a lot of things. One of them was building and launching 4 apps. Crypto and AI related apps. I am not saying this to brag or anything, but instead to tell you that none of those apps, nor the process of building them, gave me any satisfaction. But I built them anyway.
I also came across a new technology this year that got me genuinely excited. I became obsessed with it, and I started building and experimenting endlessly. But once again, it all started to feel irrelevant—as if I wasn't doing what I was truly meant to do. Then one day, I woke up and I just knew. I just felt it in me that this is the time to write my book. So, I literally ditched everything, and started writing.

I don't know if what you're about to read in this book truly reflects who I am, who I've been, or who I'll become. But here's how I see it: this book is the little voice in my head—speaking up about what it has observed so far, what it thinks about the future, and what it believes we should do in the years ahead. That's it.

So, you might be asking, can you finally tell us ***why you wrote it***, dude?

Here is the real WHY.
Because of me. Because of you. Because Ernest *Becker's* book *Denial Of Death* gave me stress and I feel like I need to leave something behind if tomorrow I get hit by a bus.

Which is, by the way, a sentence that a manager I had back in London actually told me one day when I arrived late at the office. *'You might get hit by a bus one day coming to work, but we still need your scripts to not crash Tasos'*. Pfff, shut up man!
They put me in a Performance Improvement Plan because they felt like *'I didn't care much'*.
Which of course I didn't.
Fuck'em.
I quit the next day.

Now back to our topic.

The main reason why I am writing this book is because I think I have a lot to say. Maybe it is also from my unfulfilled desire to be seen by others. This world is so hard to navigate, and the more weird stuff I saw out there, the more I felt the urge to write it. As I said, it's been a while since I wanted to do it. I guess now I have the maturity, the clarity, the time and the motivation to do it.

FYI — this is not another self-help book. I will not tell you to wake up at 5am, take a cold shower, meditate, journal, say thank you for what you have and plan your daily tasks in advance. I also won't tell you to take huge risks, build that brand or that business and BOOM you will make it in life.
Fuck all that.
That approach does not work.
Nonetheless, if you have done some of these things then you know that they ain't that bad. I have done some of them too.

But let's not deviate from our main topic.

As I mentioned earlier, I don't know much. I don't know if this world will get any better, if AI will save or steal your job. If crypto is the solution or if it will make you rich. And I certainly don't know if being rich is even what you need in the first place.
I don't know if you should drink alcohol or not, take drugs or not, travel or not, love or not (actually you should love) or if this dream of continuous happiness will ever happen to you. I'm not a guru. Nobody is. **We are all just pretending that we have our shit together simply because accepting that we don't has become unbearable.**

That's why I am writing this book.

To simply show you that another human being, similar to you, has things to say and is not perfect. That another human being has seen weird things, cold things, warm things and has some ideas on how to navigate this world for the next couple of decades. That's it.

And if I could wish for one thing, when it comes to this book, I really wish that:

- You learn something from it
- You love something about it
- You hate something about it

Because what is life if not an absurd thirst for knowledge and a heavy addiction to uncontrollable emotions. Right?

Let's begin.

Part I:

Concepts & Definitions

Chapter 1:
Why Cadmus?

Who the fuck is **Cadmus** you may ask? And what is his code about?

Patience my friend.

Cadmus was a hero in an ancient Greek myth. And in this book, we will use the myth as a reference in order to define what a life that is truly worth living is all about.

But before we do that, let's explain a few things. What is this myth about you may ask?

In a nutshell, a Phoenician prince named ***Cadmus*** was sent by his father on a journey to find his sister, Europa, who was abducted by the god Zeus. The myth says that Zeus was transformed into a white bull and abducted the beautiful Europa, and took her to the island of Crete. There, he revealed his true form to her and they became lovers. Cadmus was sent to find his sister, but he did not manage to find her. He then consulted the Oracle, which told him to continue his journey and not stop just because he did not fulfil his father's request and then, he ended up in Greece. Along the way, he killed a dragon, he planted the dragon's tooth to the ground as a seed, raised an army, started a country from scratch and he brought civilization and the alphabet to the wild land of Greece.

Probably that's the shortest version of the myth you have ever read. I know. But you get the idea.

I personally love that myth. Like most Greek mythology, it has courage, wisdom, love, hate, blood, drama and in a very direct way, it reflects the human nature of the Gods. With reference to this myth, I want to talk about some important virtues that I think are necessary in today's world and are often overlooked. Virtues that I believe if we don't

have them embedded into our cores, we will have a hard time walking on earth in 2025 and beyond. Even if the whole society praises us for **not having those virtues.** Even if we gain fame, status, or money without having those virtues, the absence of them will eventually lead to our own destruction—slowly, and in a very painful way, once the cameras are gone.

So what are these virtues I am talking about? Of course, I could not name and explain all of them in just one book. Therefore, I will mention the ones that I think of as the most crucial, and of course, you are allowed to do as you please. Add yours on top, remove some of mine or even twist their meanings a bit. Everything is in flux, always. Do as you wish.

The virtues we will discuss are: *courage, honesty, wisdom, empathy, compassion & ataraxia.*

These virtues sound classical, old and heavy, simply because they are. Don't worry, I will not explain everything from an ancient times perspective, when they used to kill each other, drink wine all day, fuck all day, and had 15 hours a day to think. I will not tell you that Stoicism is the answer to all of your problems, to let go, build discipline and avoid lust at all costs. Those things are indeed useful, however they ***didn't have social media back then*** — haha! They didn't take loans to buy cars and Gucci bags. They starved to death and went to war, they didn't spend 2 hours trying to edit a social media post so the *'algorithm'* makes it viral. They didn't have a million different types of drugs to pick from. They didn't dance foolishly on camera to share it on TikTok. Because if they did, you and I probably wouldn't be here right now. I guess optionality is both a blessing and a curse.

For that exact reason, I will explain each virtue, from my own perspective, and what I believe each virtue means in 2025 and for the years to come.

Let's dive into every single one of them.

Courage in 2025 and beyond

Thousands of years ago, you would grab a spear or a sword, go conquer a couple of countries or kill a lion (please don't kill lions, they are my mantra) and that would be it.

Hero status achieved. Your name would echo across eternity and everyone would remember you forever. Now it is not that simple (hope you get the sarcasm in my words). For me, in today's world, courage means one and one thing only: **Do Everything In Your Power To Keep Your Attention Safe.**

In today's world, we are not fighting dragons, wild beasts or armies of thousands of warriors. Today we fight for our attention when every single legal entity is aiming to take it away from us. Media, Big Tech, Big Corporations, you name it. If you want to be courageous today, you don't have to fight 1,000 men, or kill a lion. No.

All you have to do is ***turn off your notifications.***
Don't binge-scroll on instagram, tiktok or whatever you use.
Don't buy things because some commercial told you that there is a better version of you if you spend 100 dollars more.

That's it. I mean it. That's ***how to be courageous in 2025 and beyond.***

The acquiring of the virtue of *courage* will be initiated the moment you turn notifications off. Everything will be set into motion toward the better version of yourself. If you are familiar with chaos theory or the butterfly effect, you get exactly what I mean.

Now let's move to the next virtue, otherwise this chapter will be way too long, and in 45 mins I will be blocked out of the wifi of the cafeteria I am sitting at. Freaking south of Europe haha!

Honesty in 2025 and beyond

I have been having this obsession for the last 5-6 years, that I need to find a super abstract and simple sentence that describes the whole world and its meaning. I read somewhere (probably a philosophical book or article) that the most intelligent minds in human history explained things in the simplest way possible. Then I thought, ok, I will be the smartest of them all if I find a way to catch the meaning of the whole world in one sentence. Only if life worked that way haha!

I assume by now you see all the red flags in my character. Such a needy and selfish man who wants to be seen as smart all the time. I'm laughing at this need at the moment, I really don't have it anymore — Ok maybe I still have it, just a little bit haha! — but 5-6 years ago it used to be a huge problem. Which is when this obsession of discovering such an abstract sentence started.

Unfortunately, I haven't found a single sentence that describes the world and catches its meaning. However I tell you this, the one that comes really close to describing today's world is this:

"In one way or another, everyone is lying."

I will not go into more details why I believe in such a quote. If you know, you know. Use your own lens to either agree with it or reject it. The point is, in a world where almost everyone is lying in one way or another—including myself—***honesty*** has become a rare and powerful virtue. In a world that praises fake productivity, and in a world where everyone on social media seems hotter, smarter, richer and in general *'more'* than you, **being honest is a superpower.** Speak your truth, share your feelings, share your views, don't just take at face value what others say to you.

Lying takes many forms. I'm not just talking about the obvious, heavy kind—lying to hurt someone, manipulate them, or avoid jail. I'm talking about the everyday lies we tell to make our lives easier. The small ones. The not-so-big ones. I get it—sometimes, we lie because it's easier, or because some people are better off staying in their own oblivion. But in general, building a life on honesty as a foundation makes everything more real. At the end of the day, if you are honest, when you go to bed at night, you will feel lighter. You will feel better knowing that for the most part of your day, you were truly yourself. Wouldn't that mean something to you?

But be careful, do not always be brutally honest. Do not hurt others just to prove a point. Don't try to be right. Admit it when you are wrong. Don't be scared of making mistakes. That's when wisdom, empathy and compassion come in.

Wisdom in 2025 and beyond

Wisdom. If you ask every philosopher about what wisdom is, they will give you a different answer. I'm not a philosopher, so I will tell you my idea of wisdom and you can take it however you like.

I definitely don't mean that wisdom is about wearing a long and dirty cloak, eating grapes by the patio and asking yourself what life is all about. That would be an interesting thing to do in 2025 for sure, but let's face it—we don't have time or energy for this. And I won't even start about how hard it is to find a long and dirty cloak. Just search on Amazon and send me the link if you do.

Now…back to the main point.

In this world, the majority ***lives on autopilot,*** without bringing much to the table. People are focused on draining each other's energy through toxic talk, gossip or wearing masks in social gatherings to conform with society and feel that they belong somewhere—by wearing masks in social gatherings I don't mean weird sex parties, haha, I'm referring to social masks. Therefore, a way to differ in such a world is by reading, learning, doubting, and asking yourself and others about stuff. Not for being the *'best version of you'* or *'reaching your full potential'* and all that 21st century motivational shit. But simply to cultivate your curiosity, learn about what's going on, think for yourself and think for others too. Bring something to the fucking table.

If you don't trust me, trust my cousin's quote: "*The unexamined life is not worth living*".

Yeah, Socrates is a distant cousin of mine! Why? You got a problem with that?

PS: Definition of 'Delulu': *'Delulu' is a slang term derived from "delusional" and is often used in online and social media contexts to describe someone who holds unrealistic or overly optimistic beliefs, often about romantic or family relationships or interactions with very well-known people.*

Empathy & Compassion in 2025 and beyond

Probably, these 2 virtues are the most important ones and they should be analyzed together. Let me share something from my own childhood to paint a clearer picture. During my teenage years, one of my friends in our group was not as tall as the rest of us. Everyone used to kind of bug him, bully him in a way about it, and I knew he didn't like it and it affected him a lot. I never teased him about that. At least I don't recall it. I'm not pretending to be a saint here, far from it. But when it comes to that particular thing I never did. Unfortunately, I have been a part of 'bullying' and 'being bullied' in one way or another in my childhood.

That same friend, over time, developed a harsh way of dealing with others. He would judge them, tease them, sometimes pushing things too far and fights would break out or people would get hurt. I suppose it was his way of coping with the teasing he'd endured himself.
And this is ***where it gets interesting and everything starts to connect.***
Throughout most of my childhood and early adulthood, I practiced martial arts. The one thing to know about martial arts is that your weight class defines a lot. Between the ages of 17 and 18, I had to stop training so I could focus on studying for university entrance exams. That one year off, led me to *gain 13 kilograms.* I felt awful about it. It brought up a lot of insecurities.

Where am I going with this you may ask?

When I gained that weight, I *became the one who was getting teased.* Not for fun, at least to me—but real, repeated, sharp comments that would hurt deeply. That's when you realize that bullying can get many forms, it is not always a big masculine dude bullying and bothering smaller kids. I also got comments from ***that friend I mentioned earlier.*** Actually, he was the one teasing me the most. Especially in front of people, which really affected me back then. I never showed it of course, but I promise you it left many scars as a kid. What I am trying to say here is that you never know what is going on in someone's life, in someone's head, in someone's heart. That's why *we should all be careful with what comes out of our mouths.* ***Words affect people.***

That's why we should feel for each other. We should not just open our mouths and throw whatever comes first. In 2025, putting yourself into someone else's shoes, and seeing

things from a different perspective I think is a superpower. Why? Because our words, our behaviors, our actions ***are creating this world.*** My friend produced exactly what he received. After all, life is like math, it is all about *input* and *output*. And maybe my friend's output was even worse than the input. That is why humanity is so chaotic and unpredictable. You cannot treat someone badly, and then expect him or her to do good. I guess this is where real character comes in, but as we will discuss shortly, real character in 2025 is a scarce thing.

Ataraxia — or ataraxy — in 2025 and beyond

Ataraxia, what a word. In Greek, you remove the first letter 'a' from the word, and the whole meaning changes. Becomes the exact opposite. I guess it is a reminder that in life a small change can have great consequences. One more vote can lead to the wrong president, a wrong turn might lead to never coming back. A *"yeah baby let's do it without"* can change lives 9 months later.

In the shortest explanation possible, ataraxia means calmness of the mind. Calmness during turbulent times. Not allowing externalities affect the internal stillness. By the way, speaking of turbulence, as of writing this paragraph I am in an airplane flying from Barcelona to Athens. Did you know that a pregnant woman is not allowed to seat in the Emergency Exit rows during take-off or during landing? I did not. I had to switch spots with the lady sitting behind me. She did not know it either. I felt a bit sad keeping her away from her partner for a few minutes. They were touching each other's shoulders between the seats during take-off. Cute.

Anyways...stop changing the subject Tasos.
Back to ataraxia now.

In 2025, as mentioned earlier, the hardest task possible is not conquering countries, killing beasts or echoing your name to eternity. In today's world, in my humble opinion, one of the hardest tasks possible, if not the hardest, is the following: **A human being sitting on a chair, locked in a room, for an hour, looking at the wall, without a digital device.**
That's our hell today.

Calmness. Sitting still.
Living without stimulation.
That's what ataraxia is all about. Being able to remain calm and ignore all the useless noises of society.
I read about it in a book a few years back, and since then I have been thinking about it a lot. If I remember correctly the book said something like this: The root cause of a man's misery in the 21st century is that he cannot sit on a chair and lock himself in a room for an hour without his phone.

Now, I don't really think it is necessary to explain all the negative effects of social media, you already know all that. But I think that we need to acknowledge an important fact. In the past, some of the most interesting discussions between great thinkers included the opposable thumb and evolution. Now, that freaking thumb is consistently moving upwards and downwards just to load some more **cat memes**. Yeah, I am talking about SCROLLING bitch. How crazy right?

Anyways. I hope you have a clear idea of what ataraxia really means.

But before we end this chapter, let's try to back our argument a bit more.
I mean, what else is there to do?

If you FOMO — *Fear Of Missing Out* — which is something we all do in the era of the self-made millionaires, productivity gurus and 200-million dollars per year athletes, I have good news for you. You don't need to build a billion dollar business. You don't need to change the world. If you actually try it, the world will probably change you more than you change it. You don't have to worry if everyone online seems like they are doing in a day what you haven't done in a decade. As long as you do the following, everything else will fall into place according to your own needs, desires and imagination:
DITCH THE FUCKING PHONE.

Spend some time without it every single day. Stare at the wall, cook, touch some grass, I don't know, jerk off without porn. Or be a Greek. Break a plate, scream 'Ooopa' and dance.

Initially, without digital stimulation, the boredom will make you want to kill yourself. All kinds of weird thoughts will pop up, you know, the ones you have been avoiding for quite some time. But after that, something super interesting will happen, trust me on that one. Go for it, try it out. It will help you a lot.

There is so much noise in this world. And everyone is constantly reacting to it. In this exact world, ***all you have to do is stay calm***. Every time that silence makes you uncomfortable, or FOMO kicks in, don't rush to grab your phone, stay still. I don't know if by doing this you will get ahead in life, or move up in this world or whatever other space-time dimension people use to describe success in our society. But I can guarantee you that you will achieve what 90% of the people are avoiding. You will be comfortable with what is going on in your head. And oh my… in 2025 that's stronger than a bullet-proof vest.

Aaaaand…guess what?

We are done with defining what those 6 virtues look like in 2025.
I guess that's why I chose this name for the book. Because the Code of Cadmus, in my opinion, includes all of them. Being courageous enough to make big moves, build things from scratch, bring your wisdom to the table and share it with others, don't do what everyone else is doing because it is accepted. Have empathy and compassion for others who share this planet with you, who struggle like you and have feelings.

….

So, now what? You may ask.
Why should we care?
Being courageous and wise is cool bro, but they do not pay the bills.

Relax.
We are just getting started.
This whole book aims to explain the how-s, the why-s and the what-s that have led to the wrong assumption, at least in my opinion, that only the things that bring instant

monetary or status related reward are the ones that matter the most. Or the ones that should take all of our attention. *Spoiler alert*: They are not!
Pardon my French, but those things are actually the things that are making us fucking depressed.

Take a deep breath now, and let's continue.

Chapter 2:
What do I mean by *'conformity'*?

Spend some time on Youtube and you will quickly see how everyone is constantly promoting that getting out of your comfort zone is the way to go. Every single youtuber is like *Yeah! Jump from a skyscraper*, or *Go build your dream business,* take risks, go climb Everest, don't be boring, Go feed a tiger, Yeah grrrrrr. In the online world, the idea is simple: *living on the edge is how you reach your full potential.*
Well.. some of these things would be cool to do, definitely, but this is how people miss the point entirely.

Staying inside your comfort zone your whole life is a terrible choice in my opinion. But constantly trying to live on the edge just to prove a point won't do you any good either. So let's set the record straight now.
When I'm talking about conformity—or when I say to avoid it— I don't mean you should throw yourself into chaos every day or push your limits just for the sake of it. Our cute little brains are not built for that. They are made for certainty and their main goal for millennia has been to keep us safe.
Are you starving?
Your brain kicks off the safety mode and says: *you should eat.*
Is this street dangerous?
Your brain goes: *take another route now.*
That's what our brains do — in the simplest explanation possible.
All they care about is keeping us alive. Even if our lives have changed a lot compared to 10,000 years ago, our brains still do similar things, still trigger the *fight* or *flight* mode even if a situation does not require it.

So...what is conformity then you might ask?

I will tell you what it means for me and all the different forms I see it taking.

You know those moments when you go to certain places, especially if you work in an office, and you meet random colleagues in the elevator or in the hallway? You remember when you make small talk, smile, pretend to be interested or act like you are in a good mood even if you are not? Well, that's one form of conformity.

You know those moments when you meet new people—or get introduced to some normies by other normies—and if you *don't* start the conversation with "What do you do?", "Where are you from?", or "What's your name?", they immediately think you're weird, introverted, or antisocial?
That's another way people conform.

You remember those times when you were genuinely excited about something—ready to share it like it's big news—and then you told a family member or a friend, and they responded with doubt or judgment? They said something like, "Why are you doing this?", "Wouldn't it be safer to just stay here?", or "Are you crazy?"
And even though you felt crushed—sad, maybe even angry—you kept it all inside and said nothing. That, too, is a form of conformity.

You know every January when you make a list of new year's resolutions but within a couple of days boredom kicks in, it isn't that exciting anymore or it is just too hard to keep up and you ditch the list? Well, guess what...It's conformity bitch.

And do you recall when you said that you would travel the world, start your own business, work on your own project, learn how to play an instrument or learn a new language but never really end up doing it? You told yourself it's too hard, or you felt like you ain't interested enough, or it was not the right time and you went back to scrolling on your phone? Well, my friend… you know what this is by now.

These, in my opinion, are some of the ways that we conform in this world. If you have read psychology or social behavior related books you might have come across terms like *wearing masks*, *persona, copying mechanisms* etc. All of those terms are real. All of those things

are us, happening to us, and made by us. I just choose to put them under the umbrella of ***'conformity'***. Cause why not? Sue me.

Chances are, you might be having some opposing thoughts or counterarguments to the things I've said so far. You might be thinking, "Dude, we're burned out. We wear masks because this society drains us—40 to 50 hours a week—and we don't have the energy to deal with everything and everyone all the time." And you know what? You're right. I hear you. That's completely valid.

But what if wearing all these masks and conforming all the time, does not serve us anymore? What if it makes our entire life experience feel unbearable? Then what?
Do you ever think about that?

Well let me tell you where I see the irony in all this—and why we should avoid conformity, if not always, then as often as possible.

Every time someone is judging us or when we are about to judge someone else, we are willing to put all of our energy into it, go crazy, and allow all kinds of emotions to come to the surface until we explode. We are ready to do anything in order to be seen and to be heard even if what we have to say or show is not beneficial. Neither to ourselves nor to others. But when it's time to step up, to really take responsibility for our lives, to break the chains, to accept and embrace that we are about to do something good for ourselves (and probably for others) we don't go the extra mile and we don't put the same amount of effort. Isn't that ironic? Or at the very least, paradoxical?

One single thought of *'I am not good enough', 'I don't have what it takes'* or one comment from somebody like *'Are you crazy?'* or *'You can't do this'* are more than enough to stop us from taking action and send us back inside our little cages. Marcus Aurelius mentioned it very well in his *Meditations*. 'Clicks of a tongue' he said. The thing that has the biggest effect on us, simple 'clicks of a tongue', words and opinions of others that if ignored entirely, we would realise that they are nothing more than just that — clicks of a tongue. Movements of muscles that generate sounds that reach our ears and are capable of changing us in the most profound ways possible.

Marcus Aurelius said it from an 'applause' perspective. How praising people can affect them and how people who are using the words to applaud others are affected as well. But I personally think he meant more. Unfortunately I do not know for certain, I did not meet the guy. And if he did not mean more, I don't care.

I MEAN MORE — haha!

What a powerful sentence, right? What a cocky little prick I am.

By the way, this technique of linking yourself to a powerful figure from history and making a statement in order to support a stronger argument is very famous. People and organizations in positions of power use it all the time to manipulate us. Especially through the media. And it is quite simple actually. Just relate yourself to an expert, and repeat something many times over and over again with a strong tone and that's it. You will be positioned as an expert in people's minds when it comes to that particular topic. I mean, if he talks about it so much, he must know something right? Haha, crazy world.

In fact, social media success often boils down to consistently sharing your opinions and aligning yourself with fame or authority figures until people start believing you.
That's it. Repeat it long enough. Relate hard enough. And suddenly—boom—you're an expert. What a wonderfully absurd little shithole of a world we live in, right?
Anyways, I thought it would be a useful thing to share and make sure people know it in 2025.

Ok—Back to our conformity chat.

A few pages back, I said something about living on autopilot.
Living on autopilot is another form of conformity as well. And it hurts the most, because it is the hardest to acknowledge. I have lived like that as well through copying mechanisms and behaviors that kept people in harmony with me while I was negatively affecting my relationship with myself.
What I mean by that is that I would keep relationships going, via frequent communication just to keep people happy. Not because I really wanted, or needed that relationship in any way. But instead, just to avoid confrontation with people when they

asked questions like: *'why are you weird?', 'why don't you talk much?', 'why did you forget about us?', 'why have you changed?'*. I would drain my energy, disturb my inner peace and keep me in negative thinking spirals. And the worst of it? Those relationships were mostly online. Not even physical. Imagine that. Don't worry, I have a whole section in this book related to this topic—which is the biggest 'aha' moment of my life.

You probably know the story of the *Wolf in Sheep's Clothing*. To me, conformity is a bit like that—subtle and sneaky. It can happen without us even noticing and it can happen while we say things like, *"This is just how things have always been,"* or *"This is what everyone else is doing."*. We just accept things and people as they are. And then we realise that the things we do don't serve us anymore, they don't turn us into a better person, and the worst of all, they drain our super precious energy.

That is why avoiding hard things now, will bring harder days later.

When you understand that our brain's main job is to keep us safe and it achieves that by choosing the easy choice and by telling us what we want to hear, then the conformity I am talking about is even easier to understand.

Maybe that relationship does not serve you anymore.
Good, take action. Talk about it, set your boundaries, speak your truth.
Maybe that job is making you miserable.
Good, start looking for another one.
Maybe that investment is worth your time because losing a few bucks might teach you something about yourself. Something that you didn't know before.

It is important to mention that in today's world, **time and money are deeply linked**. This makes starting anything new feel heavier than it actually is. Because if we *'fail'* we lose time and money too. Which is heavy indeed. But not as heavy as we think it is. Which leads us to not taking action at all in the end. Sad story.

The extreme worst-case scenarios we always imagine when we're about to take action are just that—extremes. Most likely, they won't happen. But our brains are wired to create

them to protect us from doing something reckless that could harm or even kill us. But on a day-to-day basis, overthinking those case scenarios doesn't serve us anymore.

Anyway, I think I have made my point clear on what conformity is and how to avoid it. However, we live in the world of summaries, the world of bullet points and the world of *'explain it to me like I am a 6 year old'* mentality. Therefore, I would like to summarize everything we discussed so far. Moreover, I cannot keep on writing this chapter because I am in my grandma's house in Athens and things are getting scary here folks. Old ladies are coming over for coffee to visit my grandma and they are like Dementors from Harry Potter coming for my soul haha ! If you are from the South of Europe or a Balkan country, you know that if you are the only young one in a gathering where old people drink coffee and chat, you have to do one thing. **Run**!

Therefore, let's wrap this up.
What do I mean by avoiding conformity in 2025?

- Intentionally avoid constant comfort.
- Do the thing that makes you feel uncomfortable (especially in relationships).
- Have the hard conversations. Don't avoid them.
- Don't overthink things. Plan, but put a deadline for planning. Take action. Do what Nike said in the commercial for fuck's sake— haha!
- Keep real relationships ONLY. Don't just keep other people happy while damaging yourself. Make sure you are happy and the ones close to you will be happy as well. Happiness is like yawning. If you see one doing it, for some reason you do it too.
- Do not live on autopilot. Ask yourself: 'Why am I doing this and not something else?', 'Why do I feel like this?', 'What would happen if I don't do it?', 'What will happen if I do it?'. And other questions like that.
- Do not accept what others tell you at face value. Doubt it. Argue with it.
- Don't be scared. We will die anyway.
- Be curious in a world where everyone blindly praises billionaires and thinks they are geniuses just because they are in a position of power. Mr Robot said it

perfectly: 'They showed themselves, the top 1% of the 1%, the ones in control, the ones who play God without permission'.

- Accept that you don't know, and you will never know a lot. You might know enough at some point in life, simply because *enough* is a personally defined limit, but you will never know a lot. And that is ok. Life is too short to learn it all.
- Read the ancient thinkers. They kept me sane and helped me see things clearly. They pushed me to ask myself — if Ancient Greeks created so much, how did we, modern Greeks, come to this? How did we fuck things up so much? For plenty of justifiable reasons of course, but still, makes a person think. So… think.

Oh, and brush your teeth before you go to sleep. Healthiest thing you can do. Super easy.

Chapter 3:
What do I mean by *'soul'*?

The word *soul*, especially if you are from countries that have been through a lot of war or long economic crisis, is a heavy one. Having a soul, in my humble opinion, means you are vulnerable. Simply because you still feel things. And being vulnerable, in my humble opinion again, is synonymous to **being alive**, and I consider it as a very powerful state to be in. We should all be vulnerable.

It is 2025, so of course I cannot start telling you that the soul is only a spiritual thing, or it has to do with your third eye and that if you meditate long enough you will see the light at the end of the tunnel. Even if some of those things are very interesting, and doing them would not necessarily hurt, in today's world, things cannot be only spiritual. If you go full on spiritual mode and try to detach yourself from all the material things in society, you might make it. However, I think in 6 months you will have starved yourself to death. Actually I could bet on it, cause who doesn't like a little bit of gambling?

For that exact reason, I would like to define my own version of the word *soul*, what it means, and why you should not lose it in 2025 and beyond.

Let's start, shall we?

What does 'soul' mean in a 2025 context?

Let's put our mathematician hat on— only if math was that simple, haha! If:

- S stands for *'Soul'*
- A stands for *'Action'*
- I stands for *'Intuition'*

Then our beautiful equation is as follows: ***S = A + I.***
Soul is Action plus Intuition.
Taking action without listening to your intuition at all is like living on autopilot. Using only your intuition but not taking meaningful action means you are just a wannabe. If you go to art galleries looking at paintings and smoking a pipe with a beret on, it doesn't make you an artist. Do you know what makes you an artist? Making fucking art.

So…it has to be both.

For me, when I see an adult being connected to her inner child and knowing her purpose in life, I find it very interesting. Then if I see that same person taking action, oh my, to me this is when the *soul* comes into existence. Such a moment definitely needs to be experienced and observed.

And I don't know about you, but I like to observe a lot. People in particular. I think at times I can even reach a point where I could be called *'creepy'*. And when I say 'creepy' I mean the 'creepy' that gets you arrested. Haha. But I mean well, I promise. When I come to Greece to visit my family and my friends, I am observing things all day long. I like to walk a lot and observe everything around me. What people do, what they think, and based on my observations I try to guess what is going on inside their heads. Of course, the world is so complex, you can't get those guesses right every time.
I also like to take the metro and observe people, but only when I'm in Athens. I don't really take the metro anymore. Not because I'm a posh little prince. But because I lived in London for quite some time, and I was taking the metro to go to the center every day at rush hour. Every single day.
Now if I ever had a soul, after using the metro in the center of London on a daily basis, my soul is way smaller now and definitely a bit darker.

Now back to observing stuff.

In a couple of months, I will enter the 10th year of living abroad. One thing that I have observed these years, every time I am in Athens, is that more and more people are losing hope. I see it in their eyes. They don't have a fire in them anymore. Their souls seem

exhausted. And I am not judging of course, nor blaming anybody. The economic situation in Greece has been brutal for the last 15 years.
And when I say brutal I mean it. B R U T A L. Not with just a capital B, but with all caps. Especially for the younger generations. The ones that have so many years ahead that are full of uncertainty. I won't start showing charts with economic data to back my argument, because I know you probably don't care, but I will just share this: Greece, which was never listed in the 15 poorest countries in Europe, is now poorer than the 15 poorest countries in Europe—when I say poor I mean it from an economic perspective, I do not mean to discriminate any souls out there. Poorer not in annual income, but **in purchasing power**. Even if a monthly salary might be higher in Greece than it is in a 'poorer' country, you can buy less with it.

I will not go into more details regarding what Greeks are or aren't—I am biased after all. My passport confirms it. But seeing people's souls crushed, if not sad, is at the very least, deeply alarming. Which urges me to say what I will say next.

We cannot let our souls die. In a world where the majority stays on a superficial level simply because it is what works, and in a world where corruption, hate, war and lying are everywhere, you cannot let your soul die. It would be like giving up. Actually, not LIKE giving up, it WOULD BE giving up.

Do you remember earlier in the book that I said that in one way or another, everyone is lying? Well, I think that this is one of the main reasons why souls all over the world are crushed. Intuitions are hijacked, actions are never taken. And I'm not saying this from a *'reach your full potential'* bullshit perspective. I'm saying it from a *'live your life in your own fucking terms'* perspective.

Let's do a ***mini thought experiment*** to understand why our souls need to remain intact and how the whole system is trying really hard to crush them.

So— there are *8,000,000,000* people on this planet (Approx).

When you open TikTok, Instagram, Facebook or Twitter (or whatever app kids use these days) you have a feed that shows you what everyone is sharing. Let's make the assumption

that you use one of those apps on a daily basis— which let's face it is a solid assumption. Now let's assume that in your feed you see content from 1,000 different people every day—which is not really the case because you see content from way less people due to how algorithms work. Now follow this thought for me: If you would use one of those apps every day, and if **everyone** on the planet was using one of those apps too, and if you would see content from 1,000 ***DIFFERENT*** people ***EVERY DAY,*** it would take you **8,000,000 days** to see content from all the people on this planet (because 1,000 people x 8,000,000 days = 8,000,000,000 people).
Now: 8,000,000 divided by 365 days in each calendar year = **21,917 years** (approx).
Unless you are a god, Gandalf The Grey or my grandma, you will probably not live 21,917 years. You will live like 70?80?90 years?
And that's if you are lucky.
Which brings us to these two beautiful conclusions:

- The 1,000 people you see on your social media feed, ***do not represent the whole world, nor the state the whole world is in.***
- Even if everyone on this planet is in a better state than you are, which is not the case, ***you would not live long enough to find out.***

(PS: if my cousin Socrates was alive, he would try to argue with my chain of thought, but, I hope you get my point, which is not about how valid the assumptions are, but instead, that you should not believe what you see on social media)

Media, Social Media, The News. They show the top 1% of the top 1% of what the society, with the help of the algorithm of course, considers as successful and great. As good enough in order to go viral. That does not mean that what you see is actually, objectively or intrinsically successful or great. Cause what is success anyway? Success has a different form for each one of us. But that is not how the media game is played. They come for your attention, to hijack your actions, to show you that everyone else is doing better than you so you are stressed out all the time.
But when you try things out and you see that you don't manage to get what those social media posts show as **great things to have**, you give up. Without having the context if what you see is actually real. Or if the person on those posts got what they show that they have in a year or did it take them 10 years to achieve? You couldn't possibly know.

And our poor little brains? They are not even made for such a vast amount of information. So, what happens when you throw at our brains a ton of fake information, when you hijack our attention and on top of all that, what happens when we try too hard and we don't acquire things fast enough? Well, our motivation gets killed.

That is exactly how our *souls* are attacked. And then you realize that even if you start working your ass off in order to get what the media shows you that you should get, you are not guaranteed to succeed. And your motivation fades away sooner or later. Because no material reward, no amount of money or fame will keep you hooked enough to keep working your ass off, if rewards don't come fast enough. Psychology 101.

Therefore:

- Ditch your phone 1 hour a day
- Don't believe what you see online
- Your social media feed is not the whole world
- Take fucking action
- Keep your inner child alive
- Don't FOMO, because there is nothing to FOMO about — *more on that later in the book*

And trust me, you will be just fine. As a matter of fact, you won't do just fine.
You will do great.

And we reached the end of this chapter. That is what I mean by the words *conformity* and *soul*. And as you see, it is quite simple: ***avoid the first to keep the second.***

Let's now move on to Part II of the book.

Part II:

A Weirdly Chaotic World

不易流行

Chapter 4:
Why are millennials screwed-ish?

I am a millennial. If you are too, there is a 99% chance that your parents, when at your age, were ten times less educated and five times richer than you are today. How about that? Even if they were earning less than what you earn now in value terms, they had way more purchasing power. They probably have 1, 2 or even 3 houses. They might have even built a house, bought one, or inherited one. Or all three.
But what about you? Still on rent? Hahah, what a loser!

I hope that you get my sarcasm by now.

We cannot talk about conformity, soul, resilience and living on your own terms in 2025 and skip **the money talk.** We just can't.
You have to fully understand the following things:

- What is money, really?
- What has happened and we, millennials, are so *screwed(ish)*?
- What is the (*ish*) after the *'screwed'*?

Why do I think that we should talk about all that you may ask?
Well… have you ever worked your ass off, or made some good money once in your life, or got a few salary increases, but still, you stress about money?
Or do you ever find yourself staring at the wall, thinking that you'll probably have to work until the day you die? Well, that's exactly why we need to have that talk.

Let's begin.

If you live in Europe, do this for me please: Try to make 1,000,000€, then buy a house, pay the necessary tax on that capital and if you actually manage to do all that—which you

probably won't—then tell me, can you live with what's left for the rest of your life without ever worrying about money? Sorry, but no.
That's why I need you to understand what the fuck is happening. Why do they tell you on the news that inflation has started to go down, but then you go to the supermarket, you check the price tags and your head spins around like the little girl's from the Exorcist?

Trust me, I will not bore you to death. This will be the coolest, sexiest, most interesting, most practical and the least boring money talk you have ever had in your life. It is not about capitalism, materialism, getting rich quick or how you can generate passive income while drinking cocktails at the beach or anything like that. It will be all about what your school didn't teach you, your parents didn't teach you, your friends don't know about and most importantly, what your society doesn't want you to know. If you are bold enough to want to start a family in the future, at least do it for your kids.

I do not aim to relate money to any political regime here or to any revolutionary movement or any other idealistic concept. The only aim here is to explain what money is in 2025. Not what it seems like, not what *I want it to be*, nor what *you want it to be*. But instead, **exactly** what it is. At the end of the day, I have a degree in Economics and Finance, I have built a few businesses, and in a few months it will be my 6th year of being an investor. You should trust me. I definitely have lost way more money that I have made, but heeeeey, look at the bright side. The sky is blue, birds are singing etc. Joking.
You should really listen to me. I mean Greeks are always involved in just about every financial scandal on the planet, and we are only 10 million people. We should at least know a thing or two about money right? Hahaha.

Seriously, let's do this.

What is money?

(PS: If you are a born rich prick, skip this section, you probably know all that. And, sorry for the 'prick', even if it is highly likely that if you were born rich, you are. Joking. Love)

Money is a taboo. Money is a concept. And most importantly, **money is not real.** If it was, it would grow on trees, or live inside the earth or in atoms in the atmosphere. But it

does not. And for a thing to be really real it needs to be **real by nature**, and not by humans— but more on that later.
Even the word *'money'* itself does something to people. You learn from a young age that the richest people are the worst, that a lot of evil is associated with money, that money is about capitalism. You also hear about illuminati stories and pyramids with eyes at the top and yada yada. There are cases that these things are true, indeed, however, they are not the default case. And they are not as spooky as they sound. Well not very often at least. Using weird terminology in order to confuse, or scare someone , is the best way to go when you want to keep someone away from something.
And in today's world, that something is called *control of money supply*.

Terms like controlling, money, or supply of money are very important terms to understand. However, I do not want to bombard you with every term used to represent money in this world. I honestly believe it would bore you a lot.
Actually, let me you give a taste, a little glimpse of the words used today to describe money and you can see how boring and confusing it can get: *money supply, money in circulation, M0, M1, M2, base money, credit money, central bank money, commercial bank money, Federal bank reserves, Reverse Repos, US TBills, treasuries, bonds, IOUs, certificates of deposits and* BLAH BLAH BLAH. These are actual terms used in today's world to describe money. Seriously. I mean, one thing you should know about today's system, and especially the financial one, is that they made it their number one priority to **use as many terms as possible** to confuse you completely when it comes to money. For real. All the terms I just mentioned are different terms of saying *'money'* in today's world. And I didn't mention all of them. Far from it.

That's why, I will instead use a beautiful technique, discovered by my other cousin, *Aristotle*, which is called First Principles Thinking, to tell you the one and only thing you need to know about money. And the rest of the terms, fuck'em. Just ignore them. Go live your life and don't waste more precious hours on finance, it is not worth it. No matter what everyone tells you. But first, you need to understand that one thing.

So first things first.
We do live in a crazy world. Everybody knows that. Today's world is tough, deeply strange, and undeniably chaotic. I mean, most people are walking around thinking, *'What*

the fuck is going on?'. But if I had to describe it in the most accurate and efficient way, I'd say this: **we live in a debt-based world.**

Believe me, I could use all kinds of charts. Charts with interest rates, inflation, demographics, liquidity cycles, market cycles, business cycles, US Treasury yields, you name it. But it won't matter, because I know you don't give a fuck. And honestly, life is so short, that maybe it is ok to not give a fuck. But, I do, and I want to explain to you the difference between the two most important terms: money vs currency.

It is quite simple actually, even if it will sound shocking: You, and I, **have never used money** in our lives. NEVER. When you go to the supermarket and buy water, toast-bread, avocados, shampoo etc, what you are paying with is not money. When you are on a date, you have a few drinks and then you are ready to go home together and go bananas, when you ask for the bill and pay, what you use is not money. When you pay your rent, when you buy condoms, when you buy that bottle of wine that you can't wait to chug down or when you buy that product on Amazon that you don't really need, well what you are using there is not money either. What is it then? It is ***currency***. And you have to deeply understand why it is different.

The main difference between the two is that money, apart from a means of exchange and a unit of account, also needs to be a store of value. What that means is that if you hold it for a long time, its value should either stay the same or go up. Not down. But of course, this is not what is happening today. The value of money is constantly going down. Its purchasing power is constantly decreasing.
Now, I will close this section of what money is with one short fairytale, so you can understand it once and for all, and we can move on. To understand what a debt-based system is and why what you see in the news about the economy is always lies.

By the way, before our story begins, remember this: All the time in the news and in the media, they say that every government owes money to another government or to the central bank, or that governments have deficit issues, debt issues and that they are trying to decrease or pay back their debts. That's all **rubbish**. Fake. Shit shit shit. It's Fugayzi, fugazi. It's a whazy. It's a woozie. It's fairy dust. Like McConaughey said in the Wolf Of

Wallstreet. No one is trying to decrease anything. Simply because, the debt cannot be paid back, by nobody. Simply because, **the debt IS THE MONEY.**

Now, let our little fairytale begin:

A long long time ago, it was Day Zero on the Happy Planet. The Happy Planet was a quiet place, without much going on and money did not exist yet. Then, one beautiful morning, two greedy & sneaky old men decided they wanted more in life, and they found a way to gain more power than their fellow humans. They decided to create something, out of thin air, that humans would want a lot. Those men were nothing special. They just happened to have this idea because one of their family members told them it would be a cool thing to do. So they decided to give it a go. Without any proof of sovereignty, they asked themselves: "*How will everyone trust us and allow us to do what we want?"* . Well, they thought, let's dress up quite fancy and pretend that we are experts and we know more than everybody else. Simply because, they thought, wearing a suit, acting as an expert, and repeating yourself, is all you need to convince others that you are an expert. Their brilliant idea was to *print many pieces of paper,* put some colorful faces on them, and tell people that if they owned these pieces of paper, all their wishes would come true. So, they got all dressed up, cut a few trees, then they used some magic, and out of thin air, they created **1,000 pieces of paper.** Only those 2 old sneaky men could control and print those pieces of paper. And that's how their adventure began. They were officially ready to start, so they found the first fellow human to give those 1,000 pieces of paper. But they had to get something back, they could not just give 1,000 pieces of paper and take the risk of losing everything without making some extra pieces. That's when they came up with *another brilliant idea.* They requested from that person to give them back the 1,000 pieces of paper in the future, plus, a 3% on top of the initial 1,000 at some point later in time. And that is how the magic thing called an *'interest payment'* got invented. End of story.

(PS: I used men in my little story, not to discriminate against any gender, but just to make a point, because back then, when they created the financial system we know today, gender rights were very different. I personally believe, if women had created the system, maybe they would have found a smarter solution. And maybe everyone could benefit from this system, not only a few old men. But this didn't happen. Anyways, I just wanted to be clear.)

Now, I hope you are still reading and you haven't slept while going through my fairytale. The most important thing I want you to get from that story, is that on day zero, there was

0 money available. And on day one, there were ***1,000 pieces of paper money*** available. Therefore, there were 1,000 money units in total. Aka, **1,000 currency units**. In order to give that money to someone, it was necessary to charge a 3% interest rate on top, so the person who borrows it, returns the initial money, plus the 3% extra fee.
Now, this is important. I want you to ask yourself one question: if there were only 1,000 money units in existence, on the first day of our financial system, where would the 3% of the additional interest payment that the old men asked for come from? If only 2 men controlled the money supply, how could the person who borrowed the money initially, find the 3% of extra paper money to pay back the initially borrowed amount?

Think about it for a second. If there was only a fixed amount of something in this world, let's say 1000 units of that something, that only 2 men could reproduce, how could someone **find 30 more units of that something** to pay back?

…
…

Well, I will tell you the answer.
It **would not be possible** to find that amount of something.
That's s when the two old sneaky men came up with this malevolent idea:
They cut a few more trees, and they printed 1,000 more pieces of money, and they gave it to that EXACT SAME person, with another 3% interest rate on top of it. Now, there were 2,000 money units in existence:

- 1,000 money units + 3% interest (the first time)
- 1,000 money units + 3% interest (the second time, to pay back the first time)

Now let's stop. That's all I want you to grasp. They printed more money, to pay back the first money.
I know you are probably bored already, and maybe a bit confused. And that is ok—after being years in the game, money talks bore me to death too.
But I have good news. You literally do not need any extra information to understand the financial world we live in. The story and the fact that we print more money to pay back the previous money is all you need to know. And it mostly started after the financial crisis in 2008. After then, all the new debt issued is not for growth, but to pay back old debts.

This is how the financial world works today—ok yes, it is not that simple—but at its core foundation, that's the system.

Money is created from thin air, from old sneaky men, and the debt can never be paid back. Why? Because to pay back the initial debt, the only way to do it is by printing more money and using it for payments. Every. Single. Time. It cannot be avoided.

Let all that sink in for a second. Go for a walk. Think about it. Accept the fact that you have to stress yourself out, that you get white hair sooner than you should have because of anxiety, that you have to work long hours and take huge risks so a few old men can print more money out of thin air.

And the funniest thing? They don't even print it anymore. They just type it on a keyboard and enter it into a database. Similar to when you fill out a form and type in your email. To subscribe to a newsletter or something. Fucking hell.

That's it my friend, I won't bore you no more with the money talk.

This is how the world works, and there is nothing we can do about it to change it. Due to the fact that it does not serve anyone to change it. And if you try to change it, you will piss off many people and you might end up dead in a ditch. Seriously.
In our lifetime—if you are a millennial—there is a 99% chance this world won't change. And as it hurts me a lot to say it, because I have been in this space for quite some time, crypto will not change that system either. At least not any time soon. I hope I am wrong, honestly I do. But it does not seem like it will change anything.
Big finance firms control it now. However, crypto has indeed some other utilities—actually only one, and I'm saying that as a crypto developer too, not just as an investor—but I will talk about it later in this book.

Hence, you realize that changing the system that the world is built on, is not something that can be easily done. Escaping it though, is another topic, which we will touch on later. Consequently, if changing the system is out of our control, we should not really stress about it right? Maybe.

For now, all I want you to fully comprehend is that that's the financial system. More money needs to be printed, indefinitely, to pay back previous debts. And that means that our purchasing power will continue decreasing indefinitely.
Aaaaaaand… enough with the money talk.

Did I bore you? Did I make you feel sad? I hope not.
If you didn't know any of this, at least now you know.
If you knew everything already, then I'm happy, it means that people still read stuff.

Now let's move on to the next section of this chapter.

Why are millennials screwed-ish?

Well…the economy is a very complex system, however, the reason why we millennials are so screwed is quite simple. ***Bad timing.***

It has to do with the fact that we have been born around, but not close enough, to these *two important dates*: 1933 and 1971. What are those days you may ask? Well, they marked the initiation of the current fiat system as we know it. If you are in crypto— as a crypto bro, as a crypto investor or as a crypto developer— there is a 100% chance that you have heard the term *'fiat currency system'*. Another term used to define our current monetary system.

Before I explain what happened in the two years I just mentioned, remember that the word 'fiat', in Latin, means something like 'let it be done', or, 'it shall be'. It is used as a definition of our current system to reflect that the monetary system, aka the money, derives its value only from the public's trust in the government and it does not have any intrinsic value nor is backed by a physical commodity.

So, what the heck happened in 1933 and 1971?

Let's supersimplify it. In the past, to print money you had to have the equivalent, or a fraction of the amount you would print, in GOLD reserves. For example, if you wanted

to print 1,000 worth of dollars you should have 200$ worth of gold in reserves. Or 55kg of gold stored somewhere. This whole concept is something called 'gold standard'. No need to go into more details. Just remember that in order to print dollars, you needed gold in reserves. And by the way, the numbers I just used are completely hypothetical, just popped up in my head, they don't represent real rates.. I used them for you to understand things better.

Now due to the fact that the amount of gold in existence on our planet is limited, it should mean that the supply of the money would also remain under control and never go crazy. Right? Well, you wish– haha.

The folks out there in the U.S, of course saw this limitation and decided to spice things up a bit. They officially moved off the gold standard in two stages. First, in **1933**, President Franklin D. Roosevelt prohibited U.S. citizens from converting paper money into gold, effectively ending domestic convertibility. And later, in **1971**, President Richard Nixon ended the ability of foreign governments to exchange their U.S. dollars for gold, which effectively ended international convertibility and the gold standard as we know it. Now because of this, every central bank can turn the money printers on and GO BANANAS. Money printers go PRRRRRRR. Which of course, that's what happened.

And that's how timing, got millennials fucked.

According to Google and Wikipedia, millennials are born sometime between 1981 and 1996. I will ignore the childhood years for now, and focus on the fact that, if you are a millennial too, you **became an adult** sometime during 1999 and 2014. And by adult, I mean you turned 18 years old, I don't care when you actually matured.
Why am I saying this about turning 18? Because we have to face the fact that the whole reason why we are screwed-ish is because of *bad timing*. Nothing else. No universe is against us, even if at times it feels like that. We were born, entered adulthood and eventually the workforce during those years when the consequences of an out-of-control financial system hit the hardest. I mean from 1999 to 2014—when many of us were turning 18—these financial events happened:

- Dot-com bubble burst (1999 - 2002)
- Housing bubble initiation and credit expansion (2003-2006)

- Global Financial Crisis (known as GFC) (2007-2009)
- Eurozone Debt Crisis (2010 - well, till today)
- Money Printing and Crazy Low Interests rates (from 2010 till 2020).

And on top of that, wars started, and COVID hit in early 2020.
I mean, we didn't catch a break haha! If you are a millennial and you end up being an alcoholic, depressed or with lots of PTSD, that's ok, you have your reasons.
Let's face it, money problems always lead to mental health problems.

All I want you to get from all this is that **you should not blame anyone** for the consequences—even if you actually could and would be partially right— and most importantly I don't want you to blame yourself. I mean, if you were not born with a disease, or in a very under-developed country, or in war, or without parents or any other brutal situation someone can think of, then it is fine, it is not that bad.

We will talk about the mental consequences of the events I just mentioned, later in this book. For now let's stick to the numbers. Essentially, the main side effect of all these events—the reason why millennials can't afford a house, don't have substantial savings, and we are basically "having 99 problems, with money always being one", hahah—is this: Consistent money printing has devalued the currency, destroyed our purchasing power, and driven prices up across the board—for pretty much everything.

That's it and all we can do is just accept it. We are paying the price because some generations spent a lot without planning things properly. I used to be very mad with the generations that fucked things up so big. But empathy is important, otherwise you might lose your mind by fighting everyone. So, as my ancient Greek ancestors used to do, I asked myself: if I lived during a period when the government and everybody would give me monetary benefits, easy money and affordable housing without telling me what will happen later, would I say no? Would I reject it? Probably not, I don't know.

Imagine living in such a world, right? I mean, receiving monetary benefits and help from the government, affording housing or getting a loan with good terms. We millennials never got that. Thinking about that makes me feel like a kid sitting at the park looking at

the sky and day dreaming: *ohhh how beautiful would it be if those fancy dressed people would give me some cash.* Hahaha!

Now that you have a better idea of how we millennials got screwed, let's look at the bright side. The side that made me add the (ish) at the end of the *screwed-ish* word that I used in the title of this chapter.

What is the (ish) after the 'screwed'?

Hardship builds character, not pleasure. That's what they say.
But what does that have to do with us?

The fact that we—millennials—have seen so many *black swan events* in our lifetime, has one crucial side effect. It made us ***aware***.
That is our secret weapon. Our *ish* after the *screwed.*
I mean, we don't really have to get into the details of how aware we are when it comes to corruption among governments and banks here in the South of Europe—we really have seen enough to know the game by now.
But being aware is a two-sided coin. It does something to you.
It can make you alert, it can make you proactive but it can also give you fear and anxiety.
In general, being aware does a lot of things to you, and like freedom, it comes with a price. But more on that later.

We are aware of ourselves, aware of what is happening around us, and aware of the fact that no one is coming to save us. Above all, we are aware of what is going on inside our heads, probably because what is going on in there feels so intense that it would be impossible to ignore. I'm not saying that we understand what is happening, that we do something about it and we overcome it, but at least we know something weird is going on. This level of awareness puts us in a powerful position to take action in this messy world. Of course, we haven't figured everything out—and I'm not suggesting that every millennial has reached this level of self-awareness. But we do have the capacity to do something meaningful—for ourselves, and potentially for others.
That is why I put the (*ish*) next to the *'screwed'*.
That *ish* represents our power—the ability to shift things to our favor.

It reflects a skill we've developed more sharply than previous generations. Everyone else—especially those from earlier generations—outsourced their biggest concerns to the state, the system, the government, society, the banks, or even to God. Which is of course acceptable, and in most cases understandable. But most of us millennials didn't. We question things more than others. Of course some of this outsourcing has been done by us as well. And again, it is ok. But we cannot ignore that this outsourcing that has been done, had some tremendous consequences.

Well, before we list the consequences, what do I mean exactly when I say *outsourcing some of our major concerns to the state/system/governments etc*?

From what life has shown me so far, when outsourcing some of our deepest personal concerns—like the fear of death, uncertainty about the future, or the question of why things happen the way they do—we become in a way… *happier*. The less you think about something, the more peace you feel. The more you ignore, the happier you are. Nonetheless, ignoring the hard questions is a very risky business.
If one day something happens to you and you can no longer ignore things you will face a big dark monster. And it might be too late when you do acknowledge it. So, the outsourcing I'm talking about takes many forms. It can be outsourcing knowledge, beliefs, financial decisions, or even your entire sense of what the future should look like. Actually, here are some more concrete examples of what that outsourcing might look like:

- Trusting your finances completely to governments or your employers
- Not investing at all because you feel lazy or you say you are "too busy"
- Assuming that, at all costs, the government will be there to take care of you
- You tell yourself that *'oh, this is not for me, that's for the experts'* so you never take action
- Assuming that because they wear suits, they know more than everyone else
- Accepting that getting a good job, buying that house, taking that loan and starting a family is what a good civilian does in life
- Never changing your core beliefs and saying to yourself that if everyone else is doing it then it is correct

Again, doing either of those things, or all of them, is ok. I'm not here to judge.
I just believe that you should not blindly do those things.
Why, you ask?
Because not taking your life in your own hands, or accepting things as they are, or ignoring hard truths, and saying ok this is how it has always been, is exactly what keeps this system alive. And every time we do it, we make it stronger.
Of course, you have every right to do it. I am not here to tell you what you should or what you should not ignore. All I want to point out is that you should be aware that there is a big risk and a big price to be paid, if one day you 'wake up' and you realize that you have not been living the life you want. Just because ignoring things now might make everything easier for you it does not mean you should do it.
Just read some stuff from Arthur Schopenhauer and you will see for yourself that choosing the more challenging path is always better in the long run. But be careful, reading stuff from that guy might make you a VERY miserable person haha!

Anyway, I hope you get my point.

All in all, in 2025, having the skill of heightened awareness—and choosing not to outsource our future to the state, the government, or any concept larger than ourselves—makes us, as millennials, powerful individuals. I mean, we can still believe in something greater than ourselves—and honestly, that might even be a wise thing to do (more on that later)—but that doesn't mean we have to hand over all of life's decisions because of it. Right?
And honestly, for whatever wrong that has already happened in this world, all we can do is accept that it is done and that we cannot change it. Blaming others about their mistakes and the consequences of their actions towards us, won't help. If we keep going down that road, we're just beating ourselves up for no reason—draining our energy without any meaningful outcome. We should recognize that all of this wrongdoing has, in some way, made us stronger. And embracing our powerfulness is very important.

And that was it for this section. I know that we are in the era of AI, and our attention span is becoming shorter and shorter, so let me summarize what we have discussed so far in this chapter.

In a nutshell:

- **We millennials are financially "screwed-ish"** not because of personal failure, or because the universe has a problem with us, but due to **bad timing**, entering adulthood during dot-com, GFC, debt crises, and endless money printing, destroying purchasing power and skyrocketing prices.

- **Money is not real; it's created from thin air**, and the debt-based system requires more debt to pay off previous debt, trapping the whole society in perpetual currency devaluation.

- **Millennials have awareness as a superpower**, seeing through systems and narratives, realizing no one is coming to save us. We must navigate this chaos ourselves. And most importantly, we are 100% capable of doing this.

- **Outsourcing life decisions to governments, systems, or societal norms is risky**, as ignoring reality may lead to facing a "big dark monster" later, forcing one to confront an unlived life. Something which we will discuss later in this book.

- Despite systemic unfairness, **accepting what has happened, letting go of blame, and using our awareness, makes us stronger**, turning adversity into a tool instead of a burden.

I hope you enjoyed this chapter as much as I enjoyed writing it. I don't want this book to become just another knowledge book, or a data heavy book or anything like that. But for some reason I felt a moral obligation and a desperate need to explain to you how the monetary system works. I have spent many years researching it, analyzing it, understanding it and I have made big financial bets based on all the things I have discovered. And the more people know about it, I think, the better.
Of course, the world—and the system we live in—are not as simple as I presented them. We used a fairytale, a few examples and thought experiments, to simplify all these complex ideas so you can at least get an abstract sense of how everything works. In the

end of the book I will list some of the books and concepts I have read in my life regarding those topics for anyone interested in learning more in their own time.

I will now go walk a bit, cause my back hurts from sitting on this shitty chair for way too long writing this chapter.

Prepare yourself for what's coming.
Inside and outside this book.

Chapter 5:
What goes deeply against our nature?

This year, I had one of the biggest *"Aha!"* moments of my life.
It's pretty ironic—when you're desperately searching for something and can't seem to find it, one day you realize that it has been right in front of you all along.

Since I was 24 years old, I have been in the world of entrepreneurship, indiehacking, solopreneurship, and in general, I have been trying to hustle my way to freedom through every vertical that got my attention.
I always thought that at some point in my life the one-billion-dollar idea would come to me out of nowhere and then BOOM, Tasos would change the world. At least that's what all the marketing around entrepreneurship has been all about.
To be honest, since that age, no matter what I do or build, always in the back of my mind I'm trying to come up with this one-billion-dollar idea that will change everything.
Obviously, life does not work like that. Fortunately or unfortunately. And to be precise, when I say *"one-billion-dollar idea"*, I'm not really talking about the money here.
I mean it as a concept—a way of describing the kind of idea that genuinely changes the world. Sure, it might earn you a billion dollars (*haha*), but at this point, the money is irrelevant. Nonetheless, I still want to make a change in this world, but will talk about this later on.

So…

For once, ***without forcing anything***, without trying at all, I did get an *'aha'* moment. An idea came that changed everything for me, even if it didn't pay me a 9-digits amount.
I guess after all, ***the law of detachment is real.***
That out-of-the-blue idea I'm talking about came to me without me searching for it and it had a massive impact on my life. It has nothing to do with startups, entrepreneurship,

investments or with any app that might change the world. It might even sound basic to you or you have already figured this out way before I did.
But before revealing this idea to you, this realization that changed everything for me, we need to make sure we are on the same page regarding a few things.

What do I mean when I say *'our nature'*? And what do I mean by *'against'* it?

Not sure if you remember, but I mentioned earlier in the book that—even though our lives have changed drastically over the past few millennia—our brains still repeat many of the same patterns they did back then.
The problem is, those patterns—and the intensity of them—are often irrelevant today, and don't really serve us anymore. The reason I bring this up is simple: to show you that we humans share far more than we realize. You don't need to worry about—or suppress—your primal instincts. They're a fundamental part of what makes you human. And if you think that you are weird, broken, or too 'this' or too 'that', PLEASE DON'T. We're so obsessed with proving how different we all are, that sometimes I wonder—
Isn't that obsession itself a sign that, deep down, we're all more alike than we think?

Anyways, enough with the philosophical questions - for now.

What do I mean by 'our nature'?

Our nature is all about eating, drinking water, surviving, socialization, status, sex, reproduction and going to the toilet. Everything else—anything outside of this spectrum that in today's world is backed by phrases like *'proof that our humanity has evolved'*, or *'we have advanced in many ways'* etc—is ultimately human-made. Our nature can be described in very simple and abstract ways. However, it is indeed quite complex at an individual and case by case level.

What do I mean by that?

Is there a beast running towards you looking aggressive? Great—our nature says run, hide. Is your belly making weird noises and feels empty? Grab a piece of food and chug it

down till you no longer want more. Easy. Does the thingy between your legs feel a bit aroused? Cool—find someone who has the same feeling for you and go bananas. Have you drunk 5 beers in 1 hour but the cue to the toilet is too long? No problem— go outside, find a parking spot without a lot of light and LET GO (best feeling ever right?) . Do you feel like you need to talk to someone about something or interact with another fellow human? Good, call a friend, sit down with someone and chat about it.

In the most abstract sense, all these examples represent our ***most fundamental needs.*** And what about all the habits that our brains have repeated endlessly over millennia? Well, they're mostly built to ***satisfy those needs***—on loop.

Albert Einstein said: *'It's not that I'm so smart. It's just that I stay with problems longer'* .
He deeply understood that brains are all about creating habits.
He knew that consistency is key and if you repeat something long enough, your brain will take it as a habit and it will eventually become second nature.

Now, without deviating from our main topic, you might be wondering, *where am I going with all this?* Well, at first, I wanted to make sure you understand what I meant when I said ***our nature***. And now that we've covered that, I want you to recall something we often hear people say about us human beings: ***we are social creatures***. Which is true—I mean, try spending a looooot of time completely alone, and then tell me all about what the walls are saying to you. Haha! Don't get me wrong—I believe it's incredibly important for us, as humans, to spend time alone. To reflect. To question things.
But let's save that for a little later and focus on what threatens our nature.

For now, the main point is this: we are used to, and enticed by, social interactions.
It is the visuals, the sounds, the colors, the expressions, the smells & the touching that happens between real life figures that make everything more… well, real! That's probably why so many people obsess over celebrities—actors, musicians, public figures they rarely, if ever, encounter in real life. They build fantasies around who these people are, how they behave, and what it would be like to know them. That distance and lack of access create mystery—a kind of unfulfilled desire—which often turns into obsession. If you have read *Mimetic Theory* from René Girard and the whole concept of 'Celebristan' you know exactly what I mean.

There's something about real-life social interaction—meeting someone face-to-face and engaging in conversation—that gives us a sense of safety and certainty. I can't quite explain it. And unless you've been living under a rock, you probably know that certainty and safety are exactly what our brains are all about. Maybe it's the in-person communication—the activation of all our senses in real time—that gives us exactly what we need at that moment. Like when you're having an argument in person, you can read the other person's expressions and instantly know if you've upset them, calmed them down, or made them want to slap you. (*Please don't slap anyone. Just give people love and flowers.*)

Anyway, I assume you get my point by now—this is what I mean by social interaction. These moments are a core part of our human nature. You can't lock yourself in a room forever. I've done it myself—for a couple of years, actually—mainly to focus on learning and self-discovery. And yes, it can put you ahead in terms of knowledge, it can teach you rare skills, and maybe even add a few zeros to your bank account. But when it comes to dealing with people? It won't help you much.

That's exactly what I meant by *our nature.* And now, we are ready to move to the next part— the *'against'* our nature.

Against our nature

There are A LOT of things happening in 2025 that are against our nature. For starters, the amount of information we consume on a daily basis that it is impossible for our cute little brains to handle. Then the fact that if you are in your 20s and you don't have everything figured out you are a failure. Or if your bank account does not have 7 figures in, you are a fucking loser. Or I don't know—maybe the fact that people twice elected as president someone who grabs people by their genitalia. Because apparently, that's the only place you can grab someone from. Right?
Fuck, I promised myself I wouldn't get political.
But some things are just too loud to ignore.

All these things, and many more, that are happening in 2025, are against our nature and they are fucking as up. But there is one thing in particular that I personally believe, is

fucking everyone up, more than anything else. Or, it is the thing that just fucked **ME** up more than anything else. And I'm finally ready to reveal it.
The idea that changed everything for me. The one that will help me live a calmer, and eventually a happier life. The one that I strongly believe that is fucking you up too.

I see it everywhere—when I talk with friends, walk down the street, visit my family in Greece, stand in line at the supermarket, wait at the airport, or sit in a coffee shop trying to get work done. It's all around us. You might have noticed it too. Or maybe not. I only realized it recently. It's something that quietly eats away at our time, drains our energy, fills us with self-doubt, and leads to what—according to Eckhart Tolle—might be the root of all misery: **not being present.**

"Dude, come on—just tell us what it is already," you might be thinking.

I tell you that it is simple but yet not that simple. It is a side effect of a global shift that has happened over the last 2 decades. The shift from physical to fully digital. The fact that even when you do this thing in real life it is bad for you but now that you do it digitally it is 1000 times worse.

Are you ready?
Here you go:

Every time you **use a digital form of communication— like a chatting app on your phone— and you spend a lot of your energy in order to do the following things**:

1. To convince someone about something via texting
2. To waste time to win an argument with someone over the phone
3. To keep people happy while making you miserable via frequent text updates
4. To explain yourself and try to justify your actions
5. To announce important things about yourself and expect validation

I cannot stress this enough: ***Doing these things via the phone is fucking us up. BIG TIME.*** And we all seem to know about it, but no one does anything to stop it.

If I am so different from all of you, or so extremely unique or a very niche use case, then I will rephrase. **THIS FUCKED ME UP. BIG TIME**.
However, I don't think that's true. I don't believe that I am a unique case here and I do know that most of us are behaving in a similar way. I see it everywhere. I see you motherfuckers—hahah.

I called it my big 'aha' moment, because I realized that I have been doing it for many years, ON AUTOPILOT, and I had no clue. I did it to '*keep myself balanced*', and make sure that everyone sees me exactly the way I wanted to be seen— which is a concept called *ideal image* and we will analyse it in depth later in this book.
Maybe this is not big news for you, maybe you already knew all that and you are like *'yeah, using your phone a lot is not good for you dude, we know it'*. My perspective though has to do with specific forms of social interaction. Not just using the phone to chat, talk etc. I am referring to a particular type of communication via the phone in order to do the 5 things that I mentioned earlier. And if you have read any self-therapy or psychology books, you have probably come across some of the main reasons that cause anxiety, depression and a constant feeling of emptiness. Some of those reasons are seeking external validation, engaging in negative thinking, trying to control people's opinions and, overall, fighting every battle. All these things will completely drain your energy.

And all of those books will tell you to not do these things. That they will affect you big time. Which is definitely the case. However, those books tell you to avoid doing these things in real life. Things like arguing, or trying to win arguments and prove you are right, or try to validate yourself by seeking reassurance from others etc. But, those books never mention the consequences of doing those things ***digitally***. The side effects from doing these things digitally are 1000 times worse. Why? Because of these two little demons:

- Asynchronicity
- Faceless Interaction

Asynchronicity is pretty self explanatory. It makes everything feel like you are always partially on or partially off. But never fully engaged, nor fully disconnected. A real life conversation could take 5-10 minutes to sort it out. But via the phone, via Messenger or Whatsapp, due to everybody's busy schedule, you might exchange 10 messages in the span of 5 hours. And automatically something that could bother you for 5 minutes, ends

up occupying your mind for 5 freaking hours. If we had 150 hours in one day, maybe that would be ok. But last time I checked, the hours we have available daily are way less.

Now, *Faceless Interaction*. What's that?
Faceless interaction is basically when you chat via the phone and you don't really get the tone of the other person via text. You don't get the 'way' someone said something to you and you put into additional mental effort to sort it out. VIA TEXT. Like if someone puts emojis often when replying, and all of a sudden they don't, and you start thinking, "*hmm what's up with them, I must have said something wrong*". Or when someone answers with just one word, or without revealing the true emotion behind the text, and you start doubting yourself again. Come on, don't tell me that all this hasn't happened to you many times.

When combined, *asynchronicity* and *faceless interaction* amplify the effects of social interaction by at least **tenfold**—compared to how we'd experience the interaction in person. These two little demons do not exist when an argument, conversation or any social interaction occurs in real time and in-person. But they do exist when we do it digitally, especially, and mostly by text. And those 2 little demons kill *certainty* and *safety*, which are our brains' favorite things. Our brains own nature. That's why all this is deeply against our nature. And I guess that's why it felt such an *'Aha!'* moment for me. Even after explaining it here with words, I think it is not possible to communicate the severity of the situation and how much it affects us all. If you feel fatigue, extremely tired, your brain buzzing, stressed, or your energy feels low quite often, it has a lot to do with this behavior. It is not just scrolling on Instagram that fucks you up. It is also that you spent 1 hour toxically talking to a friend in order to win an argument for a shitty thing that happened a few days ago. The fact that you feel a constant urge to reply back via text and convince or correct someone, or justify an action and explain yourself, is embedded in your nature, you can't escape it. Choosing the phone to do it though? Exacerbates the whole experience and fully drains your energy. For real. It is exhausting you. But don't worry. It can and will be fixed.

Ok—brilliant! Another important concept out of the way.
We are one step closer to avoiding conformity in our lives.

By now, you should know what I mean by 'our nature', 'against our nature', how and why our brains crave safety and uncertainty, the 'aha' moment that changed my whole life's view, and of course, the two sneaky demons: asynchronicity and faceless interactions.
We have clearly stated the big problem that most of us face in 2025 and some of its major consequences. Thus, we are now ready to discuss how we can fix things.
And what's a more effective way to explain something than using a real-life example?
So, before we move on to the next chapter, I'd like to share my personal experience and the thought process I used to improve this aspect of my life. Consider it a ***bonus*** — a small gift. Well, technically, since you've paid for this book—unless you hacked my PC and got access to it—calling it a "gift" might not be suitable.

Anyway, my aim is to paint a more vivid picture of what all this can cause to someone, how to spot the patterns and how to avoid them.

Let's dive in.

Bonus Story, Technique & A Piece of Advice

I'm not sure if it has to do with regions, cultures, or specific national characteristics, so I won't be saying things like *"if you're from Southern Europe, you'll understand"* or *"if you're Greek, you know."*. Ok?
Because I truly believe it's mostly about people, on an individual level—their mindset, their habits, and the choices they make in life—and not about borders.

In a few months it will be the 10th year of me living abroad. Nevertheless, some people in my circle still don't get what it means to spend 10 out of 30 years of your life outside of the country. Or, even if they get that, which I personally don't think they do, they don't realize that 10 years are more than enough to change a man. Or a woman.
I don't really have the expectation or the request for anybody to 'get it' or 'get me' anymore. I just need to provide you some context before I explain to you why I used the phone for the **5 Things we discussed earlier**, and illustrate the consequences this whole thing had on me.

Letting go of the *need for people to get you* is one of the best, if not the best, ways to have a calmer life. That's exactly why I do not—and you shouldn't either—blame, judge or point fingers to anybody anymore. Simply because using a phone to do the 5 things, or getting affected mentally or emotionally by doing it, was *my freaking choice*. Nobody else's.
And as we've discussed countless times by now, if you repeat a behavioral pattern long enough, it becomes second nature—shaping not only how you see yourself, but also how others see you. Then a time comes, when you need to ditch that pattern, embrace the chaos that will come from ditching it, and just be patient, cause things WILL calm down. Trust me on that one.

Now—background story time.

My parents are lovely people. Normal people. With core values and a lot of love for their children. However, they were not prepared, mentally nor physically for the fact that one of their children would leave the country haha! And I am mostly referring to my mother, my father is not that expressive to be honest with you. Or maybe let's just say that he talks less than other people haha! Men of his generation are a bit like that. Some a bit more, some a bit less. My mother, on the other hand—as a mother and a more emotionally attuned creature—deeply ties her happiness to the well-being of her children. Which brings us to my main point. When I left Greece, my mother was quite depressed for many years. And of course, she would express that in her own toxic ways. Nobody is perfect. I am definitely not either.

There is no need going into more detail on the hows and the whats, and all the magic mothers use to get their ways, haha! Actually, as psychiatrists say: 'If mothers were perfect or non-existent, we would be out of business'. Go figure. Anyways.

If you love your mother, which I do of course, you want to keep her happy. When you do things that don't make your mother happy a lot of complicated feelings arise that have a big effect on you. The mother complex is a thing after all. Maybe for you there is another person in your life that has this effect on you. For me it was my mother. The behavioral pattern, the habit, the copying mechanism, name it whatever you want, that I personally chose in order to keep my mother and other family members and friends happy was this: Keep everyone in the loop. Keep them up to date. Don't disappear and make sure that at

all times they know you are doing ok. ***Even if you are not***. Even if you are having a very engaging conversation with your ***fridge*** at times. Which I don't think anyone would call that *'doing ok',* haha! No matter what, keep the communication going. That was the pattern. Now, ***that's where things got trickier.***
I said to myself, even if I don't really get much out of the continued communication and all the updates, I should keep doing it. Even if I don't really need or miss them at a given moment I should be there answering every text, every call, and acting as I am always doing fine. Which, let's face it, is impossible. Nobody is always doing fine.

And the real question is, how did I repeat that behavioral pattern? Well, by constantly communicating and doing the 5 Things we mentioned earlier, via the phone.

I kept repeating the same pattern on autopilot just to balance myself and keep myself in order. How? By making sure I never revealed to people who don't understand what it means to live abroad that sometimes I wasn't doing okay. By making sure that everyone else felt calm and satisfied when thinking that I haven't changed at all. *He is still the same guy he used to be for the first 20 years of his life* — they think. That I'm still the same person after almost a decade living abroad. I mean, how could that be even possible? It became an ongoing mental pressure, born from the belief that if I didn't stay in regular contact with certain people from back home, it meant I had forgotten my roots. Making sure that all these were kept under control, was priority number one for me for years. But by following a very wrong behavioral pattern. And without even noticing it.

I mean, changing your life is not easy, and it is definitely not safe. But for some people it seems completely foreign. Leaving Greece for most of my family members, and for some friends too, seemed problematic— even until now, 10 years later haha! Or, I don't know, feels like a puzzle to them. Weird. Like why go? Why not stay? Why you changed? I mean…I don't blame them. And I definitely do not have the need for anyone to get anything anymore. I'm just explaining how I have personally experienced it. And to be honest, If someone lives in a particular way, thinks in a particular way, sees and hears the same things over and over again, I can't expect that person to see things from a different angle. It took me many years, but I have finally understood that.

Now, before we move on to the actual effects of all this, let me explain ***what I did wrong here and how I kept this pattern going***, which didn't serve me at all.

Let me put my developer hat on and tell you. Don't worry it will be a super simple explanation!
If you ever wrote any piece of software, built an app or learned any programming language then you definitely came across these two terms *Input/Output* (IO) and *side effects*. If not, it is ok, I will try to explain it as simply as possible.
Input/Output represents predictable cause-and-effect—pure functions that always return the same result for the same input. **Side effects** arise when functions interact with external systems, introducing unpredictability, complexity, and the need for error handling. That was my mistake. I assumed that I, along with my family members and friends, was a pure I/O function—that I would do a logical thing, and only a logical thing would come out—but life proved me wrong. That's why humans cannot be predicted. Emotions are causing unmanageable side effects.

So, by assuming that having this behavior, for many years, would always be okay and keep things under control, **I ended up feeling completely out of control and experienced side effects that I had never expected.**

When looking at the bigger picture, when zooming out, obviously a 5 year old would be capable of seeing the side effects coming, haha! But not me. Apparently, I am not as intelligent as I think I am. So what were those **side effects?**
Here you go:

1. I became 'addicted', in a way, to the process of convincing, explaining, seeking validation from family members and friends. I felt like if I wouldn't do that, I would not be able to function properly—for the reasons I will mention shortly.
2. The realization that even if someone loves you, even if you explain, even if you correct, even if you try to convince someone about something, IT DOES NOT MEAN that they will understand you, see you or recognize whatever you want them to. Only if by explaining ourselves to people, people would understand!
3. By not doing the 5 things over the phone, I would feel guilty, angry, I would completely ignore the present and then spiral inside my head of all the

consequences that would occur because I didn't do those 5 things. I was basically 'hardcoded' in a way to repeat them.

4. Due to a particular kind of subconscious pressure during childhood, I would keep some relationships going, just to keep people happy. And not really benefit myself or them in any meaningful way. (That was a big slap in the face)

All these side effects had a ***huge impact on me.*** They removed all the good parts of staying in touch with people that are no longer in your daily life. People that you miss from time to time, and it would be great to catch up in a smooth and a healing way with them. But the biggest impact of those side effects was that they would drain my energy so much that I couldn't see that spending energy there meant that I am spending less energy in my real life and on real things. For example, instead of building real relationships or focusing on other creative things and other interests of mine, I would stay in my head being affected by all this and never feel present.
That was basically my drug of choice.
My addiction to keeping myself in order.
My way of keeping everyone happy even if I was making myself miserable.

This behavior kept me trapped in a way. I used to feel guilty, feel like I had to prove myself to people and show them that my choice of leaving Greece had only good outcomes. How could something have only good outcomes? I don't know. I mean, Ying Yang 101, for fuck's sake.

I felt I had to show that I am always fine, that I've made it and I am successful, that once you read hundreds of books, travel a dozen countries, build businesses and take a few bets, then boom, YOU MADE IT IN LIFE. I kept feeling that I have to explain every move I make. Why I am moving there, why I am building projects, why I do this and I don't do that. And when they didn't get it, I would be frustrated, engaging in long arguments in order to explain myself. Over the fucking phone. Or I would just be cold and distant.
I was keeping in touch with people I didn't match with anymore. Simply because, as I mentioned earlier, 10 years can change a man. Or a woman. And that's ok, you don't have to match with everyone from your childhood. But I felt guilty about it. I felt like I

betrayed people because I changed my life. Maybe it was my fault feeling like that, but their questions and behaviors triggered it. I guess childhood trauma is really a thing.

All kinds of insecurities from different people in my circle were projected onto me—big time. Or at least, that's how it felt. And I'm not playing the victim here—projection is something we all do. Maybe it's because since I was a kid, I've never been able to ignore what's happening around me, which makes everything feel more intense for me than it probably is. I don't know. Then, like any person caught in a pattern, I couldn't see it clearly—and I kept diving deeper into the cycle of trying to fix it. How? By proving myself, explaining myself, and justifying my actions with logic. And again, I'm not blaming anyone for projecting or for behaving the way they did. **We're all imperfect**, and projection is part of being human. But it's still our individual responsibility to handle things—and ideally in healthy ways that help us grow, heal, and move forward. Not by sweeping things under the rug and pretending everything's fine.
Which can easily describe what I did, haha!

Before I move on to the last part of this chapter, which is about an approach to deal with all this, I just want you to ask yourself: ***do you also do these things?***
Like right now, if you pause, and recall all the things you did yesterday or the last 7 days, did you try to convince someone, explain yourself, correct someone or announce things to someone in a way that drains your energy? And did you get the result you wanted from doing it? Just think about it…

The Technique

My own personal technique to handle all this is very simple. I found it on Youtube—haha!

All you have to do? Ignore everyone. Fuck'em. Disappear.

Haha JOKING. You should not do that.

But honestly, I personally had to chill a bit with all the chatting. My therapist helped me a lot with it. She even made me track and eventually reduce my interactions with friends

from childhood and family members —unless something urgent of course— on a weekly basis haha. She gave a very logical task to a very rational— and occasionally irrational— person. Of course it worked. She knows what she is doing.

Obviously, the approach I am referring to is not about cutting people off. I have tried that, it only works with people you don't love and don't really care about.
If you love them, it will fuck you up. And if they love you back, it will be a freaking mess haha. Trust me on that one.

In general, cutting people off, disappearing, or not talking to them again without an explanation is all bullshit. And I have done these things too, that's how I know it is bullshit. It is the easy solution and it won't help you improve yourself. Just look at some of the greatest modern thinkers, philosophers etc. Nietzsche? Sartre? Simone de Beauvoir? They all said that becoming who you are and breaking free from social conformities is all about challenging yourself through struggle and discomfort. Not through pleasure and easy choices. If you don't trust me, trust them.

A Piece Of Advice

If you have read *Stillness Is They Key* from Ryan Holiday you know that inner peace has a lot to do with saying *'enough'*.

Identify what does not serve you anymore, what kind of materials, what kind of behaviors, what kind of thoughts, what kind of actions you don't need to keep on doing. We all know, according to science, that thoughts cannot be controlled. They just pop up. Only our reactions to them can be controlled. Scary, but true.
Material things can be controlled too and the acquisition of them should be very limited. Behaviors and actions are highly controllable and in matter of fact, are the key to all this. Not seeking external validation, not needing to convince or correct anyone, not needing to explain yourself just to justify your actions to others and even to yourself, are really important in 2025. Actually they always have been and they will remain for the decades and centuries to come.

No excuses here. You have to do something about these behaviors. For me, I didn't have to cut people off, but had to cut my subconscious link to receiving validation, acceptance, reassurance from family and friends from Greece. I have been carrying the burden of needing to prove myself, feeling that I have to justify my actions every time. And explaining that leaving a country is a logical thing for some people and not a crazy-as-fuck action. It was not about them though. It was never about them doing anything. It was about me. I had to do it. I had to change the pattern. Like the many patterns I have changed over the last 10 years.

Have I fully solved this problem you ask? Definitely not.
Have I improved? Yes, significantly.
Will it help you? I don't know.
Should you try? Definitely.

Identifying behaviors that do not serve you anymore is very crucial in my opinion. And just being aware of them is the first and most important step. Honestly, I have seen a lot of improvements in me and in others towards me as well. For example, my mother, she used to be very sad, now she is less sad haha. She used to be scared of life abroad. Now wherever I go she wants to come visit. That's big. I mean, we are now closer than ever, and our relationship has become stronger, more real. And the same with friends. Communication is incredibly important. Over the past ten years, some friends have become like family to me, while others—friends I once considered family because I had the wrong filters—are no longer part of my life. And that's okay. That's life.

That's why growing, maturing, and not blaming anyone are super important in order to not let all of these things affect you in a very negative way.

Family and friends are of course very important. They always have been and they will always be. Along the way though, you might create new families, new friends, you might realize that you can give yourself things that no family or friend will ever have the ability to give you. They have the intention, which is super important, but the intention does not fulfil. Intention excites. Action fulfils. Remember that.
You might realize that family and friends are not enough. You might need a partner or you might not need anything at all. Everything is a possible case scenario.

But we should never forget that our time and energy are limited resources.

And that means that you need to take action for the things that matter in your life TODAY. Things that matter in your real everyday life. Physical or mental does not matter, but if they occupy your brain and your heart everyday, you need to focus on them.
If you feel the urge to communicate things with someone in order to validate yourself, or explain yourself or all the other things we mentioned, well, don't spend all your energy on that. And if the urge remains, at least don't do it to someone who is not there physically or in your life at that given moment. Ideally you should take that energy and apply it to something or someone else. Go find a friend or even a stranger close to the place you are right now. Interact with people and things in real life. Not just digitally.

Turn the urge to do things that don't serve you anymore, into energy that you can use to become a better person. Go work out, go for a walk, start that project, read that book, play an instrument, have sex, I don't know. You gotta do something.
Do you know why? Because by doing this, and repeating this pattern, it will become your new habit. A healthy habit. In 2025, ***addictions are almost impossible to avoid***. At least make them as healthy as possible.

And be careful. If you have a lot of things hidden, if you have a lot of secrets kept from others, if things from the past have hurt you a lot and you have not revealed them, this approach will be hard or even impossible. Because it will subconsciously draw you back to the old patterns. It happened to me. Which fortunately led me to openly talk about things to friends and family members that I hadn't talked about for almost a decade. Do this first, before you apply this approach. And thank me later. Haha.

This whole approach calmed me down. Not fully of course, I still go nuts at least twice a day haha. But applying this into your life will teach you things about you, about life and relationships in general. Relationships, or showing love in our case, does not have to be toxic, consistent, or via non-stop interaction. Unfortunately, in today's world sometimes in the name of love, people will make you want to punch yourself in the face. I'm sure you know what I mean. But there's no need to take it to the extremes.

If giving yourself some space is what you need, do that. And most importantly, be aware. Every time you catch yourself typing fast and rushing to explain something on the phone, take a step back. Chill, breath. You don't need to spend time and energy to explain anything to anybody. As long as you are not doing something that has a negative effect on someone else, consciously or unconsciously (even if that would be hard to identify), you don't owe anyone an explanation. And honestly, if by taking this approach all you get back is toxic behaviors or judgemental statements, well, that's proof that it is not your problem anymore. If someone needs you there all the time to be ok with themselves, that's their problem to solve. You cannot solve everyone's problem.
I tried. IT DOES NOT WORK.

Ufff. Intense chapter, right?
I feel like I said everything I had to say.

I must admit, this has been a lovely chapter to write—perhaps because I really enjoyed opening up. It captured one of the most important realizations I've had this year and I really hope you enjoyed it too.

Now I have to go. They are literally kicking me out of a *you-are-not-allowed-for-more-than-two-hours-with-a-laptop* type of cafeteria in the center of Athens. Greeks are weird.

Hasta luego.

The next chapter will be an interesting one.

Chapter 6:
Why in this world, you need a CODE?

Being a software developer or not, does not matter. We all need a CODE.
And when I say a code I don't just mean a code of principles, code of morals or code of values. Like *"don't play with humans' emotions"* or *"don't screw people over to climb a corporate ladder"* etc. We know all that. And if you are a millennial, and still don't know about all that, then I don't know, you need more than just the code I am referring to. Besides, we have already mentioned some of the most important virtues to have in 2025 and beyond, earlier in this book. So, we are not going to repeat ourselves. That's for the politicians.

Thus, when I say code, I mean a list of things that you are willing to accept from others and things that you define as acceptable behavior from your end. I believe it will be very challenging to navigate the coming decades without one.

Of course, I do not want you to just write down a list of 5-10 things that you indulge in, post them on your fridge, remain close-minded forever and cut out anyone who might not follow your code blindly. At the end of the day, this code needs to be tested. This code came into existence because it was tested and failed. By you or by others.

Let's now dive in.

This is a book written by me so, of course ***CODE*** is not just a word.
But an acronym. It is C.O.D.E!

Allow me to give you a bit more context just to set the scene before we dive deeper into the topic.

For something to come into existence there needs to be a reason, or in this case, a reasoning process. From my own life experiences, I can tell you that coming up with this C.O.D.E, has been a looooong process inspired by maaaaany fuckups. I did not come up with it because I am so perfect, or because I have done everything right and everyone should be as perfect as I am. FAR FROM IT. Actually, for the exact opposite reason. Because I have made many mistakes and after a while I realised that doing or avoiding specific things in life has a huge effect on me. Occasionally a positive one but most often a negative. You should keep in mind that this code of mine is not the bible. You don't have to follow it. You don't even have to like it.
If the very idea of a "code" or a "set of rules" already gives you bad vibes, then close the book and go do something that brings you good ones. Seriously. No hard feelings.

…

Now if you are still reading, good. We can continue.

So…first things first!

When it comes to me, there is no key to my heart.
But instead, there is a C.O.D.E to my heart.

And when I say 'to my heart' I do not necessarily mean it only from a romantic point of view. I'm talking about human connection—about resonance, mutual interest, and the willingness to build a relationship. I'm not sure if this barrier, limitation, or requirement I have in order to truly feel connected with someone is good, bad, messed up, or just a logical byproduct of living in a burned-out society—but it is what it is. And if you have seen the movie, *The Irishman*, with Robert De Niro & Joe Pesci, you know what *"It is what it is"* really means—haha, I love quoting things from movies and songs, I've been doing it since I was a teenager.

So yeah, unfortunately or fortunately, being a good person, having core values and doing good in general, are not enough for me. What a bold statement, I know. But based on what I observe, it seems like these things are not enough for most of us anymore either. They are important, of course, but they are not sufficient.

Maybe, if I'm lucky enough to grow old, I'll come back and read these words and say, *"I was such a foolish kid—overthinking everything. The simple things were enough all along."*
And honestly, I hope that's exactly what happens. Because if I can say that one day, it probably means I lived a good life. Right?
Nonetheless, it is true.
In today's world, some of our needs when it comes to human relationships have changed dramatically. We require more from others. Due to the fact that we have evolved intellectually? I don't know, maybe we just want more. Perhaps, they made us want more so they can keep us from being satisfied and fulfilled in life. Maybe they already won. Maybe not. Maybe I watched too many classic gangster movies or listened to too much hip-hop music, and this CODE of mine is just a byproduct of all that. Who knows?

What I'm trying to say is this: from what I observe in others, building meaningful human relationships requires more than just good intentions—it takes a thoughtful blend of certain virtues, and a sense of balance. After all, isn't that what life is really about?
Improving the relationship you have with yourself, and the ones you build with others.
So, I'm going to take my chances and use the rest of this chapter to explain how and why I created this C.O.D.E., what it actually is, and why I believe we truly need it—in 2025 and beyond.

(PS: I hope I manage to publish this book in 2025. If not, I got a lot of editing to do haha)

The reasons I created this idea of the C.O.D.E., and the process behind it, are actually quite simple. I just followed my instinct. If I did something I wasn't proud of—something that left me feeling shame, regret, or had a negative impact on myself or someone else—I added it to the code. And just to be clear, I'm not talking about what society told me to feel guilty or ashamed about. This isn't about suppressing emotions or avoiding discomfort. That kind of avoidance only leads to trouble.
I'm referring to actions, emotions, situations, and behaviors that genuinely mattered to me. I'd look in the mirror and ask: Am I proud of this? Do I respect myself when I act this way? If the answer was no, I paid attention to the uncomfortable feeling generated by that particular behavior and noted it down.
That's what this C.O.D.E. is—it's the thin line that helps you define, in your own terms, whether the answer to that inner question is a "yes" or a "no."

Let me give you an example before we start explaining the actual meaning of the C.O.D.E. Let's say, the first letter C in the acronym means CAT. You know, that curious fluffy creature. Which it doesn't. But let's say it does for the sake of this example. Now the way to find out the answer to one of your deep inner questions would be something like this: *'Does this behavior, or this particular action affect my **CAT** in a positive way?'*.
Or it could be like *'What I did last night made my **CAT** sad. Am I ok with that?'*. I assume you get the gist by now. You ask a question for a particular letter of the acronym.
Basically the C.O.D.E is about things, principles, personality traits, your character, and how your actions or any kind of behavior, physical or mental, might affect it. The C.O.D.E does not represent actions. The code is not a step-by-step bullshit guide. The C.O.D.E answers the question if an action should be initiated or not. The C.O.D.E is nothing like:

- **C**lean Your Room
- **O**wn A House
- **D**rive Slow
- **E**at Well

No. That's the *7-Steps-To-Success* kind of bullshit, which I personally don't like at all. The 'Wake up at 5AM, medidate, journal for 30 mins, have a cold shower then drink a smoothie' and all that kind of crap. If anyone tells you that you have to repeat a VERY SPECIFIC ACTION every day in your whole life in order to get something, run away from them. I am not saying that consistency does not matter though.
Consistency is key, 100%. However consistency does not mean that you should follow the exact same script and expect a guaranteed outcome. Consistency is about not deviating from your core principles, from your life's purpose, **on a daily basis.**
Consistency is not about you doing the same tasks always in order to achieve a goal. But instead, it is more like an abstract concept, a blueprint, and not a step-by-step guide. It is more about repeating actions that take you towards your life's purpose on a daily basis, and not the tasks themselves. Hope that made sense.

If you remember, in the previous chapter, we talked about Input and Output. This fits perfectly to this concept as well. Controlling outcomes never works unless you are a pure

function in a Haskell—programming language—-driven world. And fortunately, we humans are not pure functions. That's why step-by-step guides in order to achieve a goal usually do not work. Because they make the false assumption that putting the exact same input over and over again, the output will be guaranteed.
For example, you can tell yourself that tomorrow you will invest 100$ and you stick to it. You make the investment. In that way you build discipline around taking actions. But you do not do it based on the assumption that investing 100$ tomorrow will make you 1,000$ in 2 days. This will most likely not work. Hope you get the idea.

Let's look at another example. If your goal in life is to always learn new things and become more knowledgeable, telling yourself: 'I need to read 25 pages, on a daily basis, at 6AM', might work for a week. But then you will probably ditch it. Life does not work like that. And it shouldn't. Because if you could so easily plan and live your whole life, life would be boring as fuck. So, what do I mean instead? If your goal is to become more knowledgeable every day what you can do is something like: Don't read crap, i.e the news on mainstream media. Instead, reading an article every day is a better task. Or reading about whatever topic pops up in your head in a given moment without defining in advance what that topic should or should not be. One day you might be in the mood for reading about business or science. Another day you might just want to read Bukowski and cry in the corner while sipping wine.

Life is always in flux. You can't predict what your mind will be drawn to at any given moment. Trying to control that—trying to keep everything under your grasp—is where misery begins. Don't believe me? Ask Lao Tzu. Ask Epictetus, Alan Watts, or Krishnamurti. At the very least, trust *them*. Let go of the urge to control everything.

Now—before I reveal the full C.O.D.E., here's the technique I mentioned earlier, laid out clearly. Use each part of the acronym by asking yourself reflective questions like:

- Does this behavior or action positively impact my ____?
- What I did yesterday didn't serve my ____. Am I okay with that?

The blanks represent one of the elements in the C.O.D.E.

Simple as that.

Again, the C.O.D.E. is not the Bible. You're not required to apply it to every single thought or action. Allow yourself some flexibility. You can even change the entire C.O.D.E. if you want—swap out the words, redefine the core principles. Go ahead. Make it your own. The main point here is that you need a ***clearly defined thin line*** in life—a personal framework—that acts as the deciding factor for a yes or a no answer to the big questions. C.O.D.E is that thin line. Without one you will always be lost in life. At least in my not-so-humble opinion.

Let's begin. Shall we?

C Is For Curiosity.

Curiosity is one of the best things in life. Having it though, will not necessarily give you everything that the society praises or requires in order to categorize you as successful. However, it will give you one important thing: a less boring life. Boring means many things to many people, but what I personally mean by *boring* is basically a life that will eventually lead you back to conforming again. A life that will not be interesting enough to you, a life that will not motivate you enough to take action. And sooner or later you will be back to: *'hmm this is not for me'* and *'hmm that's what everyone is doing so I should do it too'*. Think curiosity like a muscle. You practice a lot for it to get stronger. Yes, some people have it in them since birth without the need to push themselves much, but trust me, no one has it in abundance. You have to practice.

What I mean by practicing curiosity is learning when to take action—and when not to. Think of it like the inversion mental model, which suggests that to achieve a goal, you don't always need to focus on what you *should* do to get there. Instead, think in reverse. For example: *"What should* ***I avoid doing*** *today to save $50?"*. And analyze the ideas that come up. Go deeper. That kind of mindset.

In addition, there is a side effect in the process of acquiring knowledge which feeds and cultivates curiosity. The more things you learn, the more you realise that there are so many things you don't know. That builds curiosity. Yes, it can also bring anxiety or even

make you feel discouraged, but that usually happens when you're thinking too far ahead—telling yourself there's a fixed amount of knowledge you need to acquire in order to be smart, successful, or "good enough". Well… ***ditch*** that thought once and for all. There's no such thing as ***a fixed amount of knowledge to be acquired*** in a fixed amount of time—or a fixed amount of anything, for that matter—that will suddenly earn you the label you so desperately seek. Life is constantly in flux. Everyone is different, lives a different life, and moves at a different pace. Yes, we all have 24 hours in a day, but we don't perceive those hours the same way, we don't act the same way, or aim for the same things during those hours. And thank goodness for that—otherwise, the world would be a very, very boring place. If you don't believe me, trust neuroscientist *David Eagleman*, who's done extensive work on how the brain perceives time.

Let's face it though. Unfortunately, or fortunately, depending on how you see it, some level of curiosity comes from within. For me for example, since I remember myself I have always been curious. Many things have caught my attention over the years, without me really pushing for it. But sometimes, the things you're naturally curious about aren't recognized as valuable by today's society. Society tends to associate genius with curiosity about math, science, or mastering 4D chess with one eye closed since childhood. But those aren't the only forms of brilliance—not even close. It's just that society loves to push a narrow narrative about what it means to be "gifted." And if you don't fit that narrative, you're made to feel like you're not special. But once again—fuck what society tells you.

When I say curious, I mean curious about whatever. Travelling, reading, learning something new, feeling something, trying something, seeing something or someone. Anything you can think of. From how wave energy moves in the ocean, to, I don't know, that crazy sex position your friend told you about last night over a few drinks and you want to try it out. Anything. It does not have to be fancy, or seen by others as intellectual. Just whatever caught your attention. Go for it, search about it, learn more about it and most importantly, understand it. And then, apply it in your life. Only consuming information won't teach you much. Applying that information though, experimenting with it and taking action in general will teach you a ton. 1 hour of taking action is worth more than 20 hours of reading. I think a Youtuber said that. Can't recall the name.

Now what to avoid to keep curiosity intact?

Binge-watching videos on Instagram or TikTok probably won't do any good to your curiosity. You should avoid those habits. Or at least minimize them. You can apply the questioning technique we talked about earlier— i.e *'Does this habit or action affect my* ***Curiosity*** *level in a positive way?'* —and you will eventually see the most beneficial pattern to follow.

Aaaaaand… I think that's it for ***Curiosity***.

Does it make sense to you now? I hope so.
All in all, you have to be curious in a world where burn-out and fake productivity are rewarded and recognized as ambition. You have to remain curious when social media reels weaken everyone's attention span by the minute. Seriously, you need to remain curious. This world needs more curious people.

Let's move on to the next bit of the C.O.D.E.

O Is For Ownership & Openness

Yes! O, is for two words, not just one.
Why not? It is my C.O.D.E. and I can do whatever the fuck I want. Sue me.

Let's explain one word at a time.

I will start with *openness* because it is the easiest to explain. As mentioned earlier, the C.O.D.E is not the Bible. Apart from the Bible, nothing is a Bible.
Openness, like curiosity and the rest of the pillars of the C.O.D.E, is a muscle. And it needs practice. For example you cannot expect to sit with the same people for decades, watch and listen to the same piece of news for decades, be a dogmatic person for decades and expect that your openness remains fit and healthy. That's not how it works. You have to test everything—ideas, concepts, beliefs, opinions—both your own and those of others.

You should also reflect on your own actions and see when and where you made mistakes. And think for yourself, *if I make mistakes why do I so blindly judge others for their own mistakes?* Should I be more open? You should. Me too.

Often people say that openness and having an open mind are signs of intelligence and that you have such a useful tool in your possession if you are open-minded.
To me, having an open mind is just the only logical thing to do. And I define as logical, a thing that when you do, it is meant to have a positive outcome for you and for others. Weird definition I know, but I try to be as open as possible too. Nonetheless, in our world today, when people say 'logical' I don't think they mean what I just said.

Why do I consider openness as a logical virtue to have then?

Because, the world is constantly moving. And I am not even referring to the speed of technological advancements. I'm referring to human-only related stuff. People change, situations change, views of the world change. It is not easy to survive in this world if you are not comfortable with changing. And it might even lead to your demise. Which is bad for you. (I guess). And also, your demise would make people close to you feel sad. Therefore, based on our definition of logical, not having openness would be illogical. Right? Big apologies to my cousin Socrates for this terrible reasoning haha! But come on, you get my point.

We should all keep our minds and hearts open. Otherwise, in my not-so-humble opinion, we're missing out—big time—on what life has to offer. So, all in all, stay open.

Now let's move on to the next word that the letter O represents.

What do I mean by *Ownership* you may ask? Well, it is pretty self explanatory. I mean that you should go take a loan from a bank and buy yourself a house. Make yourself a real estate owner. It is as simple as that.

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Of course I am JOKING.

In our case, ownership has to do with *'owning your own life'*. Making sure that your actions, behaviors, and the patterns you choose to follow are yours. Of course this is very hard to achieve. I mean it is quite hard to live life completely free and solely driven by your own will. Entire books have explored the idea that free will might not even exist. Take *Behave* and *Determined* by Robert Sapolsky, for example—a brilliant neuroscientist who's done outstanding work on the subject. But here's my point: at the very least, make choices that satisfy *you*, not just others. And when I say satisfy *you*, I mean it—satisfy yourself, *for* yourself, not to gain approval, praise, or validation from anyone else.

There is a famous quote from Jean-Paul Sartre – you know, the guy with the weird eye which for some reason made him look 10 times smarter — that says: *'Man is nothing else but what he makes of himself'*. I totally dig that quote. Nobody is coming to save us, we have to define our own path simply because if we wake up one day and realize that we don't like our lives anymore, at least it was our choice and we can now do something about it. Imagine living 10 years for someone else, and then realize that you don't like that life anymore and you did it only because someone else told you it was right for you. Now imagine the same, but instead, you made the choice of living that life. Which one hurts more? Don't get confused, both will hurt, but the pain will be different.

Take ownership. Take responsibility. I think it teaches us a lot about ourselves when we recognize what we have done wrong, or when we make big decisions for our future. If you always blame others, or you outsource your life's most important decisions to society, to family members, or to a friend's opinion then you are not living life well. Big statement I know, but feels right no? For me, one way that has worked pretty well so far, is to never seek advice from anyone whose life I don't admire in one way or another. Now if that also includes family members, childhood friends or friends in general that's ok! You don't have to listen to them either. They probably mean well for you, but they don't know what that *'well for you'* really means. You are the one who knows that. You and only you.

But Tasos, what If I don't have anyone else to ask for advice you may ask?
Well, there is this thing called The Internet. Have you ever heard of it? Good. Use it. Or message me, I would love to hear from you. And I will try to be objective, I promise.

Just imagine this: when you're 80, how would it feel to look back on your life and know — with absolute certainty — that you lived it entirely on your own terms?

Don't do it for you. Do it for the 80-years old version of you, that is full of wrinkles, smokes cigars and drinks wine by the patio while enjoying the amazing view.

Now, let's move on.

D Is For Discipline

For the millionth time, when I say discipline I don't mean anything extreme like wake up at 5 AM, do 100 pushups, take a cold shower, meditate for an hour, deep work for 2 hours, no coffee and you will be the most successful person on the planet. No. Even the 'waking up at 5AM' part, I personally cannot do. When I say discipline, I am referring to the ancient meaning of the word, the one that has to do with self-control and consistency.

After reading many philosophical books, from both ancient and modern times, I strongly believe in the following quote: *Freedom is…having discipline.*
Read that a couple of times before we continue and make sure you get it.

…

In this life, in 2025, sometimes you have to go with the flow and sometimes you have to plan and act strategically. What you *can't* afford to be is a leaf blown aimlessly by the wind, drifting wherever it takes you. That simply won't work. Or it probably won't end well. In my not-so-humble opinion at least. Avoiding such a situation though, is easier said than done, especially in the 21st century when everything and everybody aims to steal your attention, and pretty much convert you into a non-disciplined creature. Maybe in times like this, discipline is more important than ever.

You have probably heard of a book called *Atomic Habits* by James Clear. Very mainstream for a guy like me I know (joking), but it has indeed some solid and quite useful ideas inside. In a nutshell it argues that small, consistent changes compound over time to create powerful, lasting improvements in your life. Somewhere in between those words, the

word discipline is hidden. Discipline is about knowing your purpose, what motivates you in life, and on a daily basis, take a ***no-matter-how-small*** action that serves that purpose. In addition to that, we can argue that Pareto's Law fits very well here too. If you manage to be disciplined 80% of the time, you can take a more relaxed, laid back approach for the 20% that's left.

Personally, I am a quite disciplined guy. Sometimes it is hard for me too to remain consistent, but I have discipline hardcoded as my soul's Operational System. DiscipLinux–haha, the ones who get this will love it!
It comes from within, I don't really have to push it. Maybe it's because I am lucky, I don't know. Maybe it is because I did martial arts from an early age, and discipline is probably what every coach in martial arts talks about all the time. You learn it in a kind of a brutal way though, it is not always flowers. Actually, in martial arts, it is never flowers. But that's an irrelevant topic.

Without a purpose, without a goal in life, discipline is hard to accomplish. And when I say purpose or goal, I don't mean things like: Travel 50 countries in 6 months or Build 6 apps in a week or Make 1M$ by the age of 30. No, nothing like that. These kinds of goals are not bad per se, but they are not strong enough to keep you motivated. And it is highly likely that they won't be achieved by every person who sets them. Why? Because they don't depend only on the input. They are not pure IO functions. Remember when we discussed about Input/Output earlier in this book? Good, good. When I talk about purpose and goals I'm talking about deeper things, bigger things, things that talk to your soul. Things like *'I want to live a life full of knowledge and passion'* or *'live so I can help others evolve'* or *'focus on making creative art'* etc. These are the goals I'm referring to.

Often, people who are disciplined are misinterpreted by the so-called *normies*. For instance, if you always repeat some things in your daily life then they might call you 'a robot'. Or if you don't necessarily want to let yourself loose in a social event then you might hear comments like *'come on, you should live a little'*. Or maybe you don't want to stay up till 3 AM because you have things to do the next day and everyone is like *'Oh you are so old and boring'*. Or my favorite, when you don't drink alcohol anymore simply because you don't want to and then people call you a *'weirdo'*, *so extreme*, or you *don't know how to enjoy life*. No need to give more examples, you get my point. Well, what should you do in such

cases you ask?Well, I will quote Joe Pesci from the movie *The Irishman* again, *"Fuck'em"*. Haha! Nah, you shouldn't be that harsh with people!
If you really feel good about your life choices though, and you are inspired by the way you do things, it is super safe, and potentially wise, to ignore everyone and keep doing your thing. Yeap! It is totally fine to do that.

I'm pretty sure you've figured it out—some of those social situations I mentioned have happened to me. And I'm guessing they've happened to you too. In my not-so-humble opinion, people are capable of finding many ways to justify their desperate need to escape a life they don't enjoy. Often, people are surprised, shocked, or call you a maniac simply because you stick to what you enjoy. I really don't like it when people do that, and to be honest with you, it pisses me off—haha! People tend to cover up their need for escape with phrases like, *"Oh, just this once,"* or *"It's only one time,"* or *"Just to relax."* What they don't realize is that they keep saying these things over and over, for years. And we know that habits are built in an accumulative way. And the 'just for once' has turned into a lifetime. It is like when people say they *'need holidays'* or when they say *'work life balance'* and this kind of stuff. For me, these are just excuses we tell ourselves to comfort us for living lives that do not fully satisfy us. I mean, what the fuck with this *work life balance* shit? Are you one person from 9 o'clock till 5PM, and a completely different one from 6 until you fall asleep? Are you joking? Anyway, this topic could be a whole book on its own.

To wrap up the discipline section, maybe it would be wise to share a couple of techniques on how to integrate discipline into our lives.
What I usually do is define smaller tasks that I need to do during the day that will make me feel fulfilled and will not distract me from my ***life's bigger purpose***. Which, if I haven't defined already, looks something like this: *learn new things, interact with interesting people, be active, both from a body and mind perspective, do good and improve this world in some way, ideally find love, and most importantly, create more than I consume.* That's my purpose as of today.

Naming small tasks and spending minutes on them always works better for me. Saying things like I need to spend 5 hours to complete this, usually doesn't work. Unless, I don't know, it is a period during which I'm trying to build and launch an app and have to remain very focused for long hours. Other than that, I split my time in 15 or 30 mins intervals. Again, this might sound super boring to you, and it might be, but it works for

me. So I'm sharing it. After all, what the fuck is there to do ? Sit all day, gossip & watch the news? Fuck that. Writing things down in a clear way also helps me a lot. I hate it when I have to plan my tomorrow's tasks from the previous night, but honestly every time I do it, it helps a lot. I spend like 30-60 seconds doing it though to write them down. MAX. Not even a second more. Otherwise I get bored.

Anyway, we spent a bit more time on the topic of discipline — but that's only because it's such a crucial part of life. Think about it: the people who make comments, judge you, or criticize your behavior — are they still living the same way they always have and still complain about it? Are they surrounded by people they gossip about, or are they stuck in the same job they constantly say they hate? Are they making the same plans year after year without ever breaking free from that cycle?
If so, that's ok. Nothing is wrong with that. But if this is not the life you want, just ***ignore them.*** Do your own thing.
In a world full of copycats, choose to be different. Everyone is free to live however they want. I'm not judging anyone for their life choices — and neither should you. And honestly, neither should they.

Let's move on to the last bit of the C.O.D.E .

E Is For Experimentation

Did you know that from age 0 to 7, the brain functions like a sponge, mostly in theta waves — a hypnotic state where it absorbs experiences without filtering? Literally it is the most creative state of the brain. Without making judgements, without mental models filtering anything. These years are the time when we write the Operating System of our own minds. During that age, we form up to 95% of the subconscious beliefs, emotional patterns, and mental models that shape our adult behavior. 95%. Can you imagine that? When you are 30 years old, a lot of mental models, thinking patterns and beliefs you have about very fundamental things in life, formed during the age 0 to 7. CRAZY! Right?

Now that is a powerful and dangerous thing. Because if you went through bad situations during that age, a lot of bad things are embedded into your mind's functionality. That does not mean you cannot break free, but you are going to have a more difficult time

than the people who did not go through such bad situations. Fortunately, there is this beautiful capability of our brains called **neuroplasticity**. Our mind's power to rewire itself, to break old patterns and sculpt new ones through thought, action, and new experiences. That's where *experimentation* comes in.

Let's put our neuroscientist hat on.

From a scientific perspective, **neuroplasticity** refers to the brain's ability to change its structure and function in response to experience, learning, and behavior. This rewiring occurs when neurons (brain cells) form new synaptic connections or when they strengthen existing ones through repeated activation. When you practice a skill, focus on a thought, or experience something emotionally significant, certain neural pathways become more active. Over time, as most neuroscience books say, ***"neurons that fire together wire together"*** — meaning repeated usage strengthens these pathways, making the behavior or thought pattern more automatic. Aka, becomes second nature. Simultaneously, unused connections weaken and fade, a process called synaptic pruning, allowing the brain to adapt efficiently to new environments, habits, or beliefs. This is the biological foundation behind habit change, learning, and even emotional healing. How cool is that, right?

Now removing the scientist hat and putting on the artist hat.

If you want to change your life in some way, you have to try new things. And no, I don't mean the easy solution that most people say when they talk about 'trying new things'. I don't want you to go take all the drugs you didn't take in your 20s, in your 30s or 40s. No. It could have some positives, but why should you do that? You have every chemical, every emotion you want to recreate for yourself in you already. Be healthy. I'm also not talking from a consumption perspective only. Yeah, you could go learn something new, read a new book, go to a new place, talk to new people, but that's not the only way.
I am also talking from a creation perspective. Create something. It does not matter what it is, just make it. Do things that you haven't done before that will teach you something about yourself, your personality, the way you think and your own limits. Maybe you are crazier than you thought. Who knows haha!

Unfortunately, in today's society, doing something new is seen as a chore or as a task-to-be-completed-and-then-ditched. And if the reward is not monetary we usually do not stay motivated for long enough to start a new thing. I do not blame us though. After all, all this phobia is a result of the debt-based economy we talked about earlier in this book. And we will talk about how problematic it is that we need to monetize everything, later on.
Let's stick to the ***experimentation*** for now.
I see it when people get excited about starting something new. There is a fire in their eyes. But most often, they end up not continuing, or not even starting at times.
Due to life? Due to the voice in their heads telling them that it won't work? I don't know. The irony is that, when it comes to jobs in our society's system, we keep doing the same tasks for years—often without wanting to—and call it expertise, only to end up bored, unfulfilled, and depressed. But when it is about things that deeply excite us? We ditch them first thing, when they don't bring the monthly paycheck. What a messy little world, right?

But don't worry — as we'll discuss shortly, there are ways to fix this. And we millennials are better equipped than everyone else to clean up this mess.

So, all in all, ***try new things***. Especially the ones that talk to your soul. The ones that for some reason feel like they should be tried out. And make sure you don't ditch them too early. Stick to them for a while, even if they don't give back instant gratification. Some scientific research says that it takes around 10-14 days of repeating an activity to realise if you really enjoy it. Don't trust me. Trust science.

We finally reached the end of this chapter. I hope you learned something, you loved something and you hated something about it. I hope you see the importance of integrating such a C.O.D.E in our lives today. No need to follow it blindly. Feel free to tweak it, add to it, remove parts, or even change it entirely if you like. Just make sure that whatever code you choose to live by, ***you don't break it.***

Moving on to Part III of this book. The darker one. Boohoo!

Part III:

One Brain, One Ego & Many Voices

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Chapter 7:
What are the voices in your head?

"It is not things themselves that disturb us, but our judgments about them."

— **Epictetus**, *Enchiridion*

Epictetus understood life more profoundly than anyone else who left any writings behind. At least in my opinion. This quote from his *Enchiridion*—if it isn't the most abstract yet accurate distillation of the human experience ever written—then it undoubtedly comes remarkably close. Maybe that could be the one abstract sentence that catches the meaning of the whole world that I talked about earlier in this book. Who knows?

Over the past four years, I've made a serious effort to understand what's going on inside my head. Why do I think the thoughts I think? Why do some thoughts arise seemingly out of nowhere? Why do certain thoughts impact me more than others? I've spent the last decade living abroad—seeing new places, learning new things, becoming a completely different person—and yet, somehow, 90% of my negative thoughts remain exactly the same. Why? Well, in this chapter, I want to share a collection of concepts, tools, and realizations that, in my view, represent the most profound and transformative knowledge I've ever encountered. Knowledge that actually answered the questions I had. I consider those concepts both fascinating and powerful—not just because they offer deep insight into the human psyche, but because they've tangibly helped me get better and navigate life with more clarity and resilience. I mean, what more could one ask for?

Obviously, I did not find these answers alone. I searched them by myself, however, the answers were given to me by some of the greatest thinkers in psychology, psychiatry, neuroscience, psychoanalysis & cognitive science. Most of them I have never met, due to the fact that most of them are unfortunately dead, but I had the luck to come across their

names, read their work and get a taste of their intelligence. For the ones who have truly helped me and I had the privilege to meet in person—like my therapist (even if she doesn't like that label), and a few close friends who genuinely enjoy diving deeper into such topics, I want to say *thank you*. I'm deeply grateful for the conversations, the presence, and the reflections we've shared. Interacting with you has not only expanded my mind, but also made the journey far more meaningful.

Before we begin, I want to say that the most fulfilling thing about this chapter is that it includes all the tools you need, if you really want to understand yourself and how to break patterns that no longer serve you. It took me years to discover, understand and apply all these concepts to my life. I can explain them to you in the clearest way possible, but remember, if you don't apply them to your own life, they won't do much. A tool is only useful when you actually use it. Otherwise, it's just another object whose potential goes to waste.

What are these tools, concepts and realisations you are talking about Tasos, you may ask?

Let's list some of them:

- Individual Reality
- Inner Critic & Inner Dialogue
- Projections
- The Observer Is The Observed (Physics vs Psychology)
- The Shadow & The Persona (Carl Jung)
- Ego vs Superego (Freud & Jung)
- The Ideal Image

Even listing those concepts one by one gives me goosebumps—truly. They are that fascinating, that powerful. No amount of wealth, fame, or social status can bring us closer to a better life than genuinely understanding these ideas and recognizing them within ourselves. You'll soon see that they're all deeply interconnected. But simply defining them as terms won't be enough. To grasp their true weight, we need real-life context. That's why I'll be using my own experiences as a lens—to communicate their significance in a way that's vivid and personal.

Interestingly, as I am writing this chapter, I'm sitting at the dining table in my grandma's house in the center of Athens, and my parents are here too. I'm with my headphones on and in the background I hear their chatter. All the inner critics, the love, the insecurities, the dogmas, the subconscious forces that I can now recognize how they have shaped my mind. I can hear them and see them right in front of me. It feels like the projector of my psyche is displaying all my complexes as holograms. Haha, so interesting. They are all so cute. Love them deeply.

Understanding these concepts—and identifying them within your own psyche—is, in my not-so-humble opinion, the only true path to a more fulfilling, calmer, and ultimately happier life. And when I say identifying them I actually mean it. Write things down, with pen and paper, explicitly state what something is and why it is affecting you so much. But don't worry, more on that later.

One last thing to mention before we dive into all the concepts is that I'm not claiming that the way I perceive or integrate all these concepts into my life is the best way, the only way, or even the *right* way. My goal is not to bombard you with scientific terminology just to act smart and knowledgeable. Everyone is free to do whatever she/he likes with all the info I will share. It is just that, my way is the way that helped **me** — and something in my gut tells me it will help you too. That's why I'm sharing everything.

Let's go.

Individual Reality

The idea that each one of us experiences a different reality is not just a philosophical idea—it is an idea backed by science. Neuroscience, quantum physics, and the social science of psychology, all support this view. Every day, we often hear phrases like, *"Oh, him? He lives in his own world—just ignore him."*.
Even if it sounds like just another thing people say, there's some truth in it. Each person really does live in a reality shaped by their own mind.

We don't experience reality directly—we experience a **filtered and predicted version** of it, generated by our own brains. According to neuroscientist David Eagleman—who I

have previously mentioned in this book—the brain takes in a limited amount of sensory data and fills in the gaps using memory, expectation, and context. In essence, we're not perceiving the world as it is, but as the brain *expects* it to be. Fascinating right?
We are constantly filling gaps.
Our experience of reality is pretty much a guess, not a raw feed.
I cannot recall right now, but a couple of years ago, I watched a documentary on Youtube that was explaining how a time lag takes place, a small delay, that occurs when we actually see the world with our own naked eye. The documentary was basically saying that it takes time for light to travel and reach our eyes, which confirms that no matter what we see in this world, we're always seeing it with a slight delay.
In other words, we're always a little late, haha.
What we perceive has already happened — whether by fractions of a second, milliseconds, or however long it takes. Unfortunately I do not remember the name of the documentary and I cannot find it right now. If I recall it, I will include it at the end of this book where I will list references to all the resources mentioned in this book.

Now let me use as an example, something that happened to me almost a year ago when I was in Barcelona.

Recalling a memory…

It is just another Sunday in 2024. I am at my place in the center of Barcelona and I am chilling in the living room. I'm really upset because I'm trying to write a song on my guitar and I can't figure out the lyrics. It is around 4PM. All of a sudden, the drummer from my music group, who is also a friend of mine, sent me an audio on Whatsapp. He asked me how I am and if I have any plans. He had his mother visiting at that time if I'm not mistaken and they were spending some time together outside of Barcelona. Long story short, my friend ended his audio message with these exact words, *'...I will be THERE by 6PM, so talk to you soon'.*
As it turned out, the word 'THERE' meant a completely different thing to both of us. Without thinking too much about it, almost an hour later I realized I would not finish the freaking song, so I put my headphones on and went for a long walk. I basically went from Eixample to Pedralbes on foot. I'm not sure if you have been to Barcelona and if you know the city very well, but Pedralbes is a really nice neighborhood to walk in and it is filled with

nature. It was quite a long walk, so I arrived a few minutes after 6PM. Then all of a sudden, I saw another message from my friend saying, *'Come downstairs, I'm outside your house, let's go grab a beer'* . *I* was a bit surprised, because in my head I did not expect my friend would come to my place at 6PM. I thought when he said *there,* he meant Barcelona in general. At that moment I was like at least 1 hour away, on foot, sitting at a park listening to a podcast. Which is exactly what I replied to my friend via text. I told him that I won't be there soon enough to meet him, and that he should not wait for me. He replied to me *'Ok, talk soon'*.

End of memory recall.

Now, where am I going with all this? Well, a few minutes later, after we chatted, I thought, *"Hmm, my friend Tommy, what a nice guy. I mean, he has his family here and he still wanted and managed to find time to meet me on a Sunday. That's cool"*. On the other hand, which I found out the next day, when we met for a jam session, is that Tommy went down a completely different thinking spiral. He started thinking *"Why did he not want to meet me after all? Probably he is pissed off about something. Did I do something to him? He was probably upset, and did not even want to come down and meet me. I don't think he was even out of his house."* . We laughed big time the next day when we talked about this ahah!

Now you can see how two people experienced the same situation but perceived it in completely different ways. Don't worry — Tommy and I are still friends to this day. This was just one example (among many in my life — and probably in yours too) of how easily we can misinterpret reality. Especially via texting! If you remember the chapter about my "*aha*" moment — when I realized that using messaging apps for 5 particular things wasn't the wisest choice — you can now see how deeply these tools can shape, and sometimes distort, the reality each of us experiences. I mean faceless interactions and asynchronicity can quickly distort communication. Add to all of this the fact that no two brains are alike and that each of us is wired by a unique combination of genetics, experiences, trauma, and learning. Then you can quickly see why this world is so chaotic. I mean if we all see different realities, what's really real?

Makes a woman, or a man, think.

Inner Critic

Probably most of us, if not all of us, have a little voice in our head that never shuts the fuck up. You know which one I am talking about, the one that never really says anything good to you. Right?

You have probably come across terms like inner dialogue, voice in the head, superego etc. Terms coined by Freud, Jung and others. I know there are so many respectful scientists and researchers who have done great work on these topics, but I'm specifically focusing on Freud and Jung, because they are the ones I have mostly read about. So what is that inner critic I am referring to? Why do I dedicate a whole section in a chapter about it?

For 2 reasons mainly:

1. Because nearly all of us experience this ***'inner critic voice'*** —and knowing why it's there and what it tends to say is key to truly understanding yourself.
2. Because most of the resources out there—apart from books exclusively focusing on the topic which not everyone reads due to their high complexity— share only a top-level explanation of what that voice says and why it is there in the first place.

From my experience—and the way I understand the inner critic—it's closely related, if not synonymous, with the Superego, a concept introduced by Freud, which we'll explore shortly. The inner critic's voice is not my voice judging me. Nor your voice judging you. The inner critic's voice is other people's voices. Of those who from early childhood, till very early adulthood, had a big impact on ourselves. It can be a voice of a mother, a father, a sibling, a friend, a friend's parent, a teacher, or anyone we perceived during those formative years as an authority figure. Or let's just call it, a *special person* that we had to listen to.
For all of us, these voices are different, and they say different things. But they have one similar effect. They generate reactions from our side. Reactions that take the form of strong emotional charge and engagement in mental conflict— aka negative thinking spirals.

Undoubtedly, these voices and what they are saying are not random. You did not come up with them because you are super weird or anything like that. No. These voices are the echo of the voices of real people during your childhood and early adulthood. Voices that you actually listened to in real life.
Maybe things you heard in your room when you came back from school, or in the living room right before you head off to bed. Perhaps in the kitchen at a family dinner on a Sunday or in a car while going on a family trip. All these voices remain loud as an echo inside your head, on repeat, ALL THE TIME. However, that's also good news, right? I mean they are there for a reason, you are not completely crazy, haha! So, if there is a reason, it means that we can follow a reasoning process, and answer this kind of questions regarding them:

- How did they come into existence?
- Who do they represent?
- What are they saying?

Of course, rationalizing about all these voices and the effects on us cannot make the problem fully disappear. However, becoming aware of them—and thinking critically about their influence—is the first logical step toward reducing their impact. If you ever studied logic, you know that you are halfway solving a problem simply by identifying its existence and its components. That is the beauty of doing all this inner work. Because you begin to realize that the monster under the bed is only a monster when you don't know how it looks. Once you face it, you see what it is, its parts, its reasons, its triggers. Everything. And it is not that scary.

I'll go into more detail about how my inner critic's voice sounds later in this book, after we explore the Ego vs. Superego. For now, the main goal regarding everything I've mentioned is this: if you're anything like me — and I'm sure you are in a way or another — you also have that inner voice. And that voice exists for a reason. It was shaped by people you know, saying things that still bother you for reasons you might not consciously understand — but deep down, you know.

I hope that makes sense and don't worry, we will explore all the reasons in the following pages.

Inner Dialogue

Now if we put our *Aristotle* hat on, we have to acknowledge the following: There wouldn't be something to be called 'Inner Critic' if there was no Inner Dialogue taking place. After all, who—or what—would the Inner Critic be criticizing in order to deserve the title *Critic* in the first place?
Am I right? Aristotle vibes only! Ahah!

We would not be able to identify, feel, listen to or any other verb that can describe this event of experiencing that inner voice, if there was no *inner dialogue* taking place. There is something else, **another voice**, call it **you**, call it your **ego** (I personally think it is the ego, and I will explain later why)—or call it whatever you feel like—that is answering to the inner critic's voice. And what is that other voice doing you may ask?
It is defending you. With everything it has.

The sole purpose of that other voice is to ensure that you, as a person, feel safe, feel understood, and—above all—feel seen exactly as the person you want to be seen as. **Be careful here:** not as the person you truly are, but as the version of yourself you want others to see— aka the *Ideal Image*, a concept which we will analyse shortly.

This inner dialogue exists only in our minds. It's not physically real—no one can see it or hear it. But that doesn't mean it isn't real at all. Why?
Even if others can't see it, you hear it, you feel it — and most importantly, you pour mental energy into it. In other words, you *spend* energy. And if you remember what we covered earlier in this book: your energy is precious precisely because it's limited. Every time you engage in that inner dialogue, you're drawing from that limited reserve. How? Well, the brain doesn't fully distinguish between real experiences and imagined ones — both light up similar neural circuits, release the same hormones, and stir up the same emotions. So having an argument in your head can leave you just as drained as if you had it in real life. Wild, isn't it?
That's what the inner dialogue is. Those 2 voices, of other people's and yours, arguing.

We will be mentioning the inner dialogue a lot from now on, that's why I spent some time explaining it to you. I hope it is clear. If not, read it again, it is very important.

Projections

Projections. The thing that is everywhere, done by everyone and fucks up everybody. The 'judgements' word from Epictetus's quote we discussed in the beginning of this chapter.

My doctor— I say doctor, because labels like therapist/psychoanalyst/psychiatrist/psychologist, she does not indulge—says that projection is something that we cannot completely remove from our lives. It is embedded in human nature. We cannot stop doing it, because if we did not project, we wouldn't be able to fall in love. Unfortunately though, it is often done in different contexts, not the love related one. You probably already heard the term projection and you can identify it every time you do it or others do it to you. Despite all that, I will explain what it is, and how I perceive it in a way that makes things easier for me. Not understanding projections can make your life very, VERY, difficult.

So what is a **Projection** you may ask?

According to Carl Jung, projection is when we unconsciously attribute parts of ourselves—often the ones we suppress or deny—to other people. And to make it a bit more practical, and less theoretical, it is basically when we are irritated by something that someone is doing, due to the fact that deep down, we know that we are capable of doing it too. Did I confuse you? Let me give you the explanation that *my doctor* gave to me—that is probably the best and most logical explanation anyone has ever given to me about Projections. *Spoiler alert:* My doctor rationalized it for me because she thinks that that's the best way for me to understand things better haha! Therapy is money well spent I tell you.

Now… to the explanation.

In the least scientific way possible, the prefrontal cortex — or **PFC** as we will call it from now on — is the front part of your brain responsible for thinking before acting. It's the part that allows for rational, conscious decision-making, and yes, it consumes real mental energy every time you use it. Depending on the **code of morals** we carry in our minds — what we believe is right or wrong, what we think we can or can't do — we rely on the PFC to help us make decisions.

Now, using the PFC is a bit like climbing a wall: If you choose to climb it (i.e., make a deliberate decision), it costs energy. But if you choose not to climb (i.e., take the easier, automatic path), you preserve energy — like staying seated in a comfy chair instead of going climbing. So **when we project** — whether by judging someone or getting pissed off by other people's actions — it's often because we recognize, consciously or not, that *we* went through the effort of holding back, and that *we* spent mental energy to restrain ourselves from doing something, while the other person didn't even think twice before doing it anyway. Don't get it twisted — it's something we know we're capable of doing too, which is probably why it irritates us even more. The difference is, we simply chose not to do it. Or maybe we didn't have the option or the opportunity to do so.
That's why projection can occur for both good and bad reasons. For example, if you see someone being judgemental, or talking in a bad way, or having a bad habit, you may judge that person because you know you could be doing that too and you chose not to. Or when you see another person doing something for instant gratification, but in the long run, you know it is a bad habit and you choose to not do it. And because of that, you judge the person for doing it— aka ***you project.***
The same applies to something *admirable*. If someone succeeded in something, took a risk that paid off, travelled, built a business, made a great invention or something like that, you will most likely envy that person if you are not living life as you want. You will judge, maybe you say that they got lucky or something. It is a similar thing, in a way. You project an unlived life. A choice you never made, an action which you never took.

That's **projection**. At least for me. Maybe someone else, a more well-read person, or a more advanced thinker has a more accurate definition of what projection is. For me though, that is the most helpful explanation. Why? Because it is the only explanation that clarifies the fact that projection **is not a personal hate towards you**. When someone projects something on you, IT IS NOT ABOUT YOU. Projections are insecurities we have ourselves and we just identify them in others. That's why this explanation brings me peace. When they judge me, they judge them, through me. Otherwise, I'd feel the need to win every battle, argument, or conversation—just to convince others, explain myself, or justify my actions. Which guess what? I did it for YEARS. Seriously, almost a decade. On autopilot. For fuck's sake. And I used to call myself smart, haha.

Of course, it's not an easy thing to do. I mean—during an argument, when everyone's heated and ready to explode—if someone projects something onto you, it's incredibly hard to pause and think, *"Okay, this is their insecurity. It's not about me. Let's breathe. Let's stay calm."*.
Naturally, that doesn't happen on its own.
But it has to happen.
You have to be the one to do it.
At first, it's difficult—just like anything new in life. But remember what we said about habits: if you do it long enough, your brain will start treating it as the default behavior. Eventually, it'll become second nature. A piece of cake. And this habit will save you an enormous amount of energy, ***which you can use on other things in real life.*** Ones that are *more important than wasting energy to prove a point.* But more on that later my friend.

Let's continue.

The Observer Is The Observed

Come on, admit it—just by saying *"The observer is the observed"*, you feel smarter, don't you? I'm seriously considering printing that quote on a t-shirt and wearing it at meetup events. Whoever comes up for a chat first, I'll just repeat back whatever they say and see if they get the joke. Haha. Or is that too weird? Fuck. I thought I would have figured out the how-to-socialize riddle by now.

Ok, on a serious note. *The Observer Is The Observed* is a very powerful concept, and definitely not an easy one to grasp. I mean it took me a long time to comprehend, and honestly, I am not 100% certain that I fully get it. It is a concept, I won't say proven, but instead, discussed, by both physicists and philosophers. I mean, what is life if not a beautiful blend of these two arts right?

To all the physicists out there:
Shouldn't philosophy be considered a science?

To all the philosophers out there:
Isn't science just a collection of human-constructed terms accepted as proof?

Now, go my friends. Fight each other. Hahaha.

Joking of course. Huge love and respect for both. If you do gather up and want to chat about stuff, please reach out. I'm always interested in these two arts.

I am definitely not a physicist. And I am not a philosopher either. And to be completely honest with you, *I don't really know what I am*. Sometimes I code apps in order to make money and then invest that money like my life depends on it—cause it kinda does. Sometimes—actually quite often—I play the guitar because music is the easiest way for me to feel things and sometimes, after I read a few books, I ask myself questions that I never know the answers to. And on top of all that, I'm 30 years old and I can't grow a beard. Oh, and my feet are too big for my height. So, I leave it to you to tell me what I am.

In all seriousness, I will explain The Observer Is The Observed from 2 angles, because these are the only angles I have looked at it. One is more philosophical, and the other one is neither backed nor proved by, but related to, a famous theory from quantum physics. Let's start with the physics one, cause…why not?

Enter ***the observer effect.***

When I found this concept, I think it was on Youtube, I was like WOW DUDE. My reaction was similar to when a bunch of young nerdy boys smoke weed for the first time and the weed finally kicks in.

In quantum physics, the observer effect refers to the fact that measuring a system inevitably changes the system itself. At a subatomic level, particles like electrons exist in a state of probability — which basically means that they're not in one fixed place or state *until* they're observed. Cool right? **Something is there only if you look for it.**
The moment you measure those particles, their *wave function*— which is the probability of finding a particle in a particular position—collapses into a definite outcome. So in a very real, measurable way, **the act of observing reality influences the physical reality itself.** It's not a metaphor — it's baked into the math of quantum mechanics. How fucking, motherfucking, fatherfucking and whateverfucking cool is that? According to

physics, the act of looking at something shapes its reality. If that doesn't make you question how much of your own reality is shaped by where you focus your attention… What does?

Now from a philosophical angle.

Enter ***Jiddu Krishnamurti,*** the 20th-century Indian philosopher who brought me closer to understanding the concept *"The observer is the observed"*—which, if I'm not mistaken, was coined by him.

Now, let's be clear: *"The observer is the observed"* and the *observer effect* are not the same thing. They're not typically discussed in the same context, and maybe they shouldn't be. But for me, they absolutely are—and I'll explain why shortly. I'll also share the link to the article that helped me grasp all this at the end of the book. It's a transcript of an interview with Krishnamurti where he explains the concept while responding to questions. There's one paragraph in particular that for me, was like seeing the light at the end of the tunnel. Of course, I'm not going to unpack the whole interview here—just that one part that was key for me.

Note that what I'm about to share is **my personal interpretation** of his idea—the version that helped me the most. Which could very well mean I'm just delusional, none of this is real, and I'm telling all this to myself just to keep me happy haha!

Let's begin.

All the things we experience in life, since early childhood are imprinted into our brains as memories. Things that we see, hear or feel in any way. These memories, in our brains take the form of mental images. Actually, to make things even simpler, let's remove the *mental* and just call them images. Society's mental models, our family's beliefs and in general the environments in which we act and interact with others, shape those images and also shape our perceiving of them— aka our emotional reactions to them. Now as years go by, and we reach adulthood, there is a big collection of images in our heads of all kinds of stuff. From things like what kind of experiences we like, what behaviors we accept, which ones we don't or what kind of colors we like etc. For example, maybe you have a

childhood memory of your father screaming and fighting with your mother, and back then it made you feel sad or angry. The father screaming to your mother is the image. The fact that you feel sad or angry is your emotional reaction to that image which was cultivated back then based on how your parents made you feel about it. Maybe you have another memory from childhood which is a friend wearing a nice red sweater. That's an image. Let's say your friend gave you that sweater to wear it and people told you it fit you really well. You liked that. That probably means that you have a positive emotional reaction to that image in your head. I assume you get my point.
In a nutshell: memories from the past are images in our heads and we have a particular emotional reaction to them.

What is crucial to understand here, is that anything and anyone who participated in any of our experiences, can take the form of an image. Even yourself. Experiences and things about yourself that made you feel good, bad, angry, happy, sad or whatever, can take the form of an image. And as a result, based on our family's beliefs, based on what society told us is acceptable or what is not etc, **we identify with some of those images**. To not complicate things further, let's just say that from a huge collection of images that we have gathered since early childhood, *we pick some of them*, and we choose to call them our **'self'**.

Therefore, what you need to fully grasp here is that all these images in our heads are basically experiences that we have lived and categorized as good or bad. And the good or bad reaction is basically the emotional reaction to those images when they pop up in our heads based on how society and our family told us we should react. Aka, if they told us we should like them or not. The images are not something external, or something separate from what we call ***self***, simply because **what we call self is a collection of images**. I.e an image of you being seen as smart when you were a kid, or achieving something and being praised for. These images—aka the memories of feeling *smart* or *successful*—are the images that you liked the most—out of all the images in your head—and you chose to identify with. Why? Because society or family praise kids when they are smart, so you felt good identifying with that. You chose to call them **'me'** *or* **'myself'**. Please, read this paragraph again before you move on and make sure you understand it.

…

All in all, we felt more comfortable with some images and we identified with them. As I said, due to society, due to family, due to friends or due to anything or anyone who told us that those images were cooler to identify with. And we chose them. In the simplest explanation possible, this is what t*he observer is the observed* means, at least to me. The fact that you have memories in your head, memories of **you**—the observed—imprinted as images, that you can observe and react to—the observer— via liking them, disliking, or identifying with them. You are pretty much observing images in your head and you emotionally react to them. Those images though are experiences of your own. Aka, the observer is the observed.

By the way, does it now make more sense why social media photos and videos are so addictive? Liking, disliking or identifying with scrollable or swipeable images and videos. Anyway, I really hope you get it.

Now, Jiddu Krishnamurti, being way smarter than I am, went deeper and explained that concepts like duality and space-time discrepancies between objects and people can lead to inner conflict. And some of them, he believed, will never allow us to see that we indeed are the observed and will stop us from being peaceful. But I don't want to overcomplicate things.
All I want you to take from this is the following: Everything we have experienced in early childhood and early adulthood, are represented as images in our heads. Based on what our environments—parents, society, our schools and our friends—told us, we created an emotional reaction to those images based on if something was accepted or not by our environments.
That's what I meant earlier when I said that what's in our heads is there for a reason. Someone put it there. It does not define us for the years to come.
We never really had a choice.

And that is exactly why I chose to link the two concepts of *the observer effect* from physics, and *the observer is the observed* from the philosophical point of view.
Because, all the images, all the emotional reactions—the stress, the anger, the fear, the shame, the love, the hate—and the inner conflict that takes place in our heads are there only when we engage with them, when we choose to see them, when we observe them, when we identify with them. Which makes me question….

What if we don't keep on doing that? What if we don't observe for once? What if we don't answer back to the voices? What if we don't identify with our thoughts or fight them? And just let them pass? What if we don't react emotionally to those mental images? Will they go away? Will they become less strong? Will we be calmer? Happier? Those are some good questions to ask ourselves, at least in my not-so-humble opinion.

Hope you are still here, and enjoyed this section. I certainly did. If you need to take a break, please go ahead and do it. Next up, shadows and personas.

The Shadow & The Persona

Whole books have been written for these two concepts, but I will keep things simple. As a blockchain Youtuber once said, *'We break it down but we don't dumb it down'*.

Shadow is all the feelings, traits, behaviors and the parts of ourselves we suppressed as kids. It is energy piled up into our subconscious that has not yet been released consciously. Why? Because our society, our family and our friends, at some point in childhood or early adulthood made us feel like shit when we expressed these parts of ourselves. In short, the Shadow is the part of you you'd rather pretend it doesn't exist — your hidden impulses, flaws, fears, sexual or of any kind desires — because if you fully express it you will be judged and feel ashamed, you will get angry, sad, or afraid etc. Given the binary nature of our world, due to everyone's *black-or-white* approach in life, expressing ourselves fully, our human nature and our primitive instincts, is not really acceptable behavior. But, what our society got really wrong is that by ignoring or suppressing something that lives in the unconscious, does not make it go away. Instead, it makes it stronger and stronger. Then it controls things behind the curtains. Especially if you think about it on a collective level. Which is probably why Carl Jung focused so much on the **collective shadow.** All the stuff *we as a society* pretend doesn't exist — the impulses, fears, and patterns we've shoved under the rug because they're too uncomfortable to face. I will touch on this topic at the end of this book, when I share a few last words.

So that is the Shadow. All the things we suppress because if we express them, we will be judged and feel angry, sad, shamed or scared. However, some of those traits can be of great benefit if we properly integrate them into our lives. But again, more on that later on.

Now— the ***Persona*** is another concept that I find extremely fascinating. I don't know if it's because I only recently realised that I have been using it for years on autopilot or because when I watched Ingmar Bergman's movie, *The Persona*, I realized how easily the boundaries between the persona and the inner self can collapse. Or maybe it is because when you actually understand what the Persona is, you can easily recognize why our society is so fucked up.

So, what is the ***Persona*** then you may ask?

The Persona is your social mask — the version of you you've crafted to survive, to succeed, or to be liked in this world. It's not 100% fake, but it's definitely filtered. It's the "you" you present at work, on first dates, on social media — aka, *the curated self*. It is the mask you put on in family dinners when someone asks you why you are still single? They ask it for the 100th time and you really want to slap them, or I don't know, spit in their food when they don't look, but you choose not to. That's your persona right there. The good boy version. Or the good girl. Unfortunately in this world it is impossible to not have one. Probably the world wouldn't function without a persona. Not that the way the world works right now could be called *'functional'* but you get what I mean.

The *persona* can take many forms: the confident professional who hides deep insecurities and never speaks up, the agreeable friend who never says what they really think, the *"strong one"* in the family who suppresses their own struggles just to keep others happy and calm — we won't name who — or the life-of-the-party who's quietly battling loneliness. These masks help us function in society—but over time, they can blur the line between who we are and who we pretend to be. And of course, it is not all bad. It allows us to adapt to different social roles: to be professional at work, compassionate with loved ones, or composed in difficult situations. It helps us navigate the expectations of society without revealing our entire inner world all the time. That would make any social interaction quite unbearable.

That's why the problem isn't having a Persona—as I just said, we all need one— but it's when you forget it's just a mask and you start believing that it is all you are. That's when the real problems begin. That's when life gets heavy — because maintaining the Persona takes energy. Real energy. It's like when you're with some friends, and instead of speaking up about something that really bothered you, you stay silent. Then you go home alone, lie down on your bed, and spend two hours replaying the scenario in your head. That's energy badly spent.

The less masks you wear, and the less time you spend wearing those masks, the more authentic your life is. And with less people around. Which is ok, I suppose.

Now you can ask yourself, do you wear masks too?
Of course you are.
We all do.
I just hope that we know how they look and when it is time to take them off.
But more on that later.

Now, moving on to my favorite concepts.

Ego, Superego & The Ideal Image

Ego vs Superego.
God vs Devil.
David vs Goliath.
Achilles vs Hector.
Prometheus vs Zeus.
The Real You vs What They Want You To Be.

I guess all of the above make sense when it comes to us humans, right?

We have already talked about the *Ego, the Superego & the Ideal Image* in the previous sections, but via different wording. I want to clearly define them though, and what they mean to me, because in the following chapters we will use them quite a bit.

They are all interconnected and they share a lot of similarities. At the end of the day, the existence of one, led to the creation of the other.

Let's explore them one by one.

The *Superego*, a term coined by Sigmund Freud, is basically the echo of the parent's and society's voice inside your head. It is the voice that is judging you based on how your parents and how society would like you to be. I am pretty sure you see how Superego is almost identical to what we called earlier in this chapter—*inner critic's voice.* All the mental models, the beliefs, the views of this world, the standards, the acceptable and non acceptable behaviors that our parents and our society support or reject are **reflected within your psyche as the Superego**. Obviously, it is a super powerful concept. I came across the *superego* term and the *inner critic* a couple of years ago, but only recently I paid attention to it. Only recently I felt it was something worth analysing, something that needed to be understood and I am super happy I did it. A lot of credits should be given to my doctor for that. In the next chapter, you will understand its significance, how important it is to acknowledge its existence and to properly define what your Superego is. Similar to the 'monsters' we were scared of as kids, the ones that were hidden in the closet or under the bed. The ones that when we shed some light on, we realized they were not that scary, or were not monsters at all.
I guess that is why they came up with this quote back in the 1500s: *"It is better to deal with the devil we know than with the devil we don't".*

Now, for the *Ego,* I prefer Jung's definition and not the one from Freud. Simply because, in my not-so-humble opinion, it is more *'multidimensional'*. Jung didn't define the ego purely from a logical standpoint—instead, he brought the subconscious into the equation. And to me, that has a far greater impact when it comes to truly understanding ourselves. For Jung, the ego is our conscious sense of identity — the "I" we think we are every time we live inside our heads. Which, let's face it, is pretty often, if not always. It's the center of our awareness, but not the whole psyche. In simpler terms, our ego is basically what we created in order to survive in this world, by using the following inputs to construct it:

- What are parents expected of us
- What are parents told us is good and right

- What society praises (following it blindly sometimes, especially in young age)
- What we, based on our own personal beliefs, chose to accept as a good trait to have (now this is probably the only part that is really OURS)

Be careful of the difference here though. The Ego is not other people's voices. It is what **we** have constructed as an identity, as a sense of 'I', *based on other people's voices.* That's why earlier in this chapter, I specified that the other inner voice, the one that leads to the inner dialogue and to the conflicts with the Inner Critic, **is our Ego.** Our sense of self talking. And you guessed it, its main goal is to defend ourselves. We would not be able to survive in this world without it. The world is so competitive and of such a binary nature, that not having an ego would crush us. That's why the Ego is not all bad, but only when it is the main driver of our choices and behaviors that it has negative consequences. Its goal is to make sure that the Superego, and all the Inner Critics that compose the Superego, are corrected, put into their place and see us exactly as ***we want to be seen***. Which brings us to the last bit. *The Ideal Image.*

The Ideal Image is what always keeps us on edge. The thing that makes sure that we fight every battle even if we don't really have to. What is the Ideal Image exactly then you may ask?

Every personality trait you want others to notice in you. Every physical characteristic you hope defines you — the kind that earns you recognition and approval in the eyes of society. Every kind of social status that you want your name to be linked to.

Let's use an example to understand exactly what it is. Imagine you live in the center of London and you work at a big Finance firm. Let's say an Investment Bank. You probably want to be seen as capable, intelligent, hardworking, rich, with a big-achiever status, powerful, wolf-of-wall-street kind of vibes. All these "traits", would form your *ideal image*. They are a part of it. How you want the world to perceive you. Now there is a significant thing we need to clarify here.
The fact that we need people to see the parts of our Ideal Image, does not mean:

1. That we really **are** those things at all
2. And even if we have some of those things, it does not mean we are **ONLY** those things.

When people do not acknowledge some of these personality traits, physical characteristics or social statuses in us, ***we get upset.*** It triggers us, it puts us in a fight or flight mode and then the Ego starts its job. Therefore, we could say with some certainty that **the Ego's job is to protect our Ideal Image**. And this is super important to understand because it is the architecture of what is going on in our head.

This whole puzzle, this whole complex system that forms our psyche, took me a few years to comprehend. With the help of professionals, self-therapy books and tons of mental effort, I managed to decompose these three core parts of my psyche: the Ego, the Superego & the Ideal Image. Maybe there are more parts, but understanding just these three got me more familiar with what is going on in my head. And honestly, I truly believe that the same architecture, the same blueprint if I may, probably describes your psyche too. If you don't trust me, trust Freud and Jung. I don't think they said all this stuff just for Mr. Tasos.

Now, let's end this chapter by summarizing something that I call the ***Psyche Cycle.***

*(PS: Again, big disclaimer, this is how **I** perceive everything and how **I** used everything to help me. I do not mean to present this way as the only way nor as the right way. I just believe that it can help you too.)*

The Psyche Cycle

What I call the psyche cycle, is basically the whole flow of us living and functioning inside our heads. The process If I may, that all the 3 parts we mentioned so far, interact and are connected with each other. And it is not that hard to see when you have clearly defined them.
Let me simplify the whole psyche cycle for you.
All in all, it starts with thoughts popping up out of nowhere.
At their core, thoughts are just electrical signals and chemical reactions bouncing around your brain. We cannot really control them. We just witness them. And some of these thoughts are what we called earlier the **inner critic voices.** Our parents' and society's expectations that were communicated and eventually embedded into our brains during childhood or early adulthood. Once we hear these voices in our heads, we automatically engage into inner conflict by having our own inner voice reply back. Aka, our **ego is on**. Then, this constant inner conflict, that is only mental, consumes real energy units. A conflict that takes place in a world that no one else sees but consumes energy that could be used in the 'real' world. And why is it happening?

Because ***the Ego's main purpose is to protect and validate in every possible way, our Ideal Image.*** All the traits, characteristics and social status labels that we want to be recognized by.

That is basically it. That's the psyche cycle that most of us engage in on a daily basis where we consume most of our precious energy.

And that's how chapter 7 comes to an end.

I feel genuinely happy, relieved, and proud knowing that I managed to sit down and shape all of this into 20 pages. I was sensing a big urge for a long time to put all this on paper and communicate how these concepts literally changed my life. Maybe these ideas are things you already knew, and maybe they won't change your life overnight or help you at all. But maybe — like me — you now have a clearer grasp of what's actually happening inside your head. And even if you're still figuring it out, at the very least, you now hold a blueprint — a set of tools to help you break things down and finally start making sense of it all. After all, if there are nearly 8 billion people on this planet, there are 8 billion versions of reality. Each of us sees the world through our own filter — through the wiring, beliefs, and memories inside our heads. That means the world you experience isn't out there — it's *in here,* inside your head. Which basically confirms that we construct our own realities, and eventually, the whole world around us. That's exactly why I believe that understanding the machinery behind our individual realities is not just helpful — it's essential.

Now it's time to move on to the next chapter of this book — where we'll explore how to put all of this into practice, and along with other useful tools and activities, how to navigate the years to come in the most meaningful way possible.

Chapter 8:
What to do about these voices?

Having all the tools you need in order to accomplish something, is essential. Not knowing what to do with them though, turns a potentially remarkable outcome into just another lets-just-watch-some-Netflix Tuesday evening. You know, the evenings that leave your pyjamas with food stains for months, because…who washes their pyjamas?

But that is not how we are going to live our lives. Right?
We are going to live a great life.

We have clearly stated 3 core parts of our psyche. The Ego, The Superego & The Ideal Image. The **Superego** triggers the **Ego** to engage in mental conflict and the ego does its job by fully protecting the **Ideal Image**. Easy peasy.

Nonetheless, a few questions remain. How do we identify these parts? How do we get familiar with what our Ego really is? Whose voices are forming our Superego? What are they saying? How does the list of the traits, the characteristics and the social statuses we crave look like in our ideal image? These questions might seem overwhelming, but they're not. Trust me. You already know what the answers are, but you usually avoid acknowledging them. And knowing the answers is *all you need to live a better life*. All it takes is **a few units of energy** and a genuine desire to understand yourself.
I mean… if you don't have the motivation to make your life better, nobody else will do it for you. What else do you have to do? Work? Fuck that.

Unless your work is a creative way, personally chosen by you, to express yourself in this world— which is what your soul craves but more on that later— then you don't really enjoy your job. And let me be careful here: when I say 'job,' I'm not referring to being a doctor, or any profession where you're actively saving or improving lives. Those I don't

place in the category of simple jobs—they stand apart. Or other jobs that save or improve this world in general. Because these are not jobs. These are ways of being. In other words, they are art.
I'm referring to the useless jobs we have created in the 21st century just to call ourselves productive. The jobs that have 7 words in their titles because we are desperately trying to make them sound useful. These are the types of jobs I'm referring to. No matter how many promotions you celebrate and no matter what you say to yourself, or to others, you can't hide from me. I know you don't really enjoy them. I know it. I can see it. I can feel it. And I can definitely smell it. The proof of your disliking is there if you look closely. Every time you get so bothered by the fact that tomorrow is Monday again. Or every time you seek holidays like Santa looks for Christmas. When you feel your brain buzzing after 1 hour of scrolling on your phone, wondering where did that time go? When someone tells you something and you snap because you are exhausted and you take everything personal. I know. Trust me. The fact that you don't enjoy doing something for 8 hours a day, triggers all these things. And it is normal. Why would you enjoy doing something for 8 hours when it kills your soul?
But as I said, I feel you.
I'm an Athenian. We've been sensing this kind of stuff for a long time now.

So, without further ado, let's begin.

How to figure out what your Superego is?

Unless you were raised by a thousand different people, or by wolves—or your parents had at least one thousand close friends—your superego is probably composed of just a few voices. And by a few, I mean five or six at most. Definitely fewer than ten. At least the ones that seem the loudest or appear the most. Even though our society has many faces and enforces countless rules, it is usually represented by only a handful of voices in our heads—perhaps a certain teacher, a friend, a parent, or a close friend of our parents. We don't internalize every voice from everyone we've ever encountered, only those who left a scar. And the ones who leave scars are usually the closest ones—I'm so poetic I know, haha!

Even if you weren't raised by your parents—if you were brought up by other family members, in a foster home, in an institution, or even on the streets by yourself—you still have certain images of certain people in your mind that you viewed as authority figures during childhood. It might have been your grandparents, aunts or uncles, a social worker, or even your own self. In one way or another, someone was there—someone who, as a child, told you what you should or shouldn't do. Don't trust me. Trust Sigmund Freud.

Once you realize that the components of your Superego can be counted by just using your one hand, or maximum, your both hands, you calm down a bit. It cannot be that powerful. Right?
Well... think again. (Just kidding!)
The Superego is indeed powerful, but not that powerful to always keep you hooked and controlled. In fact, it's at its **most powerful** when we're **least aware** of it.
Remember what we said, define a problem clearly and you are half way solving it.

Every time you engage in inner conflict, you can pause and just define the person your own inner voice is answering to. Literally, while you are doing it, see who you are talking to inside your head. Is it your mother? Your father? Your sister? A friend? A teacher? Who is it? Name that person, and write their name down.
An important thing to note here is that sometimes the image of someone will pop up in your head and even *without them saying anything,* you will still engage in conflict with that person. That's probably because that person represents something for you. Something that bothered you in the past and still does, or a memory of you feeling judged around them. It does not matter if their voice says anything. If you catch yourself arguing with the image of that person in your head, write their name down. Who are they?

Let me shed some light on this process by sharing how my own Superego looks like.
A bit embarrassing I know, but fuck it, I'm going the extra mile here.

My own superego is composed of my mother, my father, my sister, the father of a friend, a family member which is not considered as 'family' to me anymore, and 2 more people who I do not want to share who they are. Haha, I'm trying to keep the drama away otherwise this book might end up pissing off a few people.
Shit, maybe I didn't think this through…

But screw it, let's continue.

So that's how my Superego looks like, and trust me, we have been having inner conflicts on a daily basis for almost a decade haha. Not that much anymore though, I guess things do get better with **time** and **inner work.**

What's your superego like? Spend a few minutes before continuing and list down the people you usually argue with in your head. Trust me, it will help a lot.

Here is how you can start: Every time you catch yourself engaging in such conflict, just pause and ask yourself, *Who am I talking to?*
It is quite easy I must say. When you argue with someone in your head, be aware, visualize them, and state clearly who they are. Once you do that, it is quite easy to identify who she—or he— is. And then, once you recognize them, write their name down and define who they are, your Superego will become crystal clear to you. When your Superego is properly defined, trust me, it will be way easier to understand what they are saying and why, and why you are in a negative thinking mode most of the time. And eventually, you will learn how to actually stop doing it.

Hopefully you have understood the process and you are getting closer to defining your superego. You might be wondering though, why does this matter?
Or in better english, who gives a fuck?

Well, you should give a fuck.
You should understand who is judging you and how they are doing it in your own head. Because these voices might affect your actions in real life. A judgemental voice might keep you from taking action for something meaningful to you. Like travelling, choosing a professional path, starting a new hobby, choosing your outfit, defining your sexuality or whatever might be meaningful to you in a given moment. Those voices affect the world you create around you. Which on a collective level, means that those voices affect the whole world. Or, to be a bit more poetic, these voices create the whole world.
You should at least know who they represent, what they say, and why. And most importantly you should know and realise **that they are not you.**

They just happened to be the voices that you heard as a kid. Nothing else. Don't forget that. Where we are born, by who, and in which environments we grow up, are just random. That's why you should never brag or show-off like a selfish little prick. We are just flesh and bones.

Understanding my superego helped me a lot. I discovered the root causes of all the negative thinking, all the inner conflict that I was engaging in. The fact that I was changing a lot over the years and **this inner dialogue remained the same,** was a big realisation for me. I mean, it made sense why those voices were there in the first place. Of course, I have not fully resolved it nor always ignore it when it happens. But, I have improved quite a lot. I mean, it is not that easy to fully get rid of it. Actually, I don't even know if it is even possible. According to human nature and science, we are a sponge during childhood and whatever input we receive from authority figures, it gets embedded into our brains. So, it would not be an easy task to completely remove it from our lives. But, you have to understand that that's all it really is. Childhood input. Nothing more. It is not you. Once you realize that, it becomes way clearer what you need to do.

Unfortunately though, as I said, the brain is not a Recycle Bin on your computer which you can empty with a few clicks. However, you can apply the principle from the observer effect towards those voices. If you cannot shut them up, and if you cannot control the fact that they will eventually pop up again, what can you do? Well, don't engage with them all the time. After the voices start talking and the images pop up, don't keep reacting towards them. Let them go. Observing them is probably unavoidable, but engaging in mental conversations with them all the time, won't do you any good.
Don't try to convince them or change them at all. And after a while, ignoring them will become second nature.

Once you have everything clearly defined, the initiation of the inner dialogue does not go away completely. Trust me. It will kick off out of nowhere.
When you open the fridge to grab some water. When you take a shower. Right before you go to sleep. You name it. It never goes away. You never fully make your problems disappear. You just learn how to live with them, to not identify with them and eventually they are not strong enough to keep you in the same negative loops. They are always there

but it is you choosing to not let them affect you. A few helpful ways to avoid engaging in that inner dialogue when it initiates out of nowhere are the following:

- Take a few breaths to calm you down when you catch yourself spiral
- Once you take a few breaths, just realize and say to yourself that this is not happening in real life. But just in your head.
- Start observing physical things around you and touch them or smell them. Like if there is a guitar around, go play it. If there is a plant, go water it etc.
- When something is inside your head, doing something in real life — aka outside your head — is the way to go. Works every time.

Well, folks, that's it.

Did you learn something? I hope you did. I definitely recommend you engage in this kind of process. It might change your life. It definitely changed mine.

Now it's time to move on to the more complicated, and of course more interesting part — understanding what your ego and your ideal image are.

How to figure out your Ego & Your Ideal Image?

The ego and the ideal image are best defined together—after all, one protects the other. I don't know if you have ever heard of Carl Jung's **active imagination** but basically, it is conscious daydreaming but instead with an actual goal to be achieved. You drop into a relaxed, open state and calm environment and you start a dialogue with your subconscious—letting images, voices, and symbols rise up without filtering or forcing. It's like walking into your own inner world and saying, "Alright, show me what you've got." And you just pay attention to what comes up. You don't analyze right away. You just observe, interact, and ask questions.

Now you might ask, how the fuck do I talk to my subconscious dude? And I feel you. It took me a lot of time to figure out active imagination, and I'm far from good with it. That's why I won't go into more detail on how to actually do active imagination. I mean,

who claims to be an expert on a topic, preaching to people how to do it, but never really does it himself? Spoiler alert: a politician. Haha!

The reason why I mentioned the active imagination concept is because I wanted you to see that what I will say next is not just an idea of mine, but a serious process that is backed by science. Apart from Carl Jung, you also find a similar process in Gestalt Therapy, called *Empty Chair*. During the Empty Chair process you literally place an empty chair in front of you and you imagine a person that you had a conflict in your past or you imagine a younger version of yourself sitting there. You can initiate a dialogue with it and even engage in conflict. You do as you feel. A lot of unresolved issues will come to the surface if you do this process. Trust me, I've done it. Once, I imagined the father of a friend—who is a part of my Superego as mentioned earlier—who always pisses me off with his comments. I ended up throwing my cell phone to the chair in the end of that inner conflict, which ended up falling down and the screen broke haha! I had to buy a new phone last year! I swear. I broke my phone because I had a chat with an empty chair. Crazy.

There are plenty more processes similar to the *Empty Chair* in therapy. In general the concept of visualization is a thing in psychiatry. However, I will just tell you a more informal and easy way of doing it without any fancy words.
So what is that process I'm talking about?

Well, it is as simple as that: *Just visualize your ego as another person. Visualize how she or he dresses, behaves and talks. That person can be yourself or it can be someone else. And then get super familiar with what that person says and does.*

Seriously, that's the process. Visualize your ego with clothes and human traits. It has helped me tremendously.
It's the first and most important step. Actually, it might be the only step. If you do that properly, everything else will fall into place.
Nonetheless, if you are a very unique case scenario and you are already familiar with active imagination or your ego is not a person but something else, you are already too advanced. I truly believe though that you can take something from this section.
Now, let's continue and break down the whole process of how to visualize the ego.

This will be extremely embarrassing—again, haha —but sharing how my ego looks like and what kind of questions I asked myself in order to properly visualize it, I believe, will make the whole process way easier for you. Based on where I grew up, the external stimuli I've been exposed to since early childhood, certain things that I have experienced when I was 18/19 years old, and life choices—like leaving Greece when I was 21 to chase my dreams—I have to admit, made my ego quite an interesting mix. At least to me.

My ego is a controversial blend of controversial figures. To give it an artistic twist, it is a mix between a narco drug lord, a 1950s gangster, a Mr. Robot–style hacker who talks with many voices, a creative artist with a château in the South of France who smokes cigars all day, and Sully from *Top Boy*. Interesting mix right?

Be careful though, what I described now is not me. That's just how my ego looks. The visualization of a creature **I have created**, that according to my beliefs and childhood input, **is the most capable creature to defend my ideal image every time someone threatens it.** That's what you should never forget, we create our egos to survive in this world. Seriously, I mean it. I have zero involvement in any type of illegal activities, I plead the Fifth Amendment, I have never coded with the aim to do harm to anybody and most importantly, I don't own a chateau in the South of France.

Now, you can pick which one of the sentences I just typed sounds more truthful to you.

Jokes aside though— that's how my ego looks. He always dresses in black, and is always fit. Never has any extra fat on his body. Always on edge, always ready, always planning the next move. He cannot chill, and he is always available to confront anything and anyone, even if there is no reason too. He turns the volume of his voice up every time someone might try to invalidate my ideal image. He is the protector, even though he does not have to be. You tell him he is dumb? That he is not strong or tough enough? That he got fat? That he is a robot? You will ask him why he is being weird? Why did he leave Greece, like it was a mistake? That he should have stayed there because that's what was the normal thing to do? Well, he will verbally try to end you. He will put his everything into making sure you are corrected, you are put into your place and that you understand who he is and what he is capable of. Even when he does not have to. Even whether you understand him

or not means nothing to him. He will still do it. He is on autopilot with one and only purpose. To keep the ideal image intact. Even if he does not do it out loud, and I seem calm sitting on a chair, he still does it in my head.

Uff. That was an intense paragraph to write. I just revealed a crucial part of myself. A part that makes me vulnerable. I guess that's ok. I hope so.

Of course, I did not wake up one day and visualise my ego like that. After years of hearing the voices in my head and after a lot of self questioning, the visualisation of my ego became crystal clear. The questioning had a lot to do with what actually triggered me into engaging in mental — or physical at times — conflict. And the most interesting part is that even if my life was constantly changing, in many ways, the mental conflict was THE SAME — FOR YEARS. Only my Ego's responses would just get stronger and more intense. The context, the participants of the inner dialogue and the reasons for conflict were exactly the same. And honestly, the questioning technique was nothing fancy. Simply by observing, simply by writing things on paper I identified those parts. But let's be a bit more organized and clearly state the questioning part.

The Questioning

The single indispensable element needed to ignite the questioning is ***awareness***. Just catch yourself when you are spiraling. When you are in your head and engaging in mental conflict. It is hard at first, but thanks to how the brain works, after some repetition it becomes second nature. Now, once you do catch yourself engaging in mental conflict, ask yourself, what did I just say in my head? What did I say to the inner critic's voice? Write it down. Maybe if the inner critic judges you about something, your answer looks something like: *'What the fuck do you know?* or *How could you know what it means to live abroad?'*. The easiest way to catch yourself while doing this and clearly state what your inner voice says to the critic's voice is to do it when you feel strong emotions in your body. If you have read *The Body Keeps The Score* book from Dr. Bessel van der Kolk, you already know that trauma and intense emotions are not just psychological—they are deeply embedded in the body. Strong emotions like anger, sadness and fear are intensely sensed by us.

And by the way, I'm focusing on the negative feelings here because we want to stop negative spirals. Why would we want to stop good thoughts?
When you feel strong emotions while you are in your head, it means that something is going on there. An inner dialogue. Take a step back right at that moment, and see what's the context.

Let's use myself as an example again. Fucking hell, I have revealed too much, haha!

For many years, I have been engaging in the same inner conflict with the same people in my head. Let me give you a few examples. First, me trying to convince my mother and make it clear that there is a constant misjudgment from her end when it comes to me leaving Greece. Sometimes not direct, but it is always there. With a tone of contempt and the classic toxic ways used by mothers. Genius creatures, I tell you. Fortunately, she and I have made a lot of progress in that area over the past few years and our relationship is stronger than ever. She wants to travel the world now with every chance. Crazy lady my mother I tell you.

Here's another inner conflict example: me mentally confronting family members who hurt me deeply during my early adulthood and my ego desperately trying to defend me in any way possible. Mostly with very bad Greek words. Like seriously, let's keep those bad Greek words outside of this book, haha!

Here is another example: me talking with friends or parents of friends who judge my actions — like leaving Greece or forgetting about people or that I have changed a lot — due to jealousy or whatever reason from their side, and my ego once again saying unspeakable things to them in my head! Always trying to defend myself and justify my actions. Literally, these kinds of inner conflicts would occur on a daily basis. And sometimes, they would occur in real life by digital means of communication — aka the phone, as we discussed earlier — and me trying to convince and correct everybody. Energy very badly spent.

In general I would engage in these types of conflict daily, and always with the same goal. To convince and correct everyone regarding my life's choices. Which in my opinion, is a logical thing to do. Right? Especially when you do things that your childhood circle never

did, will never do, and will never understand— which is totally FINE— but still judge you, it is very logical that you get pissed. It does not sound that irrational that you answer back when someone is judging your whole life's decisions right?
However, there is no need to engage in such conflict on a daily basis and waste your precious energy. Why? Spoiler alert — You repeating yourself and trying to convince people over and over again, DOES NOT GUARANTEE that they will get you. You might then ask, why do we try then? Good question…
Well, to keep the ideal image intact my friend.

All this inner madness made me realize that the **Ideal Image** was behind the curtains, controlling everything. I mean why else would that voice exist in the first place if there was nothing to defend? So I asked myself, if I try to convince my mother about my choice of leaving Greece, if I try to confront someone who hurt me in the past or if I try to put someone into their place, *What is the goal? Why do I do it?*
Well, take out a pen and grab a piece of paper, and list down all the answers to these questions. ***Summarize the answers in adjectives that could describe the things you are trying to convince your inner critics about.***
For example, if you're trying to convince someone that leaving your country was a bold or difficult decision—something they simply can't understand if they haven't done—perhaps a trait you want to be seen as is **a risk-taker**, **a nonconformist**, or **an innovator**. If you're confronting someone and trying to make them understand how deeply they hurt you, maybe what you're really seeking is to be recognized as **brave**, **resilient**, or **someone who has endured hardship**. Or when you're trying to explain that you dislike having a 9-5 job, or that others cannot grasp the kind of projects you are working on, the trait you may want to highlight is that you're **smart**, **different**, **not average**, **not boring**, or **certainly not stupid**. By now, I assume you get the idea. It is quite simple:
Based on what you're trying to convince someone of, identify the core adjective that best describes that thing you want to be seen as—and write it down in a list. That's a part of your Ideal Image my friend.

Seriously, I can't stress this enough: clearly identifying and understanding the components of your ideal self-image can answer some of the most important questions about your life. Questions like: *Why do I do the things I do? Why does something bother me more than something*

else? These are powerful questions—questions you need to become familiar with and, ideally, answer.

Once you understand your own ideal image, you'll also realize that if you're wired this way, chances are **other people are too**. That insight alone will help you understand others more deeply—and just as importantly, it will help you **stop taking things so personally**. And that applies to me too, of course.

So all in all, **write things down.** For example, my own ideal image has ***13 parts***, traits, adjectives. Of course I will not state each one of them, I already shared way too much. I would give you too much power over me—haha! But I'm pretty sure from the things I have shared so far you can guess a few of those traits in that list.

Well, amigos y amigas… that was it!

It's not rocket science. Actually—rocket science isn't that hard either. All you have to do is read it and understand it. Now, reading something can be difficult, and truly understanding it even more so. That's the truth with any concept. It all depends on how much you want to learn something that will define its difficulty and potentially lead to understanding it.
Therefore, the question to be answered is not if rocket science is difficult, or if any other concept is difficult either. But instead, ***how much do you want to learn it?*** The level of your curiosity towards a topic is probably a proof of your mind's strength — aka your intelligence — that will make the understanding of any topic completely possible. That desire will be the defining factor for everything in your life.

So, before you move on, ask yourself: how much do you want to learn about what is really going on in your head?

I really hope that you deeply understand this.

Let's move on to the next chapter that you cannot afford to miss.

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Chapter 9:
What's a life worth living?

You might already be wondering, *'Who the fuck is this guy telling me how I should live my life?'*. Well, I am not here to tell you how to live your life. Definitely not. What I will tell you though is what many books, many great thinkers, the universe and—therefore—my own intuition suggest makes a life worth living. Oh, and my cousin Socrates says so too.

Before we dive any deeper, let's clearly state the things we will talk about in this chapter. The things that, in my not-so-humble opinion, are very important to understand in order to live a life worth living. The things that without them, we will never be able to say *enough* and we will always seek for more.
These things are:

- Building A Character
- Understanding Time
- Action vs Inaction
- Creation over Consumption
- Process vs Outcome
- Unavoidable Pain

We will not be talking about each one of them separately nor in a particular order. However, all these concepts will be covered in this chapter and you will see how their interconnectedness makes them highly significant to live a life that's worth living. A life on your own terms.

Are you excited?
Good. Me too.

Let's get this out of the way first… ***making a lot of money will not solve all your problems, and will not guarantee your happiness***. To be completely honest with you, I don't even know if I believe in a state of 'happiness' anymore, but more on that later. Don't worry though, I am not trying to sound pessimistic, there is still hope.

The fact that money won't bring you full satisfaction seems like a cliché nowadays. Everyone seems to agree with it, yet almost everyone still does everything they can to get it. A bit ironic don't you think? I believe this happens because people *do* understand that money won't make them happy—they just don't understand *why*. Or they do and simply ignore it. But let's talk about the *why* first.

You probably have already heard the quote *time is money*. I could bet that the majority of the people have heard of it but still, the majority of the people don't get it. The reason why money won't make you happy is because if you do have a lot of money, you have a lot of free time. And having a lot of free time is dangerous. You will see shortly why.

But Tasos, you say, wait a second, having a lot of free time is a good thing, right?
I mean if you have 10M$ in the bank, you are probably not gonna apply for a job via Linkedin and go work for 40-50 hours a week. Right? But instead, for a few months at least, or maybe for the years to come, you will do whatever you want, versus someone else who actually has to go to work.
Then a significant question arises: *What do you do with all that free time?*

This is where things get more complicated.

Let's assume we live in a polarized world, a black-or-white world— which is quite a solid assumption I suppose—and there are only **2 scenarios** that can play out when it comes to what you do with all the free time you have when you have a lot of money. These ***two scenarios*** are:

1. You will spend your time ***doing things.***
2. You will spend your time ***thinking about things.***

In the first case scenario when you constantly do things, there is a high probability that it won't end well. Especially if you don't have a solid financial education and a solid

understanding that money is purely a psychological game. Also, according to science, when you *Do*, you *Think* less. Neuroscience and psychology back this idea in studies like *embodied cognition* and *flow states*. But let's keep things simple for now and ask ourselves, what do we usually see people do when they have a lot of money and not a very solid financial education?
Well, they buy stuff.
They acquire more and more possessions with the assumption that they will satisfy them or fill the gap they have inside them. Or we see them use these stuff to play status games and make sure that they are seen and recognized as successful individuals. Now, don't get me wrong. I'm not saying this is what every person who has money does. I am just saying what might happen in a black-or-white world or what has happened in most cases when people without purpose, character or financial education had loads of cash. Just check Hollywood Stars, famous athletes, famous musicians, big time investors and entrepreneurs. So many stories of people going broke, being depressed or dying from overdose or fatal car accidents.

When with loads of cash, and without financial education or a character, you are basically on autopilot doing things that society tells you that a person with a lot of money should do. Or you try to fulfill any insecurities you might have inside you by using your dollar bills. That won't fix things my friend.

Another potential side effect when you play status games, and you have money that you don't know what to do with, is usually *Making Stupid Decisions*. Heavy partying, a lot of alcohol, a lot of drugs, a lot of unprotected sex, buying supercars and all in all doing dangerous shit. This is what I meant by ***doing things*** as the first case scenario. Now, if you are really shocked by what I just said, and you think it is super extreme, then you can skip this part completely and say 'ok, this guy made a very wrong assumption to support his argument'. I'm totally ok with that. We live in a free world. Right? Skip it if you want.

Nonetheless, if you believe there's some validity to my assumption regarding the first case scenario, we can both agree that continuing down that path of doing things without purpose and loads of resources will eventually lead to— unhappiness, serious financial issues, bankruptcy, addictions, health problems, or even death. I mean, if you're intoxicated and driving a Lamborghini on the highway, it would not be crazy to assume

that you could crash and die. So… before moving to the next case scenario let's agree on this: *Having a lot of money without a real sense of purpose in life can lead you to do things just to impress others—things that might spiral into unhappiness, financial collapse, addiction, health problems, or even death.*

Now, what about the second case scenario?
The one regarding *spending time thinking about things?*

Well things get even more complicated in this case.

If you have not worked on yourself, if you have never ignored the world's noise and sat down with your own thoughts, then having a lot of free time to think **will be hell for you.** Dante already poetically expressed this in his work, *Inferno*, and showed what kind of tortures someone will face if one avoids confronting himself— or herself.

The moment you are alone with your thoughts and there are no distractions, every bad, hidden, scary and hateful thought will come to the surface. Everything that you have been avoiding for years will come and knock at your door by taking many forms. Forms that even yourself could not imagine. When that moment comes, the only thing that can help you to get through such a hard time is **your own character.** But how could you have created a strong character if you always avoided the hard truths about yourself? Any kind of trauma, unfulfilled desire from the past, any insecurity that you might be suppressing or any kind of memory that was always generating unbearable feelings that you constantly avoided, will appear at your doorstep out of nowhere. Even with a **strong** character, undertaking the task of confronting all these things would be very difficult. Imagine what could happen with a **fragile** character.

Let's not kid ourselves. What do you think happens when you don't want to confront your own thoughts, traumas or any hard truths in general? What do you do?
Just think about yourself for a second. What have you done in that situation? Every time there was an uncomfortable feeling, a hard conversation you didn't want to have, or an action that if taken it would lead to an uncomfortable situation — what did you do in that moment?

…

Well, if you are human, you probably found ***a way*** to distract yourself from that feeling of discomfort or you tried to get yourself out of that uncomfortable situation. Right?

This *way* of yours probably took many forms. Maybe you remained silent and you avoided confrontation to not make the situation even more uncomfortable. Maybe instead of having that hard conversation with someone you simply disappeared. Or became distant. I mean, in 2025, ghosting is a thing hahah. If the situation of discomfort did not involve another person, and it was just you, distracting yourself probably took a different form. Maybe instead of dealing with those disturbing thoughts you numbed yourself. Perhaps you drank alcohol. Maybe you took drugs, or maybe you went straight to meeting other people in social events, do all kinds of stupid shit people do in parties and ***you put your fake happy mask*** on again.

Or, you did what the majority does in 2025. You took your phone out and scrolled for hours. You numbed your brain. Which is exactly what spending hours scrolling on social media does to your brain. It numbs it. Actually, there is a scientific article that proved that your brain *'shrinks'* after consuming content on social media for hours. And when I say *shrink* I don't mean it in a cartoonistic way. I'm just referring to the fact that your brain weakens. Just google: *'grey matter reduction in brain areas after heavy social media use'* and you will see what I am talking about. Or actually, don't google it. Use ChatGPT instead. Times have changed.

Anyway.

Seriously, I see this kind of behavior all the time. Whenever I bring up a topic that makes people uncomfortable, I notice their reactions shift instantly. It's like they panic a little. They either change the subject, get defensive, or start arguing—insisting that I'm wrong without offering any solid counterarguments. And often, they do this before I've even made my point.

Therefore, unless you're once again shocked by what I've said, let's agree on this conclusion: *Having a lot of money gives you a lot of free time to think about things. If you have not*

worked on yourself enough, a lot of uncomfortable thoughts will inevitably arise. Without the mental capacity nor the character to confront them you will attempt to avoid them. That will probably lead you to distract yourself in multiple ways. Via intoxication, via fake social interactions or via mental numbness. Which could potentially lead to unhappiness, depression, hurting yourself, maybe money problems, or even hurting yourself to death.

To be honest, we can agree that even without a lot of money, many of those outcomes could still happen. Depression, unhappiness, intoxication, wearing social masks—these are experiences we all face, regardless of wealth. Being poor or rich doesn't exempt anyone from them.
So, please, follow this thought for me: If a specific event—like suddenly having a lot of money—can create two different scenarios that both end in similar outcomes, outcomes that could also occur without money at all, then something deeper, more hidden beneath the surface, **might be the real cause of these negative experiences.**

If no amount of wealth, no amount of power, or any type of social status achievement will ever satisfy you, what will? I don't know for sure. But building a strong character might be the best kind of compass in times of uncertainty.

That's why you need to deeply understand this relationship between time and money. There is a dangerous link between them. Usually when people say *time is money,* they only mean from a capitalistic point of view, the profit seeking one, the one that says buy assets and make money in your sleep. But this is simply how everyone is missing the point. Everyone seeks money, without ever asking themselves why or what they are gonna do with it. And when the time comes they realize that the first side effect of having a lot of money is having a lot of free time. And that's when they face the real monster.
The fact that the more money you have, the more time you have available to utilize for yourself, can turn against you. If you **have not done any inner work,** the consequences can be fatal. And due to the fact that everyone is different, we end up seeing all kinds of behaviors from different people.

For example, if you keep 'working' while having a lot of money then that's your own choice. If you are an entrepreneur, or a famous athlete or a famous artist and you have millions in the bank and you keep on working and working and working, then that's on

you. That's your choice. You don't have to. You could quit tomorrow and live your whole life without ever working again. Thus, from a purely logical standpoint, more money means less necessity to work—which means more time available for things *other* than work. That's why your level of satisfaction in life *ultimately depends on what's inside your head, inside your soul*. Not inside your pockets. It doesn't come from any external thing. That's why in order to live a life worth living you need to work on yourself, on your character. Otherwise you will always run away from discomfort, and you will always seek easy and fast gratification, which just exacerbates the emptiness you feel inside. If you ever read any work from **Schopenhauer** you know that life is about minimizing pain and not maximizing pleasure. But hey—let's not get too dark too fast, haha. Just remember that running away from pain all the time, mental or even physical at times, you guarantee unavoidable pain **in the future**. And when that pain comes, it might be unbearable.

In my own life, the majority of the people I have met always run away from discomfort—and I have done it too, countless times. In one way or another.
People seek pleasure everywhere. They tell themselves — and even believe that that's the meaning of life and that the great thinkers advise people to do it too — that life is only about enjoying things, relaxing, having fun and laughing. Of course these things are important and we all should appreciate them, however, I do not believe that's what life is all about. And honestly, without a character, or any level of awareness, I don't believe that people truly appreciate these things when they experience them.

They use all kinds of means, tools, and substances—good and bad—to convince themselves and others that what they're doing is *enjoyable, pleasurable,* or *fulfilling*. But I don't buy it, and I strongly believe you shouldn't either. I've been to many places and found myself in all kinds of situations, both intoxicated and sober. It never made a difference. If I had unresolved issues or thoughts I was trying to escape when alone, I was never truly able to enjoy anything. I'd always feel like I should be somewhere else, doing something else, or feeling something different. That constant inner conflict kept me from being present—and by now, you know how dangerous that is.

And again, I'm not saying that everyone experiences life this way, or that everyone is faking it. Not at all. I'm simply speaking from what I most often observe. If you believe this assumption is wrong, that's perfectly okay.

But let's think about it logically: if I genuinely enjoy the present moment, why do I numb myself? Why do I get drunk? Why do I care about taking a picture and posting it online? If my life is so good, why am I constantly counting down the days to the weekend or the next vacation? If the **now** is truly fulfilling, why do I keep distracting myself from it? And when problems arise, why don't I face them with clarity and reason? But instead I avoid the problem by distracting myself or by judging and gossiping about others?
Maybe, before preaching about how life should be lived or what others should find enjoyable, we should look ourselves in the mirror. That would be a wise thing to do.

Anyway, you see… I got upset again.

Deep breaths Tasos, deep breaths— hahah.

In my not-so-humble opinion, understanding who you are—and why you think, feel, and act the way you do—is essential to living a meaningful life. Knowing why you avoid certain things, why you feel uncomfortable, and why more money or free time doesn't automatically lead to satisfaction can make all the difference.
I don't really know how to express it but there is a feeling, a voice or let's call it an intuition, when you challenge yourself. That voice whispers to you that this is exactly where you are supposed to be and this is exactly what you should be doing. Right?
I mean what does the voice in your head tell you every time you fake things? Every time you intoxicate yourself? Every time you avoid hard truths? Every time you avoid doing the meaningful work and instead you do the work that gets you socially praised? That voice does not tell you *'Congratulations, keep on doing what you are doing*. Right? Probably not.

Or, is it just me?
Nah, I don't think so.

Interestingly, I followed my intuition to write this chapter, and surprisingly it led me to the things I deeply wanted to talk about. This sequence of thought, brought us closer to another important thing we need to talk about in order to **understand what a life worth living is all about.**

Why when I don't do things that are somehow beneficial, or for our example, somehow productive, I have this negative voice in my head telling me that I should be doing something else? Something more. Something better. Something that could potentially yield better rewards. Well…my friends, let's all welcome the ***Productivity FOMO.***

Today's world's biggest fear.

By the way, FOMO, for those living under a rock—hahaha—means Fear Of Missing Out.

We live in a world where we are constantly bombarded with information that tells us that there is always someone out there doing things better than us. That someone out there has more things than us. That someone is cooler, hotter, smarter, richer than us. This has been happening on a massive scale, worldwide, for almost 2 decades now. Which means that in our brains, it has imprinted ***mental images*** — the ones we discussed earlier — of others doing better than us, and guess what, it has generated an emotional reaction from our side towards those images. Mostly fear and anxiety. We are scared and we are stressed that we are not enough. That we don't have enough. That we are not doing enough. Well…I will try to end this Productivity FOMO for you once and for all.

THERE IS NO SUCH THING AS MISSING OUT.

Let me say it again.

THERE IS NO SUCH THING AS MISSING OUT.

Why there is no such thing as missing out you may ask?

Because you never truly miss out.
Because there is nothing to miss out on.
Because that feeling of FOMO is nothing more than society's way to lie to you.
Generating that feeling for you, is how society lies.
And what is that lie I am referring to?
That you are not doing what you should be doing instead.
That you should be stressed, so they prevent you from thinking clearly.

That there is something out there you should be doing instead of what you are doing now. But don't forget. There is nothing to miss out on. And I will explain shortly why.

So how do we overcome all this madness and all this society's lying?
Well…there is only one thing you should be doing indeed. But only one. Not two, or three. No matter what society says.
But be patient. We will say what that thing is very shortly.

Let's now back our argument with some logic and some facts to fix your thinking and ***to convince you that there is nothing to miss out on.***

There is no such thing as **falling behind in life.** And there is no such thing as **being ahead in life either**. These concepts only exist when we compare ourselves to others. Comparing ourselves to others is a human-made process that is done in order to calm ourselves, or upset ourselves, depending on the outcome of the comparison. If something is made by humans, it can definitely be accepted, doubted, or fully rejected. Remember what we already said: everyone in life has different timing. Science said it. David Eagleman said it too. Just check out his *time perception theory*. We all perceive time differently, which means we experience it differently.
Everybody's timing in life is different.

I want you to deeply understand that when you are online, checking social media, and you see everyone doing better than you, it is not true. We already explained this previously in the book. Social media shows you the 1% of the 1% and even if EVERYONE in life was doing better than you, by using social media alone, you would not live long enough to find out.
So, stop fucking comparing. You piss me off — haha, I'm joking-ish.
I also used to compare myself to others a lot, and to be fully frank with you I still do it sometimes. But I quickly remind myself that if for almost 2 decades my brain has been bombarded with such content, I should not identify with it, nor engage with it, and definitely not believe it, because it is not what my default behavior really is. But instead, what society, and in our case social media, wants me to do.

Because let's face it, being competitive, and FOMOing all the time, means you stay online. It keeps you engaging with those platforms. Which guess what? It makes more money for them. Welcome to the attention economy bitch!

Fully acknowledging the fact that we all have different timing in life, that we have different backgrounds, different mental models, different beliefs, different privileges, different networks, should be enough to calm us down and help us avoid FOMO. However, it doesn't.
That's why we need to clearly define what is *that one thing* we mentioned earlier that if you do it in your life, FOMO will go away. Maybe not fully, but it will remain at a manageable level. After all, maybe FOMO is a primitive instinct, who knows. Maybe it has been embedded in us since the tribe creation times and when we used to hunt all the time otherwise we would starve to death.
However, FOMO in such high levels, and in a very technologically interconnected world, does not serve us anymore. So, let's define what that one thing is first, and then discuss how to find it.

Don't take my word for it.
Take Bukowski's: *Find what you love and let it kill you.*

Probably this quote sounded a bit extreme, but hey, that's Charles!
Why I used this quote of his though, is because I really want to get across that if you don't do what you love in life, how could you be happy? Or satisfied? Or whatever word you want to use here that will give you purpose. Honestly, how could you?

I know that the '*do what you love'* is a bit of a cliché nowadays, because it is communicated and interpreted in the wrong way, but it is a very important concept. I do not mean it as most people do. Like *go find the job of your dreams*, or do *the job that you love* or anything like that. Seriously, I don't believe that in anyone's *dreams* nor in anyone's *heart*, the word 'job', with today's meaning, exists. If it does, please, *DREAM BETTER*. I mean just go check the roots of the word *'work'* or *'labor'* from old times, and tell me if what you found really excites you and makes you wanna do it every day after you wake up.
Anyway. For now, let's ignore all these capitalistic & macroeconomic related definitions of work and labor. And most importantly, let's clearly state that probably, *what you really love*

doing, maybe does not even bring you a lot of money. Which sucks I know, but it is what it is.

If you read a bit of biology and a bit of psychology, you will quickly find what some of our primitive instincts, emotions and traits are. I won't be stating all of them now, but some of them have to do with the fear of death, the need to be safe and a deep desire for being seen by others. From back in the day, when we were trying to be accepted by a tribe, we did it because we had the need to belong, to stay safe and avoid danger. There are even studies in social neuroscience that show that social exclusion activates the same brain regions as physical pain—the anterior cingulate cortex in particular—which means that being ignored or unseen is processed by the brain as a genuine threat. Imagine that.

Now if you combine all that with ideas from books like *The Creative Act* from Rick Rubin, or *The War Of Art* from Steven Pressfield (one of my favorite books) it becomes clear that *doing what we love* has a lot to do with if we're truly expressing ourselves through what we do. Interesting right?

But wait! How do you go about finding that thing you may ask? How hard is it? How can I stay motivated and keep on doing it if it just takes my time and energy and never gives me money back? How can I truly express myself? What does it really mean to express oneself?

Let's answer all that and put your concerns away. Once and for all.

I know that money is very useful in today's world. But what If I told you that in any activity you do, hobby, sport or whatever, when money starts being the reward received, our intrinsic motivation decreases. Seriously. There is scientific proof of that. If you check **Overjustification Effect** and **Self-Determination Theory** from Edward Deci & Richard Ryan you will see that when money is used as an external reward for some activity, the subjects lose intrinsic interest for the activity itself. That's in the actual words of Deci used back in 1971. Do you imagine? That when the money is in, intrinsic motivation is out. When the money is in, the fun is out haha! I suppose that's why we shouldn't be surprised that so many people feel depressed—sitting in desk cubicles, doing work they don't enjoy, just waiting for the paycheck at the end of the month.

The same thing is happening with hobbies. Hobbies used to be for fun, for relaxation, to enjoy them, to get your mind off things. Nowadays though, in the hustler's society, in the society where productivity is a religion and everyone is a fanatic, hobbies don't really exist anymore. Everything needs to happen for a reason. For a reward. For a benefit. One day you want to learn guitar, the next day you're searching how to master it very fast and go viral on social media. One day you're curious about filmmaking, the next you're buying top gear to become the next big thing online. You go for a run to clear your head, and suddenly you've got a smartwatch, a Strava account, and a goal to run 5K in under 15 minutes. You once enjoyed writing thoughtful quotes—now they have to be viral tweets so you can make money as a content creator. Everything has to be monetized or validated by views and likes just to keep us motivated. But that's exactly what ends up killing our intrinsic drive. Isn't that ironic?

I mean, think about it: when we engage in new activities and focus solely on the outcome—especially when that outcome depends on people's opinions or monetary rewards, which we have zero control over—we can't be surprised if things don't play out as we hoped. Especially in the digital world today, where everything is heavily saturated and talent alone is no longer enough to guarantee success. In fact, if you look at most famous, mainstream music artists in 2025, you'll notice that talent isn't even a must-have—haha, sorry, but it's true! That's why the one important thing to understand about what you love doing is this: *before you even start, you must accept that to truly love what you're doing, you need to completely ignore the outcome and focus on the process itself.*
That's what makes you love the thing. You don't love playing the guitar because one day a fan might sing your song. You love it because you really like the process of creating music, and hearing the sounds that come out from within.

There is a very high chance that if you focus on the outcome of doing an activity, a hobby, a process—or call it whatever— you will never love doing it. If you don't trust me, trust Mihály Csíkszentmihályi, the father of *flow state* and author of the book *Flow.* A concept which is backed by psychology, neuroscience and cognitive science that defines **Flow** as the state of complete immersion in an activity—where focus is effortless, time seems to disappear, and action flows naturally from skill and challenge in perfect harmony. Just think about it. Whenever you played as a kid, or when you do any kind of art, or any challenging sport. Or when you play chess. You just forget about everything

else. Your mind focuses on what you do at that particular moment and ignores everything. And time flies. That's a core requirement, a necessity if I may, for any activity to be **loveable**.

But then, another question arises.

How do I stay motivated when something does not give me any monetary or social status related rewards? Especially in a world where time is highly linked to money and it is very easy to *FOMO* over another activity that could be generating those rewards for me. How do I do that?

I will use Pressfield's ideas— from his book *The War of Art,* which I mentioned earlier— in order to explain what it is that keeps demotivating you, and why overcoming it is the key to remaining consistent. And you can achieve that no matter the external environments, your mood or the potential external rewards.
You will see for yourself that it is not the money nor the views.
The first idea he discusses in his book is what he calls ***Resistance***. The universal force that pushes everyone away from doing what they truly want to do. Resistance is that voice in your head that tells you, "Why bother?" when you start something that matters to you. Something that could potentially matter to a lot of people too. It's the invisible force that prefers you to stay on the couch scrolling, instead of writing, painting, or building that thing you keep dreaming about. Basically, he argues, resistance becomes the strongest when you're about to do something meaningful. Something truly inspiring. The closer you are to your calling, the louder Resistance becomes. It is a global phenomena and happens to all of us.

Understanding that this is a universal force that applies to everything and everyone on the planet is life changing. In a way it confirms that everyone faces it, fights it, wins it or gets defeated by it. And that's why there is nothing to catch up on, there is nothing you should FOMO about. The only thing you need to do is win the battle with Resistance— which is 100% doable— by showing up and doing the work, no matter the circumstances. You do that and you have already achieved what the majority does not. In his exact words**:**
"Resistance will tell you anything to keep you from doing your work. It will perjure; it will falsify; it will

tell you you're not ready. Resistance will perjure itself; it will lie; it will tell you you don't have the time. Resistance will perjure itself."

Therefore, it becomes clear that in order to overcome such a powerful force, we cannot depend on external rewards and outcomes that we have no control over. But instead, focus on the one thing we can control, **our input**. Our showing up. Our contribution. And the rest will fall into place.

Which brings us to his second idea—one that draws on ancient Greek mythology. I suppose all the greatest thinkers weave Greek mythology into their books… haha, just kidding. This idea is called *the Muse.*

The Muse is a divine source of inspiration. An infinite source of creativity. He argues that creative energy comes when you show up and do the work—even when you don't feel like it. The Muse ***only visits those who are consistent and disciplined***. You remain consistent and eventually the inspiration kicks in. All the things that the Muse has been whispering to you but you didn't hear, eventually come to your ears and you hear it crystal clear. I know this sounds a bit poetic, or too good to be true, or too delusional, but it is definitely true.

Even this book you are reading at this very moment, is a byproduct of this idea, of this approach in life in which I remained consistent and trusted that the inspiration will come to me. Honestly, I did not plan the content of this book beforehand. I had an idea of what were the most important concepts that I wanted to discuss and communicate clearly, but most of the details came after I sat down, put my glasses on and started writing. If I had focused on the voice in my head that said *'What if nobody reads it?'* — trust me, that voice appeared many times— I would never find the energy to write it. It would have remained just that, an idea. If someone reads it will be a positive outcome, but it is not a requirement for me to do the work.

For example, the whole idea of the C.O.D.E that I mentioned in an earlier chapter, was not planned either. It came while writing that chapter. I wanted to explain what I consider as important virtues in life and the fact that if you don't follow some ethical rules, life will be hard to navigate. And Boom! The idea of the C.O.D.E and the 'thin line' came. Maybe for you it does not sound like *'WOW'* o*r 'DAAMN, what did this guy come up with'* , but for me it does. And at the end of the day, I should not focus on external opinions, I should just show up and do the work. Which I did, and now you are reading *The Code Of Cadmus.*

Now, before we continue, I just want to mention that this whole idea of Resistance, the Muse, and the book in general was incredibly inspiring to me. I remember reading it at the airport, waiting for my flight from Paris to Barcelona. My phone battery had died, and I was charging it in front of the ladies' restroom—yes, that's where the charging outlet was, so don't think of me as a weirdo, haha.

When I read about Resistance and the way the author used the concept of the ancient Greek Muse as a creative whisperer to those who refuse to give up, I had another of those *"aha"* moments. It gave me goosebumps. It showed me that doing what I truly enjoy, that trusting the process of *doing something* and not focusing on external outcomes, is the **only** way forward and the only way for creativity to ignite.
There's no other way. And honestly, it is the only way to really enjoy life. At least for me.

There's no such thing as, *"Let's sit down, plan everything, and figure it out,"* or, *"Let's analyze market opportunities and brainstorm ideas."* Or any other ways of brainstorming ideas that the creative gurus tell you about. Maybe those methods work for some people, but for me, they never did—that's why I don't trust them and don't tell you that you should do them.

For me, the path is this: choose the activity that intrinsically motivates you, regardless of mood or circumstances, and just trust the process of doing it. Trust your creative energy, and everything else will fall into place. Honestly, I have applied this into my life and I have discovered so many things that bring me joy. As I said earlier, even this very book is a result of this. I've also discovered new passions like photography, cinematic video making, and, most recently, surfing.

Anyway, I just felt I wanted to share this with you and use some real life examples to make my case stronger.

Now let's move to the **last piece of the puzzle.** The question that I know you have been having for a while now reading this chapter.
We have talked about the universal force that keeps people away from doing what they truly want, and by overcoming it, you are already achieving what the majority does not. And eventually, you don't have to be scared of missing out on anything and anybody. We

have also discussed that **not caring about external outcomes and rewards** is the way to go, simply because that's the only way to fall in love with the process of doing something. If you don't care what happens after spending 3 hours doing pottery, or how the thing you are crafting will look like, then the *process of doing pottery* itself is the only thing left to care about.

And, we have also discussed the creativity part. The Muse. The inspiration that only comes to you when you are consistent enough and you dedicate yourself to the process. Once you are in the flow, and you ignore all external noises, inspiration will come to you. You deeply have to accept that and trust the process. There is no other way to come up with ideas. TRUST ME. Pushing yourself to come up with ideas is how you block ideas from coming to you.

Now, towards the last bit. The last piece of the puzzle: how to find that thing that you really love doing? I talked about the fact that the process of doing **something** is the thing to love, but then you ask, what is that **something?** How do I find it? What does it mean to do the thing through which you express yourself?

Let's use the following statement as a guide in order to fully comprehend the last piece of the puzzle: *Everything in life is in constant flux*. Therefore, love, and especially the way of loving, might also be experiencing changes along the way. Assuming that what you love doing will be found in the first attempt, is a false assumption. Believing that the thing that you love doing today will always remain the same and you will never love doing anything else in life, would be a false assumption as well. If everything in life is in constant flux, then you as well might be experiencing change. If you are experiencing change, you should accept the fact that probably the way of expressing yourself might be experiencing changes as well. Thus, **being open to change**, and being comfortable with change in general, is the first step of finding what you really love doing. The thing that will help you express yourself in the most accurate way possible.

Read the previous paragraph multiple times if you have to. It is very important.

Now, *expressing oneself* — what the heck is that you may ask? And honestly, I don't know if I can explain it in words. But fuck it, I will try anyways. Once again, I'm going the extra mile to achieve something.

Let's do it.

If you are a millennial, a couple of decades ago, you were a cute little kid. Actually, I don't know if you were cute because I don't believe that all kids are cute. So, let's just say that you were a little kid. Back then, there were a few things that you really loved doing. You were counting the hours to pass so you can do those things again. Nothing else mattered. Just doing those things was all you needed to be happy. Now, in order to find what you love doing, you have to sit down, take a pen and a piece of paper and think about what those things used to be. And write them down. Clearly.
This is ***the first step***. If you don't do that, and if you don't already know what you truly love doing, sorry, I can't help you. If you are not motivated enough to find what you love doing, I don't think I can motivate you. You are the only person capable of motivating you. And I want you to fully comprehend that if you choose to not do that, that's totally ok. We live in a free world. But if in a couple of decades, the truth comes and knocks at your door, and you blame others for what happened to you, or that it is your parents fault, or that it is the government's fault, or the society's fault or any other creature you find to blame, remember, IT WAS YOUR FUCKING CHOICE.
You decided to not do it. Understanding this is key.

And remember…

No matter what society tells you or what your parents tell you or what your bank account tells you, there is one, and only one job you have to do in this world. It is not a 9-5, it does not pay you on a monthly basis and it has no colleagues. It does not require a degree, it does not require you to apply for it on Linkedin and there is nobody to interview you for it.
It is right there, in front of you, available and open, and all you have to do is do it. Your only job in this world is to *try to find what you love doing*.
That's why there is nothing to FOMO on. Because **this is the only thing you have to do.** The only job that has no end, the only job in which you cannot fail. There is nothing

to be completed, there is nothing to be delivered. Even if you find what you love doing or not in this life, *trying* is what matters. Remember, it is the process that counts. If you do not try, you avoid doing the process. You fail to see what life has to give. If you never try, it is on you. Why? Because the only thing that is aiming to stop you, is the *Resistance* we mentioned earlier, and as we discussed, it is definitely possible to overcome it. How? By ignoring outcomes and other people's opinions and just showing up and doing the work.

That's it, there is nothing else keeping you from trying to find what you love.
Isn't that a bit comforting? Doesn't it make you a bit calmer? I mean you don't have to FOMO anymore, cause you know that *trying to find what you love* is the only thing to do. You don't have to feel like you are not in the right place anymore, or at the right party, or in the right country, or having the right amount of money or reading the correct amount of books. That's all gone now. And you cannot fail. Because you don't even have to find what you love doing. Just ***trying*** is all you have to do. I don't know, but for me it is a bit comforting.

Let me once again use myself as an example to help paint a clearer picture for you. I will share a **list of all the things from my childhood that I deeply enjoyed doing,** so you can see how simple they are and help you come up with the list of things you enjoyed doing as a kid and apply them in your adult life.

When I close my eyes and I think of my childhood, something weird happens. My mind does not even go to Athens, where I grew up. It goes straight to my parent's beach house outside of Athens. The place where, until I turned 16-17, I spent every summer of my life. When someone asks me what you liked the most in your childhood, or when I ask myself the same question that place pops up in my head. Effortlessly. And what I deeply enjoyed back then are crystal clear. Here you go:

- Waiting for the clock to hit 14:00 so I could watch all my favorite TV shows—most of them from South America, which, for some reason, made me feel incredibly curious and happy. Every time I would go to bed at night, I would check what time it was, and then imagine what a family in a country far away from mine was doing at that particular moment. Fun stuff.

- Waiting for the clock to hit 16:30 to gather with friends from the neighborhood, pack water and food into a plastic bag, hop on our bikes, and explore the nearby villages. Exploration without limits. Unlimited fun.
- Once back from the nearby village exploration, we would all gather at a friend's house — he had a huge lovely house — and we would all play together *hide and seek*. The most exciting game ever. Cannot even explain how happy I was playing that game.

That was it. That was all it took to make me happy and set my imagination wandering.

Unfortunately, last time I checked, there is no job paying you to sit down and watch TV shows, nor to cycle and explore nearby neighborhoods nor to play hide and seek. I mean, if there was, that would be cool. However, by looking deeper into the things you used to enjoy as a kid you can discover other interests in more abstract patterns and apply them into your life. These things can eventually bring you joy, fulfilment and maybe cash. Honestly, I believe this is where people get it wrong, miss the point and end up not putting the effort into discovering what might interest them in life.

For example, if you enjoyed playing with Legos as a kid, catching insects, or painting strange little things, you can use that as a clue to uncover what you might still enjoy doing today. Maybe building with Legos no longer excites you, or maybe it doesn't pay the bills, so you can't stay consistent. Instead, look at what you used to create with them and focus on that. Or simply focus on the fact that you loved creating something from scratch. That might lead you to explore handmade crafts as an adult, or if your interests are digital, you could build software or create something online.
At the end of the day, when it comes to childhood we can all agree that it was more about feeling and less about thinking. Therefore, that's what you should do. Focus on *how you felt back then*.
Maybe don't expect to think the whole thing through and come up with a clear list of interests right away. Perhaps, rationalization is not the best tool for this particular case. Instead, you can close your eyes and try to feel a bit what you used to feel as a kid when doing those things. I think you get my point.

Again, don't get frustrated if you cannot fully figure it out right away. I haven't figured out everything either. And maybe there is no such thing as *'figuring everything out'* because what does *everything* mean in the first place? Right?
As I said earlier, life is in constant flux. So, figuring out just a small little thing and making the short first step, is all it takes. Just start.

Ok— and once we figure out the list of the things we enjoyed as kids, then what? You may ask. Again, let me share my case and tell you **how I have reasoned about what kind of things I still enjoy doing** by using my childhood interests as the main input.

The whole game of hide and seek, the TV shows from countries far far away and the whole activity of hopping on your bike and exploring new territories, all had a thing in common. *Uncertainty*. Something new. Something exciting. Something I didn't know about and I was going to find out in a matter of hours. To me that's all I was craving for. As an adult, I've preserved this healthy childhood "addiction" and transformed it into a deep curiosity—an obsession with learning and understanding something new every single day. Sometimes I overdo it and base my entire self-worth on whether I've done something new or productive on a given day—which only leaves me feeling low and staring blankly at the wall for hours. But that's a whole other story. Let's avoid darkness and keep the good vibes going—*haha*.

By maintaining this constant curiosity into adulthood, I've been able to immerse myself in so many different pursuits—coding, building apps, reading books on a wide range of topics, investing, traveling the world, surfing, learning new languages, learning guitar and jamming with other musicians, exploring my own psyche and past traumas etc. Defining any of those pursuits as *The One* to do forever, or the one to use as a label for me, would be impossible. I would get really bored If I knew that I would do only one thing my whole life.

That's why, for someone like me, saying *"Oh, I want a career in finance,"* or *"I want to build apps my whole life,"* or *"I want to be a musician,"* just won't work and won't keep me consistent. And unless that's truly what the universe has in store for you, it probably won't work for you either. Why? Because it's **limiting**. It's doomed to fail because you're boxing yourself into being one particular thing for your entire life. But what did we just

say? Life is in constant flux. The better approach is to stay open—embrace whatever sparks your curiosity in a given moment. Dive in, learn the craft, and see where it takes you. Scientific studies show that 10-14 days of repetition are enough to form a habit and evaluate whether you enjoy the activity itself. If, at some point it stops fulfilling you, that's perfectly fine. Move on. But first, ***put in the hours***. Explore it fully before deciding it's not for you. And if you end up not enjoying it, you don't have to label yourself as a failure or assume that you'll never find what you love. You just tried one thing out of a billion possibilities. That means you're already one step closer to figuring it out.

So, if you keep complaining— bitch please, take a chill pill! Hahaha!

A similar side effect takes place when people quit something too early or avoid doing it in the first place—like when they adopt the *"It's okay, I'll do it tomorrow"* mentality. They tell themselves every possible excuse to justify their inaction. Unfortunately though, life operates in an accumulative way. What I mean by that is: the small things you do every day—the small actions you take—ultimately define your overall approach to life. If, on a daily basis, you're constantly looking for excuses to avoid doing something, you're not just avoiding the task—you're **teaching yourself how to avoid things in general**. And then time passes. One day you wake up and realize you haven't done all the things you once dreamed of doing. I see this pattern quite often, to be honest—people falling into it themselves or trying to pull others along with them. It has happened to me a few times as well.

That brings me back to something I mentioned earlier: I consider myself a fairly disciplined person, and I've been fortunate enough to keep my curiosity alive well into adulthood. I explore all kinds of interests. And when I choose to skip a social event to focus on my own pursuits, I see a particular behavior from people. They often say, *"Oh come on, it's just one day—you can skip it."*. Or they say something like *"Come on live a little, don't be so serious, what will happen if you don't do it one day?"*. I get these all the time.
From people who assume they know how life should be lived. From the exact same people who are stuck in a life routine they always try to escape from. Counting the days left to go on to the next holiday excursion, or for Friday to come again. Or counting the hours for the clock to hit 18:00PM so they can go home and be "themselves" again. I am not judging anybody for their choices of course. However, I can see the reasons for their

misery. No one is inherently lazy. But by constantly avoiding doing hard things, we teach ourselves how to get better at laziness.

Don't you think?

And that's the beauty of it—how seamlessly all the pieces of the puzzle come together: the consistency, the commitment to showing up and doing the work, regardless of your mood or surroundings. The action vs inaction approach to life, the *'trust the process'* when it comes to coming up with new ideas. And most importantly, the openness needed to let yourself go and eventually discover what it is that you truly love doing. Because as you can notice, it is not just about identifying the thing. But instead, about putting a lot of pieces together and constructing something worthy. It takes a character, a way of being, a preparation and a particular attitude towards life for it to come to you. And it is definitely possible. You'll see. Just start.

Does expressing oneself make a bit more sense to you now? If I had to put it into just a few words—and I mean words that actually make sense in 2025, not in some utopian, money-free world—then the craft of doing what you love, in order to express yourself, would look something like this:

> By keeping your inner child alive, by listening to what it has to say, and by being brave enough as an adult to accept that your interests can change very much and very often, you achieve what's necessary for the *Muse* to whisper to you *what you love doing really is*. By being curious enough to try new things, to try and solve problems for you first, in new and creative ways, you give yourself permission to apply your own unique ideas in a world that desperately needs them. Expressing oneself is not about reading another book, or working on a Sunday, or making millions or doing a ritual for the genius idea to pop up. No. Expressing oneself **fully depends on oneself and on nothing external.** Why? Because true self-expression is simply letting your inner child speak, without worrying about who's listening—or if anyone is listening at all.

I assume everything makes sense by now. The core idea is simple: *It is not about the external but instead about the internal.* If you know what it is that you love doing, and seriously, you are the only one to know that, there is nothing to miss out on, simply because you know exactly what you should be doing.

The question then becomes: Are you doing what you love? Or not? If you are doing what you love, there is nothing to miss. If you are not doing what you love, you are not missing out, you are just missing the point.

That is what a life worth living is all about.

The end.

不易流行

The next part of the book—the final one—is not a chapter.
It is the byproduct of a mental war that most of us go through, yet many of us feel that we can't afford to express. But I will try to express it in my own words.
Once more, I suppose I have to take my chances.

不易流行

Behind The Mask

What do I see when you see myself in the mirror?

Finally…

You have reached the deepest level of the maze.
The point where even the rules of gravity don't apply anymore. If they did, I would know exactly where to put my foot next.
But here I am — without knowing if I will be falling up or down, where do I step?

I feel like we both had to reach this depth. I most certainly did.
Thinking about the last few months of my life, doing anything else seemed completely absurd. This is the only thing I have been feeling a strong urge to do.

It is really strange, the fact that following other people's voices for years is what probably brought us here. Perhaps this is the paradox of the darkest corners of the maze. Only by listening to other people's voices you can reach such a level. But then, there is a moment that finally arrives that you realize that the only way out is by listening to your own voice. Your own intuition. The one you have been cultivating during all these years without even noticing.

But then you ask — what are we really aiming for here? Are we trying to **get out** of the maze? And what does *getting out* mean?
Often in stories, the thing to be done once caught in a maze is to get out, and by out, it is usually meant to **go back towards what the maze has been keeping you away from**.
But what if this is not what we want? What if the maze was not keeping us away from anything? Perhaps, what was once considered familiar was the reason why the maze got created for us in the first place. What if it was your inner voice that urged you to avoid the familiar—leading you instead into uncharted territories? What if the uncharted territories **are themselves the maze**? The one that needs to be explored and the one that holds the center where your own voice is the only voice that matters?

Maybe that's it.
Maybe the time has come to confront you all.
Maybe it is too soon or maybe it's too late.
Who really knows? I don't, so I will take my chances.
Even gravity decided to abandon this place so…
As the center of the maze commands, I'm just going to follow my intuition.

…

…

I have a question that I am so intrinsically drawn to ask. I know that mostly strong emotions will be the reaction to it—which is nothing to be shocked at— but not exactly what I am looking for. But fuck it, I will do it anyways.

So, can you please *tell me why?*
Why don't you shut the fuck up for a second?

Is that too hard to ask?
It's such a simple question. No?
Are you scared that if you stay quiet for a bit something terrible will happen? Honestly, I cannot find any other logical answer to why you don't shut the fuck up even for a second? Actually, you know what—maybe I should not be using logic at all for this one…

Why are you always talking? Why even without having any context, any facts, or any piece of information regarding someone's life, feelings or experiences, you still choose to say something that is completely meaningless? You do it both inside and outside my head. Why? Does society make you feel like if you don't *'contribute'* something you will be marked as *useless* forever? And you will never have the chance to change people's minds about you? Is that it?
Did your parents always expect something from you and you feel like you have a moral obligation to contribute in general? And what does it mean *to contribute?* If what you give is totally irrelevant, then what is the contribution exactly?

I know that silence is the modern human's worst enemy and yours too. This deep fear that we have against silence, is probably what leads to this world's major problems. The constant need to say something, no matter the validity of it, automatically reflects the quality of most interactions today. Fortunately, nature exists to keep the bar high. While nature gives us abundance without losing quality, things made by humans in abundance are usually not as good. For example, nature gives us water, and photosynthesis gives us vast amounts of oxygen. Great. Meaningful. You on the other hand? Spilling out every little thought that pops into your head? Definitely not great. Definitely not meaningful. In both cases we have vast amounts of something, however, you see how the human made one is not that necessary.

I am still not sure why all this is happening. Is it the productivity driven mentality of today's society that makes us feel like we always have to bring something to the table? Without even questioning if the table really needs what we brought, or without even asking ourselves: *"Are we at the right table at all?"*?
And isn't it a bit ironic? Due to our urge to constantly contribute without ever considering the quality of what we offer—and with the binary, black-and-white mentality that reigns over our society—we end up producing more noise than meaning. And then the very thing we feared the most actually happens: people form opinions about us that are almost impossible to change. Opinions that mark us for years to come. We are so desperately attached to what others think of us. Labels—those strange badges that modern humans both glorify and fear at the same time. How can you expect a society to function—let alone function well—when people constantly talk and generate noise just for the sake of it? When judging others solely on what's quickly visible to them and only based on the very first piece of information they see? Expecting a functional society is not daydreaming. It is wishful thinking. It is almost reaching levels of insanity. Frantz Fanon is probably shaking in his grave.

But I don't blame you. Well, at least not anymore. You are not my problem to solve. Regardless though, you still don't shut the fuck up. Even if I don't bother you anymore. Or blame you. You keep squealing at me with your high-pitched voices. Like I asked for your opinion or something. You see me calm at a table— the wrong or the right one— you see me in peace, and there you come, you start all over again. Saying the things you want to say, with your presumptuous claim to empiricism, to knowledge or even to

expertise. Assuming what you are saying is right without even questioning yourself, or without considering if I want you to share things with me in the first place. Without asking for permission to bother. Like you have the throne or someone gave you authority over what is wrong and what is right.
That probably occurs because accepting that you don't know much will make you feel very uncomfortable. Very small. Your mask will drop and then all the dead will know… *This is the fool who thought he knew a lot.*

But I ask you—would it really be so bad to accept that you don't know much? To sit comfortably on a chair, next to someone else, without feeling the urge to speak? Without feeling the need to prove yourself for once? To know that whether the person beside you thinks highly or poorly of you makes no difference at all. Wouldn't that be nice, just for once? And what if that fear of yours—that you might be labelled *X* or *Y* and that you will never change it—simply vanished? Would you enjoy it? Or would you start doubting yourself again? That you must be doing something terribly wrong in order to feel such safety?

I don't know. Seriously, I have no idea. Will it be so devastating to let the masks drop? Will everything burn to the ground if we choose to show our true selves for once? Without worrying about how high the monetary reward will be, or what the status to be achieved will be. Is it going to be so catastrophic for us? I don't think so. It might be catastrophic for this system that we live in. Yes. But not for us. The numbers in the bank, the amount of clothes in the closet, or the square footage of your house do not matter to anybody. No one wakes up or goes to sleep thinking how smart, how good, how rich or how poor you are. No. No one does that. No one gives a fuck. It is only when the society and the system put their everything into praising these things that they start to feel important again. And there you are, back in the same loop, picking the mask that best fits the conditions of the day. Following the trend of the day.

So what is it then? Can you be honest for once?
Is it *shame*? Is that the feeling you are so scared of? That once people know that you are not perfect, everyone will ditch you and you will stay behind? And, what is ***behind***? And who is ***ahead***? Again, using the past to scare yourself and the future to avoid your present.

Is it really that rough? Has showing your truth become unbearable? Perhaps.
But wait a second. Revealing your true self might have a positive outcome no? Wouldn't it make everything easier instead? You would not have to pretend all the time.
The fact that you might not like someone but never having the choice of expressing it because it would make other people uncomfortable would not be a problem anymore, right? And imagine that, we avoid honesty between two human beings, because it might end up being uncomfortable for a third party that is not even involved. How ironic? Even for the participants it might not be that bad. But it might be for the surroundings. And oh my, what a shame that would fall upon us if our surroundings do not think high of us? So, what do we do? Well, we continue the infinite chatter. The useless noise. The chitchat. The conformity. So we can all smile together in the cameras while dying inside. But let's not be all negative and think of it from a different angle: What if I really liked you so much, but all the inner conflict and self-doubting kept me from saying it out loud? Wouldn't that be a pity?

So, I beg you. All of you that have teamed up and are trying to conquer my **Broca's area**. Tell me, what is it then? That keeps you from shutting the fuck up? I mean, you keep jabbering, non stop, all the time, but you can't seem to answer this particular question of mine. Why is that?

But as I said earlier, I don't blame you. Don't worry. I know why you are doing all this. They made sure that you will always be like this. It is impossible for you to remain silent simply because in today's world silence is a sign of *weakness.* And when I say silence I mean from both a talking and a taking action perspective. Staying both quiet and still. Wow, this society does everything in its power to prevent people from ever experiencing that. Pure silence. Sitting there, effortlessly, without talking, without doing. How wonderful?

That's why I don't blame you anymore. That is the only way for you to *survive* and maybe *thrive* in this society. Only if such a state in such an environment could be called *thrive.*
In a society that points fingers like its life depends on it— which kinda does— you want to make sure that the finger is never pointed towards you. Make sure you are always safe. Even if you are always fake. And what is the best way to achieve that? By participating…by playing your role. Fucking hell, you and your roles all the time!

You do not want to be the person perceived as lazy, not smart enough, or not busy enough. No no. These are not just words, these are curses in today's society. What you crave instead, are all the titles and the labels that society praises and promotes as the most essential virtues to possess. You know which labels I'm referring to.
The brilliant mind, the logic expert, the math genius, the incredible engineer, the badass coder or the corporate wolf who never breaks under pressure. Without these titles, you will never achieve the highest of statuses. Only if you have made big moves, and you never left any opportunity untaken will you be worshiped. Only then. Only when you are the toughest, the coldest and the most consistent. Only when you never show any sign of weakness or sensitivity. Only then will you be deemed worthy. Right?

That's how they keep us on a leash. By holding us in a state of constant contradiction. On one hand, they instill in us the relentless urge to contribute, to say something, to add to the noise — without giving it the time or thought it deserves. And on the other hand, by ensuring that everyone's views and approaches to life are deeply polarized, they guarantee that once we make a mistake our ideal images will be destroyed in a matter of seconds. And who has the energy to start from scratch? All over again? To rebuild that image and change people's opinions? Such a hard task to undertake. I know.
But then, what happens after? You fear that if you don't say the right thing at the right time, you won't be seen as the smartest in the room. And yet, more often than not, what you say has barely crossed your mind before leaving your mouth. So, you want to contribute and be seen as smart while only thoughtless words come out of your mouth. Such a contradiction. Or worse — you never wanted to say anything at all, but they made you feel as if you had to. That's the world. The world that keeps you always on edge. Never relaxed. Never satisfied.

I can see the world's reflection in every word that you use. When you judge me based on filters that you never chose. When you project things on me or on others that you haven't managed to deal with yet. I know when you say something from love, even if it is toxic, or when you are jealous and scared. I know when you don't care about me anymore but admitting it out loud will make many third parties upset, and you can't have that. In a conformity-first lived life, such a behavior is unacceptable. Right? It is obvious to me when you just try to keep the pattern alive, even if it does not serve us anymore. It gives us nothing in return. You tell yourself that because something used to be good, it has to

remain like that forever. But you forget that life is in constant flux. And it's ok. It makes sense why you forgot. You never had the time to remember. You spent all your energy keeping the chatter going. On *autopilot*. To check all the boxes. To be a good civilian.
I know. And imagine that I don't know much.

You see the irony again right? We are scared that technology will come and take over our jobs and our lives. That robots are the threat, we say. When the majority lives on *autopilot* already, and almost completely numbed when it comes to resonating emotionally with someone else. But robots are the senseless ones. I guess Carl Jung is laughing in his grave when he sees us humans project our insecurities on robots. Isn't that wild? Human nature won't be stopped nor changed by anybody who types colorful words on a black screen. I guess that calms me down a bit. Especially when I know that that someone will not be me. No more reason to FOMO.

Do you understand now? That there is no time for bullshit? That cutting the cord is what you must do? And you will achieve it by putting your mask down. At least when talking to me. At least when you talk to the people that you feel 'close to you'. I mean, you cannot tell me the same things over and over again without any solid argument and expect me to behave as you wish. You, entering the circle when third parties decide it, does not automatically make you an insider or one of us. And vice versa. Exiting will not get you permanently forgotten or excluded. And do you get it now that you have to fully comprehend the reasons behind your actions and words? Are you doing all this because you really want to? Or because you are scared? Jealous? Angry? Sad? Shut the fuck up and ask yourself. I will be right here. Experiencing it all. Waiting for you to finally get close.

We will all be able to enjoy each other's company in a more profound and honest way if we do that. It will be more real. Don't you see? Understanding who is pulling the strings of our behaviors is the first step into cutting those strings. The strings that generate actions that do not serve us anymore. Actions that are fueled by childhood complexes and insecurities instead of pure reasoning and good intentions. Light will be shed and answers will be given to the big questions. The questions that concern if we really love each other, or if we really enjoy each other's company. Do we keep in touch because we want to? Or is it because we have to? Because of a third party's inability to manage discomfort.

Just think about it. Maybe take a break from all the screaming.
I won't judge you. ***I am not you.***

…
…

Did you take a break?
Did you ask yourself why? Why is it this way? Or you ignored me again?
If deep inside most of us are suffering from that social structure and such behavioral rules, why do we keep repeating the pattern? Is someone benefiting from all this? Does someone want us to be like this? Of course. What did you think?
They have figured out that the greatest threat to their system is a human who takes a step back and pauses. One who does not immediately react. One who stays silent for a moment, does nothing, and understands that free time for thinking is a weapon. For them, that's the ***biggest threat to their system.***

Woh…wait a second— I feel that me and you, we have discussed this before. It almost feels like a déjà vu. On another day? Another life? Maybe just in another chapter.
Have we ever talked about having free time for oneself? What does it mean? And what can it lead to? Hmm, maybe. Interesting…

Anyway, I'll keep repeating myself and say that **I don't blame you anymore**. It makes perfect sense why you continue this way. This is the burned-out society. This is our society. I mean, let's observe the mirror a bit more. Let me take a closer look and tell you what I see.

People in their cubicles, inside big, fancy buildings or fancy clothes, finding every possible way to prove to others that they're busy, that they're important, that they have a say in all this. Obviously, the little, sneaky system does not let them go. Instead it rewards them with fancy titles. The titles that have 10 words in them and still make no sense. And ironically, the more senior the title is, the less work you do. If you know, you know.
In such an environment, taking a step back and pausing is ***seen as losing.*** There's no room for that kind of behavior here. And maybe that's what exacerbates the problem: a society with polarized, binary views, where no one can be seen as motionless. And the

better you repeat the pattern? The more you're rewarded with yet another fancy word in your title. Now, what a piece of art is our little society right? It is definitely something!

I remember I was talking with **one of you** in real life a few years ago, and we were discussing ***ego***, and why you snap like that when people trigger something in you. I told you that it is not really ***you*** who is reacting, but instead, it is your ego defending you. And you said to me these exact words, with your high pitched voice: *'What do you mean? My ego is me.'*. I had already read the books by then, and I knew, right at that moment. That's the root of the problem: blurring the boundaries between identities is what brought us here. Again, such a poetic irony. We cultivate something in order to survive in this competitive and tough world that ends up owning us. Or even destroying us. I still haven't figured it out yet though. Why are some of us so possessed by our ego that we cannot even control it, and we end up making decisions purely based on our ego's desire?
I guess if you spent some time online today you would have your answer.
Online is never about: *Do this, and maybe do this, and probably this will happen, so you can acquire this.* No. It is never like that. Online it is always extremes like: *Do this, and if you don't, you will never do it again. That's the only way. Only losers avoid it.*

So—again— in such an environment, with a now or never approach, I don't blame you anymore.

We're both programmed this way. But, the difference lies in awareness — in how deeply we notice ourselves playing the part. That awareness decides everything: whether we keep looping through the same pattern, or finally break free from it. But in order to become truly aware, you have to do the very thing that scares you — the thing you've never done because even the thought of it never made you feel safe.
I am here to remind you though that there is no such thing as *'feeling safe'* in chaos.
However, ***chaos knows how to keep you safe***. That's the beauty of it. But the system does not point you towards that, because if you were in chaos for long enough you would realize that most of it you cannot control. You would realize that trying to control it will only affect you in a negative way. And eventually, after many attempts, you would calm down. You would pause. You would not react. You would stay still, and maybe you would do the thing that the system is so deeply scared of you doing: *Think for yourself.*

That is probably why you scream at me all the time. You always have something to say. You have something to say even if you don't have to say anything at all. Apparently, the scientific fact that was supposed to make us enjoy life more is also a two-sided coin. *When you do more, you think less.* That was the idea. But look at us— we found another way to fuck something up that was meant to have a positive effect on us.
Yet once again, another truth emerges, one that deteriorates our experience of life and shifts the odds out of our favor. We do more, and we think less, while what we do is mostly of low quality. Or to be more precise, what we do is not what we chose for ourselves, but what others chose for us. Which I assume is the same as living life in a lesser quality.

I mean where should I start? Scrolling? Avoiding the truth? Avoiding pain? Judging? Envying? Numbing our brains and bodies in any way we can? Playing with people's feelings? So many ways we found to fuck things up. I guess society trained us very well.

We are trained to have a curriculum. We are trained to act based on a protocol, based on what someone who is seen as an authority figure tells us to do. When we choose to act that way though, we are closing the door to *Chaos*. We don't allow it in. We prefer instead the comfort of our chair, the warmth of our bed, the security of our inner circle. The circle that all it does is just confirming what we want to hear. Even if what we want to hear is not good for us at all. Just for our ego. Confirmation bias 101.
That's why you should never accept anyone or anything as an unquestionable authority. Simply because you don't need one. You've only been programmed to think you do. And here's life, playing its sneaky paradoxical games again. Wanting to be the boss guarantees you'll have a boss too. Isn't that ironic? You can't boss others without being bossed by something — or someone — yourself. But again, I'm talking to you like you will listen. Like you care or like you will do something about all this. I assume I still have some optimism inside me. I still believe things can change for the better. Maybe I am just foolish. Or maybe in 2025 foolish and optimistic are just synonyms. Who knows?

Let me drink some water please. My mouth is dry from all the inner chatting with you.
…
…

Now—a few more questions arise: who is to be considered an authority figure? Who is choosing this figure to be the authority in the first place? Of course, I know you don't care about getting political, or sociological or analysing how a state forms, so I will keep all this out for now. But If I exclude these things, I have to do something that I promised that I wouldn't do. And I told you to not worry about it. I guess we all lie in one way or another. It is time for all of you to ***take responsibility for your actions.*** You cannot blame the society, the government, your parents or your bad luck for everything that happens to you, and then the very next moment go and repeat the same exact patterns as they did. You are all so arrogantly occupying my **Broca's area**, acting omnipotent, but when it comes to taking responsibility you all take a step back and just get louder. Creating even more noise to distract yourselves from the fact that you are wrong.

You cannot outsource your life's most important decisions to others and expect things to end well for you. You cannot expect that a government will take care of you when you are old and retired. You cannot expect to have a child, hand them over to the public education system, and expect them to become a wonderful human being without any negative traits. You cannot keep putting your mask on at social gatherings pretending everything is fine and boasting about how important your job is — only to go home feeling sad and empty, searching for new ways to numb yourself. You simply cannot do that. And most importantly, you cannot scream at me and tell me that this is what I should be doing too. That I should follow these patterns blindly and behave accordingly in public. No. Instead of doing this, try shutting the fuck up for a change. Seriously.

…
…

Ok—sorry if I screamed at you.
I guess I had to return the favor.

I hope by now you have realized how important this is. You have falsely assumed, and blindly accepted, that your parents, or your friends' parents, or your teachers, or someone with a suit on, know what they are talking about. That they know the facts, the data, the science, your feelings, your experiences and your thoughts, when they tell you what you should or should not be doing. That is a false assumption. But I know that you wanted

different things in life, and other people's limitations limited you. I see it crystal clear. After all, imperfect people make our lives imperfect.

But as I said, they do not know all your facts. Some of them want good things for you though, yes. But intentions show you ***what others feel for you***. Intentions don't show you ***the way.*** Both are important, definitely, but you have to understand that you need both. Receiving love while you are pushed at the end of a hill, won't do you much. That's why you should not take everything at face value. They might mean well, but they don't know how. They might mean bad, but they ended up showing you the way. And who knows, sooner or later, you might not be screaming at me all the time. So loudly.

Therefore, you realize that it is inevitable. You have to cut the cord. Mentally. The subconscious one. You have to take ownership of your life. You should not depend on other's opinions or other people's life choices. Accept that you have both bad and good traits in you. Why else do you think we managed to come up with the devils and the gods? Maybe that was our unique way of projecting our bright and dark traits on something that we cannot physically experience. Again, outsourcing responsibility, but with a deeper meaning now, a meaning that I am not the one to define as right or wrong.

It takes a lot of courage to take ownership of your life, I know. And probably the hard times will outnumber the easy ones— by tenfold. But you have to do it. Otherwise it will be an infinite torture. A torture that no matter the excuse you will come up with, it does kill parts of yourself, because you are a human being too. You cannot live a life full of pretending, when it is **deeply embedded into your nature, the need to be truly seen by others**. How could you be convinced that you received love, if you never show them what is truly there to be loved in the first place? I mean, how could you survive all this unharmed? Without a single scar? Impossible.

I suppose that this has been the biggest lie of them all. The promise that was never kept. The one that I made to myself too, and I'm not sure I kept it. As a matter of fact, I know I didn't. This idea, this belief, that in such hard and turbulent times that we live in, if you tried ***to make it*** and actually ***succeeded*** there would be only light at the end of the tunnel. You would cross to the other side and be happy, fulfilled, satisfied, completely unharmed.

But how could that be? I recall trying to pursue myself that no matter what I do in life, whatever way I choose to make my way to freedom, I would be able to look myself in the mirror at the end and still recognize who I am. That I would not turn myself into a monster just for the sake of making it. Did I manage to do it? I don't know.
It does not feel like it. Maybe there is no such thing as *making it* after all.
Or no such thing as *freedom*.
Making it probably means different things to different people.
At the end of the day, what does it really mean to be a *monster*?
Perhaps when I was making that promise to myself I was too young and too naive.
All I wanted to make sure was that I won't reach a point where I have betrayed my principles in order to achieve something. Especially if that something was not really desired by my very soul, but instead others told me that's what I should desire.
As a matter of fact, maybe that's what a monster is— a creature that moves around without control, without making conscious decisions, with behaviors merely driven by its ego. Who knows? Maybe we all have been monsters once in our lifetime.

I still recognize myself when I look at myself in the mirror though. Maybe I was wrong and there is indeed no such thing as *making it* in life. Perhaps it exists and it can actually be done. Maybe all this is just proof that I never actually made it. Again, who knows?
I mean, who knows what is real and what isn't?

Just look how fake all the parts of the system are. So fragile. The slightest glitch can turn everything into dust. Where should I start?
The money? The investments? The debts? The statuses? The achievements? All the constant preaching? The idolisation of human beings who have positions of power? What else? I don't know. The fact that the modern world's geniuses are the ones who send rockets to other planets and say they do things for the good of humanity and people actually believe them? Is that it? Did we solve all the problems here on Earth and now we are planning to go camping on Mars? Haha, seriously, is that what keeps you FOMOing all the time? That frightens you and keeps you from shutting the fuck up? And I have to pay the price listening to you 24.7? Fucking hell.

I mean just look at it. It is all fake. A distraction. A distraction from the truth. Even if we tell ourselves that we have evolved so much in the last century, facing the truth still remains unbearable. Still remains something that we simply cannot do.
I don't know. Again, don't worry, I still don't blame you. It is just that these things make me very emotional.

The problem though isn't that we struggle to face the truth. Stronger people, with stronger minds, many years ago struggled with it too. Books have been written. Who are we to overcome this? The Facebook kids? The Instagram influencers? Will solve the riddle once and for all? Haha, I don't think so. But it is ok, we don't have to. Nonetheless, we shouldn't run away from it. We should not panic and freeze even when just thinking about it. We should never act when in panic. That's the worst time to act. Perhaps that's why they want you to constantly speak, to constantly be loud and make noise. Or to constantly be stressed and scared. Maybe they figured it out that that's the way for you to do whatever they want.

I hope you have realized by now what this hard truth that I am talking about really is. Everyone is scared of it, because it is indeed scary. I won't reveal it in words, because I still believe that you have the capacity to acknowledge it.

But let me tell you something that's no secret: I'm like you at times. I also make noise because I want to be seen as something that they convinced me is worthy to be seen as. I also daydream, imagining all the ambitious scenarios this system has planted on my list of desires—the statuses, the limitless wealth, the power. The '*my name echoes into eternity*' kind of dreams. Of course, I do that too at times. For me though, they come and go. At first, they feel omnipotent, as if they'll be the ultimate source of motivation for the years to come. But they fade faster than they arrive. I'm not sure if that's because achieving them is so difficult, or because I'm not capable, or maybe they're no longer worth as much to me. I suppose I'll just choose whichever explanation makes me feel better about myself. That's what we all have been doing so far, right?

I said so many times that I don't blame you anymore. Is it true though? Or deep down, do I already know that now that I am aware of you all, claiming my freedom is fully on me? If I keep repeating the pattern or if I break free from it so completely on me.

Perhaps, that's why I don't blame you. I have identified you all, and I know how hard it is to start from scratch. Maybe that's why I don't let myself loose. I don't allow myself to make mistakes publicly. Maybe that's why I remain silent. I probably don't even want it. Like you, I might really need to scream very loud. And let myself go. But I don't do it. At least in public. Probably that is just PTSD at its finest.

When you know that there is nothing or no one to really have your back you cannot risk it all just in the heat of a moment. Even if there are things and people that want to have your back, they can't. I told you, intentions show feelings, not ways. Maybe that is the price to be paid when you break the cycle. The pattern. Your group's pattern. Your family generation's pattern. No one can really help you even if they deeply want to. I mean, you cannot expect everyone to be able to handle your madness. I don't know. Maybe I don't let myself relax because I care too much about the ideal image. My ideal image. Or maybe, I have fully grasped that wisdom is in the silence. Who knows. I suppose I have to scream more every now and then and see what comes.
I mean, you look so happy when you do it — why not me?

But once again, as I said, I don't blame you. I don't blame those who couldn't stand the pressure. If you feel anything for me though, I beg you, please be quiet.

And just like that—I turn the lights off before I go to bed. After I spent an hour talking to myself and to the voices in my head in front of the mirror. Now it's time for a deep sleep. The only time the voices never bother me. How ironic? The thing we are so scared of— when its time comes— might not be that bad after all.

I'm glad I shared this with you.

So—now what?

Well—I said what I had to say. I let it almost all out.
Anything else that remained untold is not meant to be shared.

How do I feel? Definitely lighter. Probably with less FOMO that everything might end out of nowhere tomorrow and I won't have shared my views. That I would be forgotten without ever being heard. Now you are free to forget about me, because I know that, at least until now, you have paid attention. You heard.

So, what is to come? You may ask.

What is to be done from now on?

Fortunately, you only have to do a thing or two. Seriously, that's it. We already talked about it. But even if you don't, the transition is already happening. Slowly. In the background. You cannot stop it. It has been building up for years. An actual shift. The event that will not change everything overnight simply because it has been unfolding for years. It is that powerful. It is coming like a powerful ocean wave to take us all with it.

A significant amount of people, compared to the world's population, have felt it and have taken action, and that's all it takes for things to change. This event brought gravity back into the center of the maze and the maze automatically turned into a map. Without clear paths, of course. But paths designed based on pure intuition. The riddle has been resolved by the few, and the side effects will be felt by the many. A significant amount of people have taken their masks off. The awareness behind the observer who constantly observes is finally obvious. There is nothing more to be achieved. That was the only achievement needed, and it has been accomplished. Everything from now on is just the next logical step towards the right direction.

So, what should you do? If you haven't been aware, all you have to do is just that, ***be aware***. Doubt. Ask. Investigate. Feel. Don't suppress. Don't live on autopilot. Don't outsource your life's biggest choices to others simply because it is the easiest thing to do. Don't judge others without having all the facts. Actually, fuck it, don't judge others at all. Do something more interesting with your life than dealing with other people's lives all the time. Embrace the chaotic world we live in. Don't take anything for granted. Assume things will go wrong, and don't try to control everything. Think for yourself. Read. Put the fucking hours in. Don't just go work and brag about how great you are at it. Don't brag just because you are doing one thing very well. Most jobs are fucking useless in 2025

anyway. They are just there to keep the debt cycle going. Seriously, books have been written. Build honest relationships. Don't keep old ones just to keep people happy if they don't contribute anything valuable to your life. Read art. Make art. Whatever form. Make music, paint, write, design, photograph, filming, crafts, whatever you fucking want. Be honest. Don't be sneaky and don't play games with people. Respect yourself and others. And again, think for yourself.

Oh…even if I promised to myself I wouldn't do it, with all the data coming in and the last 5 years of my life, I have to say it at least in one paragraph in the whole book.
Invest! And most importantly, invest in fucking crypto. Not because it is the greatest thing ever made by humans, or that it will bring down governments or set you free. No. None of that is probably true. Most of it is a scam, like everything else in the fiat system. Nor because the tech is remarkable and we will be using cryptocurrencies to pay for our groceries. No. Not for that either. Do it because it is the only way to make generational wealth if you are not coming from a rich family. Seriously, there is no other way if you are not already rich. Again, books have been written.
And unless you are not like me, and you want to work until you are 70 at a job you don't like and expect governments to take care of you, then ok, don't do it. But if you think it is capitalistic or materialistic to talk about investing and generational wealth in 2025, then perhaps I've failed to make my point in this book entirely.

So, I will try one last time to convince you.
Fuck labels. Fuck intelligence. Fuck big moves. Fuck making it in this world. And most importantly, fuck this system.
Invest so you can ***acquire time***. Not money.
Both are useful. But time is priceless and not replaceable. I can't say the same for money though. Never trade the first for the second. I really hope you get that.

…

Then you may ask, what if I am already aware? What if I have time? What then?
Well— congrats. You are ready to live this absurd experience more vividly than most.
What are you waiting for?

Live the experience. Create. Don't just consume. Create things through which you express yourself and ideally generate positive experiences for others. Teach through your creations. Communicate messages that are super important and need to be read by the many. Learn new things but also find some idle time. Get bored. It will open more mental doors for you. Stare at the wall, it is totally fine. Actually, it is highly advisable.
I mean, what else should you do? Work? Huh, fuck that!

So, that's what I believe you should do. And now I'm so jealous, I wish someone had told me what I told you in the last few paragraphs when I was 18.

That's all. That was my book. My first lovely book.
Quite an emotional moment I must admit. I know I promised that we will talk about what a life worth living is all about and how to navigate 2025 and the years to come. And I want to believe that we achieved that, right? But again, if we focus on the years to come and we put our everything into making sure that we will be living well in the future, maybe we are missing the present. And maybe we are missing the point entirely.
Therefore, I won't try to explain anything else in greater depth. Instead, I'll close with a short story. I'll take you back exactly nine years — and when I say exactly, I mean it: the very same day as I'm writing this paragraph, only nine years earlier. Synchronicities are real. Check it out.

I am 21 years and a few months old, and just got into a flight from Athens to London. For the first time in my life, I moved abroad, to start a new life. Getting on the plane was nothing stressful for me, I never felt any hesitation, nor any thrill about the new beginning. Just neutral. When I arrived in London though, things became quite strange. You see, I missed my bus to Brighton, and I had to wait almost till midnight to get the next one, which would arrive around 20 minutes past 1:00 AM to its destination. Everything was super grey, very humid, and of course, it was raining while I was waiting by the bus station. It was very quiet and almost felt like I was in the middle of nowhere. At that very moment, I had 3 hours to kill, so I did what I did best. I smoked and I smoked, then I drank a beer, and then I smoked a bit more. After almost 2 hours, out of nowhere, fear and anxiety kicked in for the first time. It was very weird. I was feeling my pulses going up and my stomach quite tight. Even my legs got a bit shaky. I mean, I moved to another country, to start a new life, and until then, for

months, I never felt anything. That moment though everything kicked in. A storm of feelings and thoughts. *What am I doing here? Why am I doing it? What if everything goes wrong?*
I even got my phone out and looked for a flight back to Athens. Seriously, I found myself obsessively scrolling on my phone, searching for flights, while rainwater on the screen made it hard to even type. Complete mess! I didn't have a UK sim card yet, so I was on roaming data from my Greek number. The signal was TERRIBLE! After some time of complete breakdown, I realised that it was almost time to catch my bus. The bus had arrived, but I was literally not getting on it! That very moment I really had to make a choice. Probably one that would define the years to come. All of a sudden, an old guy came out of the bus who looked like he could easily be on a cast for a Harry Potter movie. He said these exact words to me: *'Are you getting on? You won't be making it to Brighton tonight unless you get on the bus young fella! Come on, hop on!'*
You know, with that wonderful English accent that makes everything cinematic. He said to me don't worry I will give you a hand with your bags. Which he did, he actually got my big suitcase and put it in the bus for me. I was not sure if I would get on the bus, but my suitcase was already in, hah crazy! Then all of a sudden, I stopped thinking, I finished my cigarette and I made the step. I got onto the bus. Of course when I arrived in Brighton there was an issue with the flat I was supposed to live in and I was left in the street with my baggage looking for a place to stay, at 2 AM! Terrible haha! But that's another story for another time.

All I want you to take from my book, and from my story, is this: life's most important decisions are never easy to make. Sometimes you have to do things completely by yourself. Even when others want to help you, if you are choosing a different path, they simply can't help you. A time will come when you find yourself alone, and all kinds of thoughts — all kinds of voices — will rise out of nowhere. Doubts and fears will rush in, doing everything they can to keep you from acting. But you must remember: these are the defining moments of your life. When every thought and feeling urges you to retreat, to give in to fear — take it as a sign of growth and take the fucking step.

Long story short, as I said, I got on the bus. And the bus didn't just take me to Brighton. It took me closer to a life worth living.

The end.

Remember to follow the ***eye****.*
It *will show you the way.*

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References

Links to concepts and books if you want to go deeper.

This References section will be what I wished someone had shown me when I was 18 years old. I wish someone would have said to me, *You don't have to read 1,000 books or spend a decade searching. These are the concepts and books you need in order to expand your mind and understand the world better.* But once again, life does not work that way.

Think of this list as the topology of a mesh network. Each reference in the list is a node, linked to another node in and outside of that very list. Maybe you end up expanding my list— I'm actually counting on it.

A book or concept from my list might speak to you in a completely different way than it did to me—and in that difference, you might uncover entirely new ideas of your own. That's the beauty of it. I'm sharing it because I believe these are some of the most essential concepts to grasp if we want to understand life more fully—both **scientifically** and **artistically**. If this book has taught you anything worth passing on, let it be that these two perspectives are not just complementary, but ***equally necessary.***

List Of Concepts

Psyche & Inner Work

1. Shadow Integration
2. Inner Conflict Awareness
3. Ego, Superego, Ideal Image & Their Interconnectedness
4. Identity Processing
5. Cognitive Dissonance
6. Emotional Regulation & Metacognition
7. Observer vs Observed *(https://kfoundation.org/the-observer-and-the-observed/)*
8. Three Ego States: Parent, Child, Adult

Society, Science, Technology & Economy

1. Attention Economy
2. Modern Monetary Theory
3. Debt Based Economy
4. Psychological Biases
5. Universal Entropy
6. Neuroplasticity
7. Brain Structure
8. Brain & Body Connection
9. Brain Waves
10. Human Nature
11. Behavioral Psychology
12. Behavioral Economics
13. Information Theory
14. Market Cycles (Business, Debt, Real Estate)
15. Network Architecture & Topology
16. Chaos Theory
17. Cognitive & Authority Bias
18. Systems Thinking
19. First Principles Thinking
20. Surveillance Capitalism
21. Social Engineering (FOMO in particular)
22. Quantum Thinking
23. Synthetic Media
24. Narrative Controls
25. Blockchain & Decentralized systems
26. AI & Crypto (Their integration via AI Agent Payment Systems)
27. Antifragility
28. Investor Psychology
29. Status Games

Art

1. Music Theory
2. Chord Triads & Inversions (from a guitar perspective, might apply on other instruments too)
3. Self Expression via Creation
4. Means Of Art
5. Cinematic Photography
6. Cinematic Video Making
7. Alternative Cinema
8. Theta Waves & Creativity (Art & Science mix)
9. Writing To Communicate
10. The Art Of Storytelling

These are some concepts — or just terms you can search about — that I strongly believe can make you understand yourself and the world better. They are not listed in an order based on their significance. You can pick and start from whichever you fancy. Of course, they interest me deeply, that is why I am sharing them. But I am not saying that there is nothing else in the world worthy enough to be read. Of course not!

Anyway, I hope you find at least one of them interesting and once you dig deeper into that topic a whole new world will open up for you.

Now, to the list of books. It would be impossible to list down all the books I have read or all the books that interest me. It is impossible to even remember them all. I will use my memory and intuition to share with you the ones that have helped me a lot all these years and I believe will help you too. Once again, I really hope they will open up new worlds for you.

List Of Books

1. **The Big Picture** – *Sean Carroll* ~ Combines physics with philosophy to explain the universe and our place in it.

2. **Technofeudalism** – *Yanis Varoufakis* ~ Explores how technology reshapes the global economy and power structures.

3. **Antifragile: Things That Gain from Disorder** – *Nassim Nicholas Taleb* ~ Shows how to benefit and grow stronger from chaos and uncertainty.

4. **The War of Art** – *Steven Pressfield* ~ A guide to overcoming resistance and unlocking creative potential.

5. **Mastering the Market Cycle** – *Howard Marks* ~ Understanding and navigating financial market cycles for better investment decisions.

6. **The Psychology of Money** – *Morgan Housel* ~ Lessons on the human behaviors that influence financial success.

7. **Meditations** – *Marcus Aurelius* ~ Stoic reflections on self-discipline, virtue, and perspective.

8. **Apology of Socrates** – *Plato* ~ Socrates' defense of philosophy and the examined life.

9. **Discourses** – *Epictetus* ~ Practical Stoic wisdom for living with purpose and resilience.

10. **Letters from a Stoic** – *Seneca* ~ Timeless advice on life, death, and personal integrity.

11. **On the Shortness of Life** – *Seneca* ~ A reminder that life is short and must be lived with intention.

12. **Beyond Good and Evil** – *Friedrich Nietzsche* ~ Challenges moral absolutes and explores the nature of truth.

13. **Notes from Underground** – *Fyodor Dostoevsky* ~ A deep dive into human psychology, alienation, and free will.

14. **The Stranger** – *Albert Camus* ~ An existential look at life, death, and the absurd.

15. **Thus Spoke Zarathustra** – *Friedrich Nietzsche* ~ A poetic-philosophical work introducing the Übermensch and eternal recurrence.

16. **Inferno** – *Dante Alighieri* ~ A vivid journey through the circles of Hell, rich in symbolism.

17. **The Creative Act** – *Rick Rubin* ~ A guide to cultivating creativity as a way of being.

18. **The Denial of Death** – *Ernest Becker* ~ Explores how fear of mortality shapes human behavior.

19. **Hidden Repression** – *Alex Gladstein* ~ How the IMF and the World Bank enslave every country that needs refinancing. Real facts.

20. **The Matter with Things** – *Iain McGilchrist* ~ An in-depth exploration of brain hemispheres, reality, and meaning.

21. **Capital Wars** – *Michael Howell* ~ How global capital flows influence economies and politics.

22. **The Perennials** – *Mauro F. Guillén* ~ How to thrive in a world where age boundaries are dissolving. *Also read **2030** from the same author.*

23. **The Road to Character** – *David Brooks* ~ A call to build moral depth over superficial success.

24. **The Hidden Cost of Money** – Sebastien Bunney. ~ Revealing how money weaves its influence throughout our social, economic, and political spheres.

25. **The Price of Tomorrow** – *Jeff Booth* ~ Why deflation is inevitable and can lead to a better future.

26. **The Body Keeps the Score** – *Bessel van der Kolk* ~ How trauma affects the body and mind, and how to heal.

27. **Read Write Own** – *Chris Dixon* ~ A vision for a new internet era based on ownership and decentralization.

28. **The Status Game** – *Will Storr* ~ How status drives human behavior and shapes society.

29. **Stillness Is the Key** – *Ryan Holiday* ~ The power of slowing down and cultivating inner peace.

30. **Dead in the Water** – *Matthew Campbell & Kit Chellel* ~ A true story of crime, corruption, and maritime mystery.

31. **Seven and a Half Lessons About the Brain** – *Lisa Feldman Barrett* ~ Short insights into how the brain really works.

32. **Chaos** – *James Gleick* ~ An introduction to chaos theory and its impact on science and life.

33. **Infinite Powers** – *Steven Strogatz* ~ The history and beauty of calculus as the language of the universe.

34. **How the World Really Works** – *Vaclav Smil* ~ A scientific breakdown of the systems that sustain modern life.

35. **The Art of Self-Therapy** – *Nick Trenton* ~ Practical tools for self-guided psychological healing.

36. **The Nicomachean Ethics** – *Aristotle* ~ Foundational ideas on virtue, morality, and the good life.

37. **The World for Sale** – *Javier Blas & Jack Farchy* ~ How global commodity traders shape economies and politics.

38. **Confessions of an Economic Hitman** – *John Perkins* ~ A firsthand account of economic manipulation on a global scale.

39. **Chip War** – *Chris Miller* ~ The battle for semiconductor dominance and its geopolitical stakes.

40. **The Order of Time** – *Carlo Rovelli* ~ A poetic scientific exploration of time's nature.

41. **Cloud Money** – *Brett Scott* ~ How cashless payments are reshaping money and power.

42. **Cobalt Red** – *Siddharth Kara* ~ The human cost of cobalt mining in the tech industry.

Bonus list *(Books I have not read yet and I am planning to in the next 12 months)*

1. **The Medium is the Message** – *Marshall McLuhan* ~ Explores how the form of a medium influences the message it delivers and shapes society.

2. **Amusing Ourselves to Death** – *Neil Postman* ~ A critique of how entertainment-driven media erodes public discourse.

3. **Ways of Seeing** – *John Berger* ~ An exploration of how visual culture shapes perception and meaning.

4. **The Brothers Karamazov** – *Fyodor Dostoevsky* ~ A profound novel on faith, morality, and the complexities of human nature.

5. **The Act of Creation** – *Arthur Koestler* ~ Analyzes the creative process across art, science, and humor.

6. **Gödel, Escher, Bach: An Eternal Golden Braid** – *Douglas Hofstadter* ~ A mind-expanding study of patterns, consciousness, and self-reference.

7. **Truffaut/Hitchcock** – *François Truffaut* ~ A deep dive into Alfred Hitchcock's creative process through candid interviews.

8. **The Filmmaker's Eye** – *Gustavo Mercado* ~ A visual guide to cinematic composition and storytelling.

9. **No Longer Human** – *Osamu Dazai* ~ A haunting portrayal of alienation and identity loss.

10. **Butcher's Crossing** – *John Williams* ~ A novel about obsession, nature, and the human cost of ambition.

11. **Writing to Learn** – *William Zinsser* ~ Shows how writing can deepen understanding of any subject.

12. **On Writing Well** – *William Zinsser* ~ A timeless guide to clear, engaging nonfiction writing.

These are the books that I wish someone had told me when I was 18, ***This is what you need to know.*** They discuss most of the concepts & ideas I have mentioned in this book, but in way more detail. Consider this list as a starting point, not as a list of tasks to complete and then life will be great automatically. These books will expand your mind and give you different perspectives. That's the beauty of books in general. We read one and it opens up new worlds for us to explore.

Enjoy.

If you wish to get in touch with me feel free to do so:

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